False Deliverer

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by Lunaeryi

Summary

Kephale’s constellation has mysteriously lit up, and one by one, the constellations of the remaining Titans follow suit, leaving the Heirs in confusion and unrest, with no answers to be found.

Mydei, tormented by strange and disturbing dreams, is desperate to understand the unfolding chaos. Meanwhile, Phainon, always present and unnervingly calm, draws closer, offering reassurance that teeters on the edge of reverence.

In a world spiraling out of control, at least Mydei has Phainon to lean on, right?

Notes

Yall I don’t write Mydei centric since I suck ass at getting the words I want to paper, so this is my attempt at it and attempt at horror.

Not beta read so please point out any mistakes u see😭

PS: Do you guys prefer if I double space everything so the paragraphs aren’t as squished together or do u want just one space like it is mostly right now?

See the end of the work for more notes

Devouring the Self

The sun sank behind the stone walls of Okhema, its final rays casting the city in a warm, golden glow. Mydei paused just beyond the gates, taking in the familiar sights of the bustling square. Merchants packed up their stalls for the evening, their voices blending with the clang of hammers from distant forges and the faint laughter of children. It was the same as always—life in motion, a fragile rhythm in a world teetering on the edge of chaos.

He exhaled slowly, letting the cool air fill his lungs. The mission had been successful. He'd spoken to those scattered villages, the ones closest to the black tide, and convinced them to seek refuge in Okhema. It wasn't easy—not for him. Mydei had a soldier's pride and a prince's bearing, traits that earned respect on the battlefield but offered little comfort to frightened priests. That was Phainon's strength, not his. Phainon could charm anyone with that easy smile, the way he always knew just what to say to make others feel safe.

But this time, it had been Mydei's task. He had taken the reins, and while he had done what was necessary, there was no denying the strain. The weight of expectation was something he bore in silence, even as the whispers of his past followed him wherever he went.

The people of Okhema had accepted him, but not without reservation. He could feel it now as he moved through the square, the subtle shift in the air when he passed—a tension, like the faintest crack in an otherwise smooth surface. Mydei ignored it, as he always did. Their doubts didn't matter. What mattered was their safety, the walls of Okhema shielding them from the black tide creeping closer every day.

His boots clicked softly against the stone as he entered the central hall, the familiar warmth of the space easing the stiffness in his shoulders. But the moment he stepped inside, Mydei stilled.

Aglaea was there.

She stood near the center of the room, her golden threads shimmering faintly in the dim light. They flowed around her like liquid light, tracing invisible patterns in the air. Mydei couldn't see their purpose—only Aglaea truly understood the web she wove—but he could feel their weight. The threads seemed to hum with life, carrying a knowledge far beyond his grasp.

Though her gaze was turned toward the window, Mydei knew she couldn't see the city beyond it. Her blindness had never hindered her, not when the threads revealed all she needed to know. There was an otherworldly quality to her presence, an unshakable stillness that made it impossible to forget she was more than human.

"Aglaea," he said, his voice steady but quieter than usual. He inclined his head slightly, a gesture of respect.

"You've returned." Her voice was soft, yet it carried a weight that filled the space between them. The golden threads shifted, twisting and curling as if they were listening. "And you've done what was asked of you."

"Yes." He approached, keeping his movements slow and deliberate. "The villagers will arrive within the week. They'll be safe here."

Aglaea tilted her head slightly, her threads weaving tighter around her like a cocoon. "Safe for now." She turned to face him fully, though her unseeing eyes didn't meet his. "The tide presses closer every day. We cannot afford delays."

Mydei nodded, though her words lingered like a shadow over his thoughts. Aglaea had always been singular in her focus, her devotion to the mission unwavering. She spoke in absolutes, her blind eyes fixed on a vision only she could see.

"There's something else," she continued, her voice dropping to a near whisper. "The threads tell me… there is a fracture. A shift."

"A fracture?" Mydei frowned, his mind already racing through the possibilities. "Do you know what it is?"

Her threads shimmered, their glow intensifying for a moment before dimming again. “Not yet. But it draws closer. You’ll feel it soon enough.”

The way she said it—calm, certain—made the hairs on the back of Mydei’s neck stand on end. He straightened, his expression hardening into the stoic mask he wore so well. “Whatever it is, we’ll face it. Like we always do.”

Aglaea’s lips curved into the faintest of smiles, though it held no warmth. “I hope you’re right, Mydei. For all our sakes.”

She turned back toward the window, her golden threads swirling around her in slow, deliberate patterns. Mydei lingered for a moment, watching her. There was something unsettling about her words, the way they seemed to settle in his chest like a stone. But he pushed the feeling aside. There was no use in dwelling on what couldn’t yet be understood.

For now, the mission was complete. That was enough.

Or so he told himself.

The sun sank behind the stone walls of Okhema, its final rays casting the city in a warm, golden glow. Mydei stood at the edge of the highest rooftop, his gaze steady as he surveyed the sprawling city below. The rooftops, the narrow streets, and the distant horizon—all of it was part of the world he had come to protect.

For a long moment, he simply stood there, taking in the familiar sights, allowing himself a rare moment of quiet. The mission had been successful. He had spoken to those people, convinced them to seek refuge in Okhema, and, in doing so, kept them safe from the black tide that threatened their existence. It hadn’t been easy, but it was necessary. Still, Mydei couldn’t shake the weight of the task. There was something in the quiet moments between each mission that always seemed to linger longer than it should.

Okhema, despite the steady pace of life, had its own quiet tensions, most of them swirling around him. He was the former prince of Kremnos, after all, and even now there were people in the city who couldn’t completely shake

the rumors of his past—of betrayal, of a kingdom lost. The murmurs had faded over time, but the shadow remained, hovering just out of reach.

But Mydei didn't focus on the whispers. He had made a choice to be here. To serve Okhema and protect the people who had given him a second chance. And that was enough for him.

He took a slow, steady breath, the evening air cool on his skin. Okhema had come to feel like home, but there was a certain weight to it—the constant hum of movement, of people depending on the Heirs, on him. He couldn't help but feel the burden of that weight on his shoulders, even now.

A noise from behind him broke his thoughts. Soft footsteps on the stone rooftop. Mydei didn't have to turn to know who it was. He'd been expecting Phainon. The man's presence had always been a constant, even in moments like this, when everything else around him was still.

Phainon didn't speak at first, simply standing a few feet away, letting the quiet settle between them. The evening's calmness seemed to wash over them both, the city still below, alive but distant.

"I thought I might find you up here," Phainon said at last, his voice quiet but warm. It was a typical greeting, but the way he spoke it held something else—something unspoken. Phainon always had that way of making his presence known, not just through words, but through his very being.

Mydei glanced at him over his shoulder, offering a small nod. "It's peaceful here," he said simply, his tone measured, avoiding anything more. The words felt familiar, but not too heavy. He wasn't sure how to explain it, but Phainon's presence often felt like an anchor, a grounding force in the ever-shifting world they moved through.

Phainon took a step closer, his gaze drifting out toward the horizon. He didn't press Mydei, didn't ask too many questions. That was how Phainon always was—observing, understanding, and giving space when needed. It was one of the things that made him so easy to be around.

For a while, neither of them spoke. Mydei's thoughts wandered, but he kept them guarded. It wasn't as though he was uncomfortable with Phainon's company—it was more that sometimes, in these moments of stillness, the weight of everything else came crashing down.

Finally, Phainon broke the silence. "You did well out there," he said quietly, his voice steady. "The new recruits will be safe here."

Mydei offered a small, almost imperceptible rare smile, though it didn't quite reach his eyes. "They'll be safe, yes," he agreed, his voice neutral. "It's all we can do, really."

Phainon looked over at him, and for a moment, Mydei caught the faintest glimmer of something in his expression—something soft, but it was gone before Mydei could fully understand it.

"I'm glad you're back," Phainon said, his words simple, but there was a sincerity in them that Mydei felt more deeply than he let on.

Mydei nodded, his smile faltering for a second. "It was necessary," he said, the weight of those words hanging in the air between them. "But we can't stop now."

The silence between them stretched again, but this time it felt comfortable —neither of them needing to speak. They both understood the weight of their roles, of the unspoken responsibility that came with being part of the Heirs. There was no need for further words, not in this moment.

"Deliverer," Mydei said after a moment, his tone quieter, lacking the biting edge it usually has. "you've been distant lately."

Phainon's gaze flickered for a moment, but his expression remained calm. "I'm fine, Mydei. Just… thinking."

There was something in his words that didn't quite match the calmness of his demeanor. Mydei caught it, but he chose not to press further. Not yet. If Phainon wanted to talk, he would. If not, Mydei could wait.

“I’m here if you need me,” Mydei said simply, his voice calm and steady as ever. “You know that.”

Phainon offered a small, genuine smile, his eyes meeting Mydei’s. “I know.”

And with that, the two of them stood side by side, the city of Okhema stretching out before them, its life continuing undisturbed beneath their feet. The weight of their thoughts hung heavy, but neither spoke of it—at least, not yet.

Mydei stepped away from the edge of the rooftop, his fingers trailing along the stone railing. The city sprawled below him, familiar and constant, its quiet hum settling into his bones. As he descended from the rooftop, the weight of the mission he had completed felt both lighter and heavier in equal measure. The recruits were safe for now, their journey toward Okhema secured. He had done his duty, and yet, a strange feeling lingered in the back of his mind, something unnameable but pressing.

His thoughts wandered back to the day’s events—the quiet faces of the villagers he had met, those who still hesitated at the gates of Okhema. He knew why. Kremnos was his past, a past he couldn’t escape. The name still haunted him, despite all he had done. He wasn’t blind to the way the people of Okhema watched him, the way their voices hushed when he passed. There were those who respected him, yes, but there were always whispers, always the sting of doubt that clung to him like a second skin.

Yet despite all that, Mydei couldn’t bring himself to care. Not in the way they thought. He wasn’t here for their acceptance. He had his purpose now, and that was enough. He had learned long ago that there was no use in chasing approval that would never come. The people of Okhema needed protection, and that was what he could give them. What he had chosen to give them.

He made his way through the quiet streets, taking in the familiar sights—the soft glow of lamps lighting the paths, the distant clang of the blacksmith’s hammer, the lull of voices as people finished their day’s work. Okhema was thriving, despite everything. Despite the black tide, despite the constant

strain of their mission. There was a kind of life here, something that felt worth fighting for.

As he walked through the city, Mydei could feel the weight of the day's success slowly ebbing away. There was always more to be done, but for now, the quiet was a comfort. He paused in the square, watching as the last of the market vendors packed up their goods. It was a simple scene, but it reminded him of why he had come to Okhema in the first place. To protect this. To protect the simple moments, the ones that held everything together.

He leaned against the stone wall of one of the buildings, his arms folded across his chest, the quiet of the city settling around him. For a brief moment, Mydei allowed himself to relax, to just be here. His thoughts lingered on the faces of the new recruits, the lives he had just saved. He could see them in his mind—nervous, uncertain, but ultimately grateful.

A sound behind him broke the calm, and Mydei straightened. His gaze flickered over his shoulder, but there was no tension in his posture. The footsteps were too soft to belong to anyone else.

It was Phainon again, he'd followed him. Mydei didn't turn around at first, letting Phainon approach without interruption. He was used to the quiet comfort of their shared silences. Phainon stood by him now, a slight distance away, but still close enough that Mydei could feel the subtle shift in the air when he was near.

"Is everything alright?" Phainon asked, his voice steady and calm, as it always was.

Mydei nodded, not bothering to explain further. "It's fine. I was just thinking."

Phainon's gaze softened, though he didn't press. "It's good to think. Sometimes it's the only way to clear your head."

Mydei met his eyes for a moment, his gaze steady. Phainon's presence was always reassuring, his quiet confidence a balm to Mydei's more turbulent

thoughts. The city was safe for now, and despite everything, Mydei was certain of his place here. There was no doubt in him, not now. Not anymore.

“I’ll join the others soon,” Mydei said, pushing himself off the stone wall, his posture shifting back into his usual resolute stance. “But for now, this moment is enough.”

Phainon didn’t respond at first, but Mydei could feel the unspoken understanding between them. They both knew the weight of their responsibilities, the endless mission they carried. It would never stop, not until the black tide was gone, and Okhema was safe. But even now, in these quiet moments, Mydei found a kind of peace.

After a few beats of silence, Phainon nodded, his gaze moving to the horizon. “I’ll walk with you,” he said softly, as if that were all that was needed.

And so, they walked side by side through the streets of Okhema, the city’s steady hum surrounding them. There was no urgency in their steps, no need for words. The city was safe, for now. That was enough.

As Mydei and Phainon continued their quiet walk, the air shifted once again. It wasn’t the normal pulse of the city, but something deeper—something that made the hairs on the back of Mydei’s neck stand up. He could feel the pull, the growing sense of purpose that had always guided him. Phainon, sensing the change, stopped and turned toward him, his expression unreadable.

“Time to go,” Phainon said, his voice steady. “They’re waiting for us.”

And just like that, the moment of normalcy slipped away, replaced by a heavy weight. “Lets go.” Mydei murmured, walking past Phainon.

The Vortex of Genesis had grown quieter as more of the Heirs arrived. Mydei stood slightly apart from the group, watching the steady weaving of Aglaea’s golden threads and the quiet, confident presence of Tribbie. There was an unspoken understanding among them all—though they hadn’t yet spoken of it, everyone could feel the shift in the air.

Castorice was there too, standing in her usual quiet manner, her presence somehow both unsettling and reassuring in its stillness. Mydei had always known she embodied death itself, and though he, as an immortal, would never experience it the way others did, there was something about Castorice that reminded him of the children from Kremnos—the ones who had lived despite the harshness of their world.

It wasn't the fear of death that Mydei felt around her, but the deep understanding of loss. Death wasn't a stranger to him—it was something he had witnessed firsthand in countless battles, in the fall of his kingdom, in the lives lost every day to the black tide. But with Castorice, it was different. There was no fear in her, only an unwavering, quiet reverence for what had to be. The way she kept her distance from him, though she never meant to isolate him, felt like a silent respect for the lives they had lived.

As the others spoke in hushed tones, Castorice approached Mydei, her presence as soft as the whisper of a breeze. She didn't say anything at first, simply standing a few feet away, as if waiting for the right moment. Mydei turned slightly, acknowledging her without words.

"Sir Mydei," Castorice's voice was soft, but there was no hesitation in her words. She spoke with the same respect she gave everyone. "You've been quiet today."

Mydei met her gaze, his eyes searching hers. Though her blindfold obscured her vision, there was something in her posture that suggested a deeper awareness, an understanding that didn't need sight to perceive. She knew.

"I've been thinking," he replied slowly, his voice steady but more reflective than usual. "About what we're facing. The news we're about to get, it's bound to be unsettling."

Castorice nodded, though her face remained unreadable, as it always did. "The threads are tangled. Too many strands are pulling in different directions. But we will face it together, as we always have."

There was an odd comfort in her words, simple as they were. Mydei could feel the quiet reassurance in her presence. It wasn't just her words—it was the calm certainty with which she spoke them. Even if death was her domain, Castorice seemed more at peace with it than anyone else in the room.

He exhaled slowly, letting her words sink in. "I know," he said softly. "But sometimes… it's hard to see what's ahead."

The corners of Castorice's lips quirked upward ever so slightly, as if understanding his sentiment. "None of us can see it, Sir Mydei. But we will face it. You are not alone."

He nodded slowly, his voice quieter now. "Thank you, Castorice."

She offered him a nod, her head tilting slightly as if acknowledging his words without the need for further explanation. "It is nothing, Sir Mydei."

And with that, she stepped back, keeping her respectful distance once more, as was her way. Mydei watched her go, the quiet weight of her presence lingering in the air. For all her power, for all the mystery she held, there was something human about her. It was a reminder that even in the face of death, one could find peace, even if it was just for a moment.

The silence that followed was almost suffocating as Aglaea and Tribbie stepped forward. The golden threads that flowed from Aglaea's fingertips seemed to hum, the air thick with tension as the news was about to be delivered. Tribbie's gaze swept over the room, sharp and calculated, her focus unwavering.

"We've been waiting," she said, her voice low but firm. "It's time."

Mydei's chest tightened, his heart beating faster with the weight of the words they were about to speak. The unease that had settled in his stomach only deepened.

"The constellation of Kephale has been lit," Aglaea's voice echoed, the finality of her words striking him like a thunderclap. "The Titan of Creation

is no more. His flame has been taken."

A wave of shock rippled through the group, but Mydei stood still, his gaze unwavering. The room fell into a stunned silence. Kephale—the God of Creation—had fallen. The implications were far-reaching, and yet, all Mydei could think about was the question that hung in the air:

Who had done it?

The air in the Vortex of Genesis had grown thick with tension after the announcement of Kephale's fall. The Heirs stood in uneasy silence, their minds racing with the implications. Kephale had been one of the ancient Titans, a force of creation itself, and the idea that someone had defeated him was unsettling enough. But the fact that they had no idea who had done it—or worse, why—was more than troubling.

Phainon stood at the edge of the group, his usual composure masking the thoughts swirling in his mind. The Heirs exchanged quiet words, some speaking in hushed tones while others stood still, lost in thought. They all knew that whoever had done this had to have been close to them, someone who knew their identities, their weaknesses, yet chose not to join their cause. The thought gnawed at Mydei's chest as he stood in the center of the group, feeling the weight of the unknown pressing on him.

Trianne spoke first, her voice sharp but tinged with doubt. "Whoever did this, they knew us. They knew what we were fighting for. Kephale's fall—it's no accident."

Trinnon, usually silent but ever vigilant, nodded grimly. "Someone wanted to destroy what we've built. It doesn't make sense. Why would they choose to take down a Titan, and yet refuse to join us? It's… deliberate."

Tribbie's eyes narrowed, her arms crossed as she scanned the room. "It doesn't feel right. Whoever did this is playing a game. They know who we are. They know what we're trying to protect, and yet they chose to destroy Kephale. The Titan of Creation—gone, just like that. But why?"

Aglaea remained silent for a moment, her golden threads flickering around her as if listening to the whispers in the room. Finally, she spoke, her voice low and calm. “The threads tell me nothing, only that the balance is shifting. This is not just a victory, but a disruption. Whoever has taken Kephale’s flame… they’re a threat we don’t fully understand yet.”

Mydei couldn’t help but feel the weight of her words. It was clear now—this wasn’t just about victory. It was about someone making a statement. Someone had taken Kephale’s flame, but the reasons behind it were still shrouded in mystery. Whoever had done it was out there, and they were coming for them.

“Mydei?” Phainon’s voice broke through his thoughts. “Are you all right?”

Mydei’s gaze snapped to Phainon, his features hardening for a moment. “I’m fine,” he muttered, but the edge in his voice was unmistakable. He knew Phainon’s presence was meant to offer comfort, but in that moment, it felt like an intrusion. The weight of the situation was heavy enough without having to explain himself.

Phainon’s eyes softened, though he remained silent. He seemed to sense the growing tension in Mydei, but said nothing, waiting for him to speak, to act, to lead. As the Heirs continued to discuss their options, Mydei found himself withdrawing, his thoughts turning inward.

He didn’t respond, he needed time to think alone. That’s right—The bath houses.

Mydei’s footsteps echoed softly on the stone floor as he made his way to the private bathhouse. The hallways were quiet, a welcome silence after the clamor of the Vortex. His mind churned with thoughts, a growing sense of unease gnawing at him. The news of Kephale’s fall still lingered in his mind, but there was something else—something that had been building steadily over the past few days.

He didn’t like it. He didn’t like it at all. The tension in the air was thick enough to slice through, and the uncertainty was eating away at him. The very fact that one of their own had defeated a Titan—someone who knew

them, yet chose to remain outside their ranks—bothered him. It should've been straightforward, but it wasn't. He couldn't shake the feeling that the world was about to tip, and none of them were prepared for it.

Pushing open the door to the bathhouse, he let out a quiet breath, the warm air soothing the tightness in his shoulders. The steam rising from the water felt like a brief escape, a chance to center himself, even if only for a moment.

But as he stepped in, his gaze snapped to the door. There, standing in the shadows, was Phainon. How did he even get here so fast? He could've sworn Phainon had been behind him a moment ago.

Phainon's calm demeanor unsettled him. He wasn't surprised to see him, but the fact that Phainon was just standing there—silent, watching, unnervingly still—didn't sit right with Mydei. His posture was unnaturally relaxed, too controlled, like he didn't have a care in the world. The slight tilt of his head, the almost serene expression—there was something about it that felt off.

"What the hell are you doing here?" Mydei said, his tone sharp and biting as he crossed his arms, a flicker of annoyance rising in his chest. "You know, for someone who acts like he's too busy to help, you sure spend a lot of time lurking around, don't you?"

Phainon didn't flinch. In fact, he seemed almost… pleased. A faint smile tugged at his lips, though it was subtle, more like a quiet amusement.

"I thought you might need company," Phainon replied, his voice unnervingly calm. Too calm.

Mydei raised an eyebrow, the unease in his gut growing. "Company?" he repeated, taking a step closer. "You've got to be joking. You're the last person I'd want company from. You're way too—"

He trailed off, his words hanging in the air as he finally let himself get a better look at Phainon. The way Phainon's eyes didn't leave him, the almost reverent focus he had—it was strange. Too focused. Mydei frowned,

pushing the feeling of discomfort aside. This wasn't like Phainon. He was always composed, sure, but this was something different.

"You're… unnervingly calm," Mydei finally said, his voice laced with disbelief.

Phainon's smile widened slightly, though there was an odd tenderness in it, an intensity that felt too much. "I'm just here to keep you company, Mydei. If that's alright with you." His words were soft, but they carried a weight that Mydei couldn't quite place.

Mydei's eyes narrowed, something in his chest tightening at the casualness with which Phainon spoke. "You're weird," he spat, a hint of derision in his voice. "You never act like this. Did you hit your head, Deliverer ?"

Phainon didn't respond to the mockery, his gaze fixed on Mydei with an unsettling intensity. "You're always so tense," Phainon said, taking a step closer, his voice still too calm, too smooth. "I thought you'd enjoy a little company. You deserve it."

Mydei instinctively took a step back, his body bristling with unease. "What the hell is going on with you?" he asked, his voice harder now, tinged with a sharp edge. "You're not acting like yourself. What's the game?"

Phainon's smile didn't falter, but his presence seemed to grow more imposing, the air around him thick with something Mydei couldn't quite understand. It wasn't anger. It wasn't even annoyance. It was something darker, more… unsettling.

"No game," Phainon replied softly, his voice dropping to almost a whisper. "Just… a little bit of peace. Don't you want that, Mydei? To just be… understood?"

Mydei stared at him, unable to shake the feeling that Phainon was getting too close. This wasn't right. Phainon had never been this forward. They were allies, yes, and rivals, but this… this was different.

“You’re getting way too close for comfort,” Mydei said sharply, his patience thinning. “If you’re looking for something, you’re wasting your time.”

Phainon’s smile remained, but now there was something in his eyes—something that sent a cold shiver down Mydei’s spine. “I’m not looking for anything, Mydei,” he murmured, his voice low and almost reverent. “I’m just here… for you.”

Before Mydei could respond, the door creaked open slightly, and Phainon stepped forward again, the distance between them closing faster than Mydei was prepared for. Phainon’s presence was suffocating now, too close, too intense.

“I’m always here,” Phainon said, his voice soft and steady, yet carrying an unnerving edge. “I won’t leave you, Mydei. You can’t push me away.”

Mydei felt his heartbeat quicken, his instincts screaming at him to step back. But he held his ground, eyes narrowing. “What’s wrong with you, you damn bastard?”

But Phainon didn’t even flinch. His gaze softened, the hint of something almost worshipful in his eyes, as he leaned closer still. “I’m not leaving. You’ll see.”

Mydei stepped back quickly, his heart pounding as he finally broke the tension. “Get out, Phainon,” he said, forgoing his title, his voice tight with anger and discomfort. “Just… leave me alone.”

Phainon’s expression flickered, but he didn’t push any further. With a final, lingering glance, he turned and left the bathhouse, the door swinging shut behind him.

Mydei was left standing in the quiet, the strange feeling lingering in the air. He didn’t know what was happening, but something inside him told him this wasn’t over. Whatever was growing between them, whatever strange pull had settled into the air between him and Phainon, was far from normal. And he wasn’t sure if he could stop it.

he bathhouse was silent now, the only sound the soft ripple of water as Mydei sank deeper into the warmth, his muscles relaxing against the smooth stone. The heat was soothing, a stark contrast to the turmoil roiling inside him. He tried to focus on the simplicity of the moment—trying to silence the questions buzzing in his mind, trying to push aside the uneasy feeling that Phainon's presence had left behind. But no matter how hard he tried, it lingered, like a shadow creeping at the edge of his thoughts.

He let out a long, slow breath, the steam from the water swirling around him. The news of Kephale's fall still weighed heavily on him, but it was the uncertainty of who had done it, who had been close enough to take down a Titan, that kept gnawing at him. They knew nothing. Nothing about the person who had managed to defeat one of the greatest powers they had ever known.

And yet, that wasn't what had his mind tangled the most.

Phainon.

Why had he acted that way? Why had Phainon been so… different tonight? Mydei's fingers gripped the edge of the stone as he shifted uncomfortably. He hated feeling this way—off-balance, unsure of himself. He was used to the weight of being a leader, a soldier, someone with purpose. But Phainon? He made him feel like he was losing his footing. Phainon had always been unnervingly calm, but tonight it was something else. It was like a mask slipping into place, something colder, something more… possessive.

"Stop thinking about it," Mydei muttered under his breath, leaning back against the side of the bath, staring at the ceiling. He couldn't let Phainon get under his skin like this. He wouldn't. He'd made it this far without letting anyone in—why should Phainon be any different?

His fingers brushed the water's surface absently, the ripples distorting his reflection as though the world itself was unsettled, out of focus.

The silence of the bathhouse felt heavy. Too quiet. The only sounds were the distant murmurs of the city outside, but they felt far away now. Mydei

closed his eyes, leaning his head back further against the stone, trying to drown out the noise in his head.

He couldn’t focus. The discomfort, the tension, the growing weight of his own thoughts—they were suffocating him. He’d been on edge ever since returning from his mission. The responsibility, the doubts, the fear of what was coming—he couldn’t shake it.

And then, just as he thought he might be able to calm his mind, it happened.

A shift. A flicker of something dark behind his eyelids. Something familiar, and yet, deeply unsettling.

The moment the first vision hit, Mydei’s eyes snapped open, the dream creeping into his mind unbidden, dragging him from his moment of fragile calm. He sat up suddenly, his breath coming faster as the world around him began to warp.

It wasn’t like any dream he’d had before. It was vivid—too vivid—tangible, almost real.

The air was thick with the scent of decay, and the ground beneath Mydei’s boots was wet with something far too warm to be rain. His breath hitched as he glanced down at his hands—blood, slick and dark, coated his skin. The sight made his stomach churn, but there was no time to think about it. There was something in the distance. Someone.

Castorice.

She was standing just beyond him, her form distorted by the fog that seemed to rise from the earth itself, thick and cloying. Mydei’s heart pounded in his chest, his breath coming too fast as he took a step toward her. She stood motionless, her body rigid, but there was something off about her. Something wrong.

“Castorice?” Mydei’s voice was strained, echoing strangely in the dense fog. “What are you—”

Before he could finish, Castorice collapsed to her knees. Mydei rushed forward, but the sight made him freeze in place. Her mouth was open in a silent scream, though no sound came out. Her hands were pressed to her chest, and as she pulled them away, blood poured freely from a gaping wound. But it wasn't just any wound—it was as if something had torn through her from the inside out, a jagged tear that bled not just from her body, but from her very soul.

Mydei's heart lurched. His legs felt weak, like they wouldn't hold him up. He stepped forward, but the closer he got, the more the world seemed to warp, the ground beneath him becoming slick with the blood that pooled around her.

"Castorice, no—" He tried to reach out to her, but as his hands hovered above her, something inside him twisted. He couldn't bring himself to touch her. Something told him it was too late. That it had always been too late.

Castorice looked up at him, her eyes wide and empty, the light fading from her once-gentle gaze. "…" she whispered something he couldn't heart, a name, her voice hoarse, barely audible. "This is… your fault."

The words cut through him like a blade. He stepped back, gasping for breath, but the world around him seemed to close in. His chest tightened. His hands—his hands were covered in blood. He didn't know how, but they were. The blood, the gore, it was everywhere, staining him, making it impossible to breathe. Impossible to think.

But it wasn't just Castorice's blood. It was his too. And in that moment, he realized what was happening.

Castorice's body had begun to twitch violently, her fingers clawing at the blood-soaked earth as she convulsed. But there was something more. Something horrifyingly wrong. The gaping wound on her chest seemed to pulse, as though it were alive, as though it were feeding.

Mydei's throat went dry as he watched the wound gape wider, the flesh tearing open further, and then—then something dark and twisted crawled out from within her.

It was her heart.

Her still-beating heart.

It tore free from her chest, and Mydei felt a sickening pang of recognition. The symbolism. The cruel mockery of it all. Her heart—her core, the thing that gave her life, that symbolized her essence—was now spilling onto the ground, the last remnants of her vitality bleeding out onto the earth.

Castorice's face twisted in agony, her mouth opening in a silent scream. And then, impossibly, her body—her mutilated body—started to twitch again. She was reaching for the heart, though it was no longer hers to claim.

Mydei's stomach turned as he watched her grab the heart with her trembling hands, and then, against everything that was holy, she began to eat it.

The blood splattered onto her face, coating her lips as she consumed the very thing that had once kept her alive. But it wasn't just her heart—her core—it was the entirety of her. Mydei could see the way her body seemed to decay as she ate it, her form shrinking and wilting as she took another bite, her fingers shaking with desperation.

"Castorice, stop! Stop it!" Mydei practically screamed, though his words felt empty, useless. He couldn't stop her. He couldn't stop any of this.

And then, it hit him. It wasn't just Castorice's death that he had witnessed. No. It was something far darker. Far worse. He was watching her self-destruct. He was watching her become the very thing she had sworn to fight against. And as she ate, the last remnants of her vitality were absorbed, consumed, until nothing was left. No soul. No life.

Just a hollow shell.

And Mydei? He was helpless. He was complicit.

The nightmare twisted and turned, the blood-soaked earth stretching as the vision of Castorice's demise consumed him. His hands were covered in

blood, just as hers had been. The more he reached out to stop it, the more it felt like it was pulling him in. The taste of guilt, bitter and sharp, clung to his tongue as he finally gave in and sank to his knees, the weight of the dream settling on him like a suffocating fog.

Mydei awoke with a jolt—had he fallen asleep?—his breath ragged as he sat up in the bath, the remnants of the dream clinging to him like a heavy fog. His heart was pounding, and for a moment, he couldn't tell if he was still in the dream or if he had truly woken up. His hands were slick with sweat, his body tense, but there was no blood. No gore.

It hadn't been real. It couldn't have been.

But as the images of Castorice's agony flooded his mind again, he couldn't shake the feeling that something about the dream had felt too vivid, too tangible. He wiped the sweat from his brow, his pulse racing, but the weight of the vision clung to him stubbornly. Castorice… eating her own heart… he could still hear the sound of it, the sickening crunch echoing in his ears.

Shaking his head, Mydei tried to push the thoughts away, his hands still trembling slightly as he stood and stumbled out of the bath. It was just a dream. It had to be. But there was a sinking feeling in his chest that wouldn't go away.

He glanced at his hands, expecting to see blood—some sign of the nightmare's reality—but there was nothing. Just the cold, clammy feeling of sweat.

The disorienting sensation remained, though. He didn't know if it was the dream still hanging over him or the growing unease gnawing at the edges of his mind. The feeling of helplessness, the weight of his actions, threatened to consume him.

But he couldn't afford to dwell on it—not now. He had more pressing matters. The Heirs were depending on him. Okhema was depending on him. He couldn't afford to be weak.

As he exited the bathhouse, he took a deep breath, forcing himself to shake off the remnants of the dream. It wasn't real. But something inside him told him it would be soon enough.

It had been days since the Vortex of Genesis, days since they had learned of Kephale's fall, and Mydei had yet to close his eyes for longer than a few fleeting moments. His body ached with exhaustion, but his mind refused him the solace of rest. Every time he closed his eyes, he saw fragments of dreams he didn't understand—visions of blood, broken constellations, and faces he couldn't save.

The others had begun to notice his weariness, though no one dared speak of it aloud. Even Phainon, who was always watching, had held his tongue—though the unnerving calm in his eyes only served to keep Mydei on edge.

He threw himself into work, overseeing the defenses of Okhema, ensuring that every citizen was accounted for, every vulnerable point reinforced. The black tide loomed ever closer, but it wasn't the only shadow he felt creeping toward them.

And yet, despite all his efforts, the whispers lingered. The rumors of who had defeated Kephale and claimed their coreflame haunted the Heirs. Whoever it was, they knew enough to have targeted a founding Titan—and yet, they had not come forward. The unease it left in its wake was palpable, a tension none of them could shake.

The Vortex of Genesis had been unusually silent since the meeting about Kephale's fall, and the unease in the air seemed to linger longer than it should have. The Heirs were gathered once more, faces weary, minds preoccupied with the disturbing news of the past few weeks.

But now, there was something new—something that shook them all to their core.

"Thanatos's constellation is lit," Aglaea announced, her voice somber but steady.

Mydei froze. Thanatos—the Titan of Death. His mind immediately scrambled to make sense of it. It hadn't been long since Kephale's constellation had been lit. Was this even possible? How could one of the greatest Titans fall so quickly after another? It was unheard of. Unprecedented.

"What?" Anaxa poke up, his usual calm replaced by shock. "But how? I thought… I thought Castorice was meant to claim his coreflame."

Mydei's eyes flickered to Castorice, who stood there, motionless. Her usual serene composure had been replaced with an unsettling stillness.

She didn't speak at first. Her golden threads, which Aglaea controlled with grace and precision, shimmered nervously around her, but Castorice's own quiet energy seemed uncertain. "I was supposed to," she muttered, almost to herself, her words laced with confusion. "But… it wasn't me. It shouldn't be me. I was the one who was meant to face him. The others… They couldn't—"

Mydei's mind reeled. Castorice had always been the one to represent Death. She had the coreflame of Thanatos, and the expectation was that she would be the one to defeat him. But this?

"How…?" Mydei began, but his words faltered. It didn't make sense. He turned to Phainon, hoping the calm presence of his fellow Heir might offer something resembling clarity.

Phainon, as always, was impossibly composed. He observed the Heirs quietly, his gaze settling on Mydei with an unreadable expression. Then, his lips parted, a faint smile curving his mouth. "I suppose we'll find out soon enough. Whoever did this—well, they were quick. Not a surprise with the way things have been going."

There it was again. That unsettling calm. It should have been reassuring. After all, Phainon for once steady and composed in the face of chaos. But today, his presence felt more like a warning, he was too calm for the gravity of the situation.

Mydei's unease grew, but he masked it with a careful expression. "You're right," he replied, though his voice betrayed a slight edge of doubt. "But… why so quickly? Kephale's fall was unexpected, but this is… unheard of."

Phainon nodded, stepping closer to Mydei, his smile gentle but filled with something unreadable. "There's no sense in trying to make sense of things we can't control. Whoever did this is already long gone. And now, we have to focus on what comes next. Whatever's happening… it's bigger than us. But we'll find our footing."

Mydei nodded slowly, though his mind continued to spin. Something was wrong. The quickness of this—how the Titans were falling, one after another—it was too much. Phainon's reassurances were meant to steady him, but instead, they only deepened his suspicion.

But the Heirs were already starting to move forward. Despite their confusion, they began making plans. Okhema needed protection, and they had no time to question every anomaly. There would be time for answers later.

As the others filtered out of the room, Mydei lingered for a moment. He couldn't help it. His thoughts were too loud, too frantic to ignore.

Phainon, noticing Mydei's lingering hesitation, placed a hand on his shoulder—softly, almost gently. "I know you're unsettled, Mydei. We all are. But let's face it together. I've got your back."

Mydei's heart skipped a beat at the touch, but he forced himself to keep his gaze steady. He didn't want to show Phainon how his words had affected him. How they always did.

"You always do," Mydei replied reluctantly, though there was a strange edge to his words now. "…Thank you."

Phainon gave a knowing smile, though it wasn't as unnerving as it usually was. There was something almost comforting about the way he stood there, still as a rock amidst a storm. "Anytime, Mydei."

As Phainon walked away, Mydei felt a strange weight settle in his chest. It wasn’t quite the comfort he had hoped for. It wasn’t quite what it seemed, but for the moment, he allowed himself to believe it was.

he following days felt longer than they should have. The uneasy news of Thanatos’s constellation had sent ripples through Okhema, and the uncertainty hung in the air like a storm waiting to break. The Heirs carried on, though, each of them retreating into their duties to try to maintain the delicate balance of their world.

Mydei walked through the halls of Okhema, his mind heavy with the recent revelations. He hadn’t been able to shake the conversation he’d had with Phainon. There had been something about his words that unsettled him more than usual. *Always have your back* . The phrase echoed in his mind, a reminder of—

No, Mydei thought to himself, pushing the thought aside. *Focus on what you can control. The city. The people.*

He turned the corner of the Vortex of Genesis, his footsteps silent on the stone floor, and his thoughts turned back to the latest issue: Thanatos’s fall.

It didn’t add up. How could Castorice—who was meant to face Thanatos—have been left out? The Titan of Death was her legacy, her destiny. The more Mydei thought about it, the more questions arose. But there was little time to reflect. The city needed protection, and he couldn’t afford to waste energy on things he couldn’t answer.

But still, there was something gnawing at him. A sinking feeling.

And then, the next morning, they were greeted with the impossible news.

Castorice is dead.

The announcement spread like wildfire through the Heirs, and when Mydei heard the news, he couldn’t suppress the wave of dread that washed over him. The same dread that had haunted him when he had first learned of Thanatos’s constellation being lit.

But this wasn’t the same.

He hadn’t seen Castorice in hours, but there was something about the news that felt wrong.

“How?” he asked aloud, though the words came out like a whisper. “How could she be—”

he silence in the room was thick with disbelief. Aglaea, ever the calm presence, was the first to speak. “She was found at the edge of the city, near the boundary where the black tide encroaches. She was… torn apart. It was brutal, Mydei. She didn’t stand a chance.”

Mydei’s chest constricted. *Torn apart* —it sounded so familiar. A vision of another dream he’d had resurfaced—one he had right after Castorice’s—the image of his spear piercing Phainon, the whispers calling out to him, *urging him to take a piece* . And then the vision of Phainon’s heart, ripped out and placed on a plate in front of him, fresh blood still dripping from it.

The words echoed in his mind. *Won’t you take a piece, with your bigger teeth?*

He hadn’t understood it before, but now it was too real. The connection to what had happened to Castorice… the brutal, violent end that mirrored the chaos in his dreams. It felt like a sick joke. And the worst part was, Mydei didn’t know how to stop it.

“Who… who did this?” Mydei demanded, his voice a growl now, his mind racing. There was no answer to that, of course. No one could give him a straight answer. No one could tell him how Castorice had fallen, why she had been chosen.

His breath came faster, more shallow now. Mydei’s hands clenched at his sides. He wasn’t sure if it was fear or anger rising up inside him, but his heart pounded erratically in his chest. *Who did this? Why didn’t I stop it?*

Aglaea, sensing the shift in Mydei, stepped forward, her golden threads shifting around her as she addressed him, though her voice was soft.

“Mydei, please. We need to stay focused. We have to—”

“ *No*! ” Mydei snapped, the words sharp like a blade. “I can’t. I need to do something. I need to move. Get me out of here. Please.”

His voice wavered, and that was enough to break through the cold veneer he had kept for so long. Aglaea hesitated, her expression both sympathetic and concerned. She knew what he was asking—what he was begging for, even if he wasn’t fully aware of it himself.

“Mydei…” Her voice was gentle but firm. “You need to stay grounded. If you go out there now, you won’t come back the same.”

But Mydei wasn’t listening. He couldn’t. He felt like he was suffocating, like the walls were closing in. “I don’t care!” he shouted, his voice rising in desperation. “Get me a mission, anything. I need to leave. I need to get out of here.” He wasn’t usually like this, but this was an exception.

Aglaea sighed, knowing there was no reasoning with him. “Very well.” Her voice softened. “I’ll get something for you. But you have to promise me you’ll stay focused.”

Mydei didn’t answer.

It wasn’t long before Aglaea found a task for him—something small, but something to keep him occupied. Mydei took it without question, hardly registering the words. He moved like a machine, his body on autopilot as he tore through the assignment, eyes sharp with an edge that wasn’t entirely his own. He killed everything that stood in his path, his mind too far gone to stop.

Each strike was a little harsher, a little more reckless. His hands shook with rage, though not the fear he couldn’t bring himself to admit. It was anger. Anger that he couldn’t stop this. Anger that he couldn’t save her, that he hadn’t been able to do anything in time.

His sword cut through enemy forces with the precision of someone who had no intention of stopping. But as his hand clenched around the hilt, his

thoughts seemed to slip further and further into disarray. The shaking was too much to ignore.

Mydei's breath grew heavier, his vision blurring at the edges as he slashed through more bodies. *Focus. Just focus*. But the words didn't help. He wasn't fighting for victory. He was fighting to feel something—anything other than the pressure building up inside him.

It wasn't until he saw the last of the attackers fall that he realized his hand was trembling so violently it was difficult to keep a hold of the sword. His breath was uneven, and the world around him felt distant.

What was I doing?

He staggered back, trying to steady himself. The blood on his hands—on the blade—seemed to pulse with an unholy life of its own. It's just a coincidence, he told himself, but the words didn't stick. Nothing felt real anymore.

He was beyond exhaustion, but somehow, he found the strength to keep going. I can't stop. *I can't let myself fall apart. Not now.*

The words circled in his mind, and still, his legs carried him forward. Each step felt heavier than the last, but he refused to stop. Mydei had become used to the weight of the world on his shoulders, even when it felt unbearable. The violence of the day was a distant blur, but the pain in his chest—the deep, hollow ache that never seemed to go away—was real.

His breath was ragged, and his hand clutched the hilt of his sword as if it could anchor him. He needed something. Anything.

Why had he come out here, away from the others? He wasn't sure. Maybe it was the overwhelming sense of dread still settling in his chest, or maybe the need to be alone, to process everything that had just happened.

The blood from his previous kills was still drying on his hands, the stench of death clinging to him, suffocating. He could feel it weighing him down

as his boots scraped against the cobblestones of a forgotten courtyard, far from the bustle of Okhema's center.

Just focus, Mydei. Breathe.

His mind was fraying, but there was one thing he knew for certain: he couldn't afford to break. Not now. Not with everything that was happening.

And then it came—the unmistakable sensation of his heart *shifting* .

At first, it was just a pressure—tight, a small ache in his chest. But as the seconds passed, it escalated into something more. His heart began to pound painfully, his breath stuttering as a familiar yet unbearable sensation started to crawl under his skin.

The pressure grew, unbearable, until it felt like something was *tearing* inside him.

His body felt *wrong*.

He gasped, his hand flying to his chest as if he could somehow stop it, but the pain was overwhelming. It wasn't like a normal wound. This was something different, something worse. The agony surged, and for the briefest of moments, Mydei's vision swam with spots of red.

Not again, he thought grimly. *I can't keep doing* this.

The pressure in his chest intensified until it felt like his body was going to implode. Then, with a sickening crack , his chest erupted.

Blood spilled from his mouth, the thick, metallic liquid splattering across the stone floor beneath him. His hand went to his chest, but it was too late. A sharp, violent pain lanced through his body, and for a moment, everything seemed to explode in a cascade of agony.

He stumbled backward, clutching his chest, but the pain— *the rupture* — continued. His heart had shattered inside him. It wasn't just the blood spilling from his mouth; his body was rejecting itself, the very life force inside him breaking apart.

He collapsed, hitting the ground with a heavy thud, his body convulsing as the flood of blood continued. It wasn't the usual death he'd known. This was worse. His body was turning on itself, each heartbeat like a dagger.

But Mydei didn't panic. He never did. He was *immortal*. This wasn't new. He had died hundreds, thousands of times in ways far worse than this. Each death had been a lesson in endurance, each rebirth a reminder that no matter how brutal, he would always come back.

So, as the world around him bled to darkness, Mydei simply let it happen.

It was the price of living, after all. Death was nothing to him. Not anymore.

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When Mydei came to, the first thing he noticed was the stillness. The heavy, suffocating silence that surrounded him. Blood pooled around his body, staining the cold ground beneath him, but it was already beginning to feel less important.

I'm still alive, he thought, taking a shallow breath. *Of course, I am.*

The pain that had torn him apart just moments before had ebbed, though the tightness in his chest remained. His heart felt whole once more, but the sensation was wrong. It wasn't just physical—it was something deeper, a crack that wouldn't heal so easily.

His hand moved to his chest, and Mydei could feel it—a faint pulse beneath his skin. He was alive. But there was something off about the whole thing. The sensation of his own heart beating— *again* —was not a comfort.

Rising to his feet, Mydei staggered for a moment, his hands shaking as he wiped the blood from his lips. He felt the familiar weight of his body, the unyielding pull of immortality. But it felt… less steady this time. As though there was something different about how he came back.

His vision was clearer now. The blood that had spilled out of him had mostly dried, and yet his hands were still shaking with the aftermath of the violent death he'd suffered.

He wasn't sure why it had happened. Why this death had been so different, so violently disorienting. He had lived through worse, but this… *this* felt different.

His mind drifted back to the vision, to the nightmare where Castorice had been torn apart. The violent end— the *same* violent end that he'd seen so clearly in his dream.

Was this the cost of being near it? Near the unraveling of everything?

No answers came.

But it didn't matter. Mydei had never needed answers before. He had never needed them. He had always endured, always been able to survive the worst.

But this time, something gnawed at him. A nagging feeling that whatever was happening, whatever was unfolding, was not something he could simply fight off.

It was bigger than him. It was bigger than anything he could control.

And though he stood, seemingly whole once more, Mydei couldn't shake the feeling that something was coming for him—something that wouldn't stop until he had nothing left to give.

Mydei's steps were slow as he made his way back to Okhema, the weight of his last death pressing on him in a way that made his muscles ache with exhaustion. Though his body was still whole, his chest remained tight, an unseen pressure that was almost suffocating. He couldn't shake the feeling that something was deeply wrong, but he couldn't figure out what.

He had died. His heart had burst, blood spilled from his mouth, and yet here he was, walking. *But how*? The sensation of life, of returning, had been so

sharp, so intense, that it unsettled him. He had always known his immortality was a curse as much as a gift, but this… this felt different.

What am I becoming?

He pushed the thought aside. He didn't have the luxury of dwelling on it. There was too much at stake. Castorice was dead. The other Heirs were struggling to hold everything together, and with Kephale's constellation lit, and now Thanatos, the situation was more precarious than ever.

But the unease in his chest wouldn't leave. The feeling of being *fractured* lingered like a shadow over him.

When he finally reached the gates of Okhema, he could see the city stretching before him—silent, still, and waiting. A quiet sense of normalcy had returned, or at least it seemed that way. But Mydei knew better. Everything had changed.

And still, as much as he wanted to drown in his own confusion, he couldn't shake the nagging desire to find *something* —someone—to anchor him. Someone who could reassure him that everything wasn't falling apart.

It didn't take long before he found himself outside the familiar halls of Okhema, his hands brushing against the cool stone as he stepped inside. The dim lighting inside the building did little to ease the storm inside his mind. The world outside seemed so distant, as if nothing had happened.

But then, like always, there was Phainon.

Phainon had been waiting. Mydei wasn't sure how he knew that, but Phainon always seemed to sense when Mydei was about to arrive.

" *Deliverer* ," Mydei said, his voice a little more biting than usual as he spotted Phainon standing in the shadows near the hall. "Still here, I see."

Phainon didn't smile in the way Mydei expected. His face remained calm, neutral, but there was something about the way he looked at him that made Mydei's stomach flutter.

“You’ve returned,” Phainon said, his voice quieter than usual. There was no hint of mockery, no sharp edge, just an almost gentle undertone that Mydei didn’t know how to place. “I was waiting for you. After you ran off like that I got worried, everything alright?”

For a moment, Mydei hesitated. His lips parted as if to speak, but nothing came out. *Everything’s fine*, he wanted to say. But it wasn’t. And Phainon could probably see that.

“I’m… fine,” Mydei said finally, forcing the words out, but his voice trembled slightly. He cursed himself internally. He hated showing weakness.

Phainon’s gaze never wavered, but there was something soft in his eyes—a quiet concern, or something else that Mydei couldn’t quite decipher.

“You’re lying,” Phainon said, his voice almost teasing, but there was a thread of genuine curiosity in it. “But I’m sure you have your reasons.”

The way Phainon spoke, so calm, so collected—it was *unnerving* . How could someone be so at ease when the world was falling apart? How could he remain so unaffected by everything?

“You always know exactly what to say,” Mydei muttered, his voice edged with frustration. “Why is it so easy for you to act like everything’s fine?”

Phainon took a step closer, his presence suddenly looming in a way that made Mydei’s heart race. There was an intensity in Phainon’s gaze that Mydei had never fully acknowledged until now. It was almost too much—*too* close .

“I don’t know, Mydei,” Phainon said quietly, his voice dipping into something deeper, something almost *intimate* . “Maybe it’s because I understand you better than anyone else.”

Mydei flinched, though he tried to hide it. The last thing he wanted was to let Phainon see how much the words affected him. He straightened, trying

to regain his composure, but Phainon was so close—too close—and it made his stomach churn in a way he couldn't explain.

"You don't understand anything," Mydei said quickly, taking a step back, but even then, he felt Phainon's gaze following him, steady and unyielding.

Phainon smiled, but it wasn't the teasing smile that usually annoyed Mydei. It was soft, almost… *gentle* .

"Maybe not," Phainon said, his voice lower now, almost soothing. "But I'm still here. If you need someone to talk to."

The words hung in the air, heavy with a meaning Mydei didn't want to acknowledge. But he couldn't stop the feeling—an unexpected pull that seemed to draw him closer to Phainon, even as he fought to push it away.

"I'm fine," Mydei repeated, almost to himself, as if saying it enough would make it true. He stepped away from Phainon, his feet leading him toward the nearest door to the private baths. "I don't need anyone."

Mydei's thoughts were scattered as he entered the bathhouse once again where it'd started, the steam from the water swirling around him, obscuring his thoughts for a moment. He sank into the warm water, letting the heat seep into his bones. The quiet of the room was a welcome escape, the only sound the soft trickle of water as it splashed gently against the stone.

Everything is fine. Everything has to be fine.

But as he sat there, the weight of the world pressing on his shoulders, he couldn't shake the feeling that it was all slipping through his fingers. There was so much wrong with everything. The deaths. The betrayals. The growing unrest.

And then there was Phainon.

Mydei closed his eyes, letting the water surround him as his mind raced. It was easy to dismiss the tension between them, to pretend it didn't exist. But it was there. It's always been there.

He didn’t know why Phainon’s words seemed to haunt him. Maybe because, for the first time, someone really saw him. The vulnerability he tried so hard to hide—it was there, open and raw. Phainon knew that. Phainon always knew.

The door opened behind him with a soft creak. Mydei didn’t need to turn around to know who it was.

Phainon stepped inside, his presence like a shadow in the dim light.

“You’re still here,” Mydei said, trying to sound unaffected. But his voice was thick with something he couldn’t name.

“I said I’d be here if you needed someone,” Phainon replied, his voice low, almost a whisper.

Mydei wanted to push him away. He wanted to tell Phainon to leave, to stop intruding on his solitude. But he didn’t.

“Just don’t,” Mydei muttered, his head dropping into his hands.

Phainon didn’t press. Instead, he stood by the edge of the bath, watching him with an unreadable expression.

It wasn’t until Mydei finally lifted his head that Phainon spoke again, his voice softer this time.

“I don’t expect you to say anything you’re not ready for,” Phainon said quietly. “But I’m not going anywhere, Mydei. Whatever this is… we’ll face it together.”

Mydei felt his chest tighten at the words. He wanted to brush them off, to tell Phainon it didn’t matter, but… *God, it mattered.*

nd still racing, but the warmth of the bath started to work its calming magic. The steam curled around him, soothing the tightness in his chest. The longer he sat there, the more the silence seemed to press in, not suffocating, but oddly comforting.

He closed his eyes again, trying to force the noise in his mind to quiet, but the faintest sound of movement drew him back to the present.

When he opened his eyes, Phainon was standing there, looking down at him.

“Mydei,” Phainon said, his voice softer than usual. “I’m not leaving.”

Mydei said nothing in response, but he didn’t ask Phainon to leave, either.

Without another word, Phainon undressed and slowly eased into the water, his movements quiet but deliberate. There was something oddly peaceful about it—the way he slid in, his presence filling the space without needing to dominate it.

Phainon sat beside him, the heat of the water rising between them. For a moment, nothing was said. Just the sound of water shifting as they both settled into the bath.

Mydei let the silence stretch longer, feeling the pull of exhaustion but refusing to give in. Something in him wanted to keep fighting—to stay awake, to hold onto control. But then, just as he thought he might break, Phainon leaned toward him, his head slowly finding its place on Mydei’s shoulder.

Mydei tensed, just for a moment. His heart raced, expecting that pang of annoyance, the urge to shove him away, to remind Phainon of their unspoken boundaries. But instead, the feeling was different this time.

He didn’t push him away.

He didn’t say anything either.

He just let Phainon rest against him, his head light on Mydei’s shoulder, as the heat of the water surrounded them both. For some reason, the weight of Phainon’s head there felt right —like a steady anchor in the chaos of everything else.

Mydei’s heart thudded against his chest. He could feel Phainon’s breath slow, and in turn, his own pulse seemed to settle. For once, he didn’t feel the need to push away. He didn’t feel the tension building, didn’t feel like he had to maintain distance.

Just for a moment, he allowed himself to just be there—present, in this shared space.

Neither of them spoke. There was no need for words. Mydei didn’t know what it meant, but something inside of him—something quiet and aching—relaxed in the stillness. He wasn’t sure if it was a fleeting comfort or something deeper, but in that instant, it didn’t matter.

The weight of the world was still there, pressing down on him, but for a few moments, it wasn’t suffocating.

He wasn’t alone.

Triplets of Fate

Chapter Notes

> I’m gonna be honest, I posted this like 3 times already but deleted it a second later because of a formatting issue. God, I spent over an hour just trying to post this.
>
> Ahhhh I hate how ao3 doesn’t save italics, istg I spend more time going back to add those than the actual writing😭
>
> I’m pretty sure my friend had the flu or something and got me sick on accident, so I wrote this half asleep high on Tylenol because I want more Phaidei.
>
> So what I’m getting at, if it’s ass and shorter than u expected, you have full rights to hate on this one, I love degradation😈
>
> Alright but srs, enjoy reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A few weeks had passed since Castorice’s death, and the air in Okhema felt heavier. The city, with its familiar rhythm of life, seemed untouched by the monumental shifts that had just occurred. But to Mydei, it was as if the world had been tilted, and no matter how he tried, he couldn’t find his footing again.

The death of Castorice, the fall of Thanatos’s constellation—he had seen it coming, in some strange way. But that didn’t make it easier to bear. The loss had hit him harder than he expected, though he refused to show it. His mind still raced with questions that had no answers. How had it happened? Who was behind it all? The Heirs had been left with so many unanswered questions, yet they couldn’t afford to dwell. Every day brought another challenge, another problem to solve.

Still, Mydei found himself reflecting, sitting alone in his chambers as the sun dipped lower behind the stone walls of Okhema. The silence weighed on him more than anything. He let his gaze fall to the window, watching as the city faded into shadows.

A cold breeze slipped through the cracks, making the candles flicker, and Mydei's thoughts drifted back to the events of the past few weeks. He had kept his distance from the others, burying himself in tasks and reports, avoiding any deep conversations about what had happened. What could he say? He had lost so many already—he had to keep moving forward.

But sometimes, in the quiet moments like this, the melancholy crept in. He didn't want to admit it, but the absence of Castorice lingered in the back of his mind, like an open wound. And with each passing day, more constellations flickered in and out, and the heaviness in his chest only grew.

He turned from the window, the room around him feeling colder as he pushed the thoughts away. There was no room for sentiment. He was Mydei, a soldier, a protector of Okhema. He didn't have time for weakness.

Yet, even as he tried to steel himself, his mind kept drifting to Phainon.

Phainon had been with him more often recently, in ways that Mydei hadn't quite expected. The Deliverer, his greatest foe, yet also his friend, had become a fixture in Mydei's life. At first, it was just small things—an offer of help, a word of reassurance. But now, it was different. Phainon was there, lingering, his presence constant and undeniable.

Mydei had never thought much of it at first. But now? Now it was becoming harder to ignore. Phainon's support, his unwavering attention—it felt… comforting, in a way. But that thought unsettled him.

Stop, Mydei told himself sharply. He couldn't afford to go down that road. There was no time for distractions, no time for feelings. Not now. Not when Okhema was so fragile, so vulnerable. He couldn't let himself fall into that trap.

Yet, despite his best efforts, his mind kept returning to the same thought: Phainon. What did this mean? What was he supposed to do with this feeling that had no name?

He clenched his fists, shaking his head to rid himself of the thought. There was no place for this. Not with everything going on. Not when they were all in danger when the Titans were falling one by one.

The room fell silent again, the only sound the flicker of candlelight and the distant hum of Okhema outside. Mydei stood from his seat, moving toward the window once more. The city was so still tonight, almost as if it, too, was holding its breath.

Focus, he reminded himself. *You're not the same person you were before. You must fulfill. Don't lose sight of it.*

With a deep breath, Mydei turned from the window and walked toward the door, ready to step back into the world outside. There were no more quiet moments for him. Not now. Not while the world seemed to be crumbling around him.

And yet, even as he left his chambers, the feeling remained. Phainon. Just the thought of him brought a tightness in his chest, a pull he couldn't explain. But Mydei kept walking, knowing that distractions, feelings, all of it would have to wait.

There was more at stake now. There always was. And he couldn't afford to falter. Not for anyone.

Not even for Phainon.

The sun hung low in the sky as Mydei made his way through the streets, the day's duties finally drawing to a close. His steps were slow, the weight of the hours spent running errands and coordinating the city's defenses pressing on him. It had been a long day, one that had passed in a blur of faces and voices, all of them asking for his attention.

Just as he thought he could finally enjoy some solitude, a familiar voice broke through the bustling sounds of the street.

“Mydei!”

He turned to see Phainon, standing beneath a nearby tree, looking up at something with a mixture of frustration and happiness at seeing him. Mydei raised an eyebrow, curious.

As he stepped closer, the reason for Phainon’s distraction became clear. A small, fluffy cat was perched high in the branches, looking down with wide eyes. Below the tree, a young girl, no older than five or six, clutched at Phainon’s shirt, her face a mix of distress and hope.

“My cat, my cat’s stuck…!” she cried, her voice trembling with desperation.

Mydei couldn’t help but smile—well, more like a smirk—as he watched Phainon attempt to coax the cat down. Phainon was shifting from foot to foot, clearly trying to figure out the best way to reach the tree’s highest branch.

“Need a hand, Phainon?” Mydei called, amused.

Phainon looked down at him, his face breaking into that characteristic, charming grin. “You’d think after everything, a cat would be the least I could manage,” he said, his tone light, though Mydei could hear the hint of frustration beneath it.

Mydei’s lips twitched upward, the fondness in his tone clear even if his words were meant to be mocking. “I never thought I’d see the day where the great Deliverer struggles with a cat.”

Phainon laughed, shaking his head. “You’re not the only one.”

With a final stretch, Phainon finally managed to reach the cat, coaxing it down with surprising ease. It mewed contentedly as Phainon lowered it to the ground, handing it back to the girl with a soft smile on his face.

“There you go,” Phainon said, his voice warm. He patted the girl gently on the head, his expression softening even more. “Just be careful next time, alright?”

The girl smiled brightly, hugging her cat to her chest. “Thank you, Mister!” she exclaimed before scampering off, cat in tow.

Mydei watched the exchange, something stirring in his chest that he couldn’t quite place. Moments like these—when Phainon let his guard down, even just a little—made Mydei feel something more . A flicker of something deeper.

“Of course, you’d have a soft spot for children.” Mydei said, unsurprised.

Phainon chuckled and turned to face him, clearly not minding the mockery. “Everyone has their soft spots, Mydei. Even you.”

Mydei shook his head, his lips twitching upwards as a small smile formed on his face. “Maybe.”

It wasn’t long before Phainon swept him back into the whirlwind of work once again. There was always something to do, some task that needed attention, and Phainon wasted no time in dragging Mydei through every corner of the city. Mydei had expected to find some quiet space to think, to reflect, but it seemed Phainon had other plans.

The people of Okhema, as they always did, greeted Phainon with warmth and respect. His easy smile, his calm presence—he was a beacon in the chaos. Mydei, on the other hand, often found himself met with hesitant glances. Some recognized him, others didn’t, but the whispers about his past were never far behind. He had once been the prince of Kremnos, and no matter how hard he tried, that shadow would always follow him.

It was in these moments that the contrast between him and Phainon became painfully clear. Where Phainon was accepted without question, Mydei was met with a cool distance, even when he worked tirelessly beside the people to protect them.

They stopped by a vendor selling fresh bread, and Phainon exchanged a few words with the merchant, laughing softly. The vendor smiled warmly at him, nodding, but when the merchant turned to Mydei, it was a more formal acknowledgment, a polite nod rather than the friendliness Phainon had received.

Phainon noticed the difference, but he didn't comment. Instead, he patted Mydei on the shoulder as they moved on.

"You're doing fine, Mydei," Phainon said, his tone soothing but with that underlying sincerity that always seemed to soften Mydei's sharp edges. "The people are grateful for your work. Don't forget that."

Mydei gritted his teeth, pushing the thought aside. "I know," he said, his voice a little harsher than he intended.

They continued their rounds, moving from one task to the next, the day slipping away faster than Mydei had expected. Despite his internal conflict, there was a part of him that didn't mind Phainon's constant presence. It was easy, almost comfortable in a way he couldn't quite explain.

The day had bled into twilight, painting the sky in hues of burnt orange and deep indigo. Mydei stood in the courtyard of Okhema, his posture still and deliberate, as if the weariness in his body wasn't there. The faint hum of the bustling city was distant now, replaced by the quieter murmurs of wind through the old trees and cracked stone walls.

Phainon stood a few paces away, leaning lazily against the remnants of a fountain. His gaze, sharp and unwavering, lingered on Mydei as though watching him was its own form of meditation. The silence between them stretched—not uncomfortable, but unspoken words weighed heavy in the air.

"You didn't have to stick around," Mydei said finally, his voice calm, and low. He glanced over his shoulder at Phainon, his expression unreadable.

Phainon straightened, pushing off the fountain with a fluid movement. "And leave you to your brooding?" he said lightly, though the warmth in his tone

softened the jab. “You’d work yourself into an early grave if you weren’t… well, immortal.”

Mydei huffed quietly, the closest thing to a laugh he’d allow. “That’s not a concern for me, but you should rest.”

Phainon walked closer, closing the space between them until he stood at Mydei’s side. His presence wasn’t overwhelming, it felt natural. “I’m resting right now,” he said, gesturing vaguely. “In my own way.”

Mydei shook his head but didn’t press the matter. His gaze turned back toward the horizon, the last vestiges of sunlight sinking below the edge of the world. For a while, neither of them spoke, the silence settling in comfortably.

“I’ve noticed you’ve been more…constant,” no maybe that wasn’t the right word,

“No, absent lately,” Mydei said, his words slow, measured. “It’s unusual.”

Phainon gave a small, half-smile, tilting his head slightly. “Is that your way of saying you’ve missed me?”

“No,” Mydei said flatly, but his tone lacked bite. “It’s just an observation.”

Phainon chuckled softly, the sound low and warm. “You’re welcome, by the way. For all my efforts.”

“Efforts?” Mydei raised a brow.

“Keeping you alive, keeping you sane… the usual,” Phainon replied, his smile widening. “You’d be lost without me.” It sounded like teasing.

This time, Mydei didn’t respond. His expression was distant, thoughtful as if weighing something in his mind. He shifted his weight slightly, his hand brushing against the hilt of his blade out of habit. Finally, he glanced at Phainon, his eyes steady.

“You’re a good person,” he said quietly, the words slipping out almost like an afterthought.

Phainon froze for half a heartbeat, his sharp features softening in an instant. For all his confidence, the sincerity of the statement hit him like a blade to the chest.

“You… think so?” Phainon asked, his voice quieter now, more genuine.

“I know you are,” Mydei replied, his gaze steady. There was no humor in his tone, no attempt to mask the truth of what he said. “It’s not a matter of opinion.”

The simplicity of the statement lingered in the air, more impactful for its honesty. Mydei turned his head away, his focus shifting back to the horizon. “That’s all I meant to say.”

He began to walk off, his figure cutting a stark silhouette against the fading light.

Phainon stood frozen, watching him leave, his heart racing in a way that felt unfamiliar—unsettling, even. Mydei’s words echoed in his mind, over and over, louder than anything else around him.

You’re a good person.

A faint smile curved Phainon’s lips, but it wasn’t his usual smirk. It was something smaller, quieter, but infinitely more uncanny.

He was going to make sure Mydei never had a reason to doubt that.

Phainon now stood alone in the courtyard, the last light of day slowly fading into night. He exhaled, and for a brief moment, his chest felt tight—almost like something had lodged itself deep inside him, unwilling to leave. *You’re a good person*, Mydei’s voice echoed in his mind.

It was strange, how those words had hit him. Not the usual words of admiration or praise he was accustomed to hearing, but something rawer.

Something that felt too real, too vulnerable. Phainon chuckled softly under his breath, the sound hollow in the silence.

You're a good person.

He repeated the words, rolling them around in his mind like they were some kind of puzzle to solve. Mydei's voice lingered, just as clear as when he had spoken them, but Phainon felt the weight of them differently now. His chest tightened again, the sensation growing heavier with each passing second.

Is that what I am? Phainon thought, his fingers idly playing with the edges of his sleeve. A good person? *Or am I just pretending to be?*

His eyes dropped to his hand, and he noticed the golden butterfly that had perched there. The delicate creature, a nymph from Aglaea, fluttered its wings gently, unaware of the dark thoughts swirling in Phainon's mind. It was beautiful in its fragility, a soft glimmer of gold in the growing dark.

You're fragile too, he thought, his thumb brushing over the nymph's wings with the slightest pressure. *Just like Mydei. So beautiful. So fragile.*

For a moment, he let himself imagine what it would be like to protect it. To guard that fragile beauty. But then the thought shifted, twisting into something darker.

What if I could be the one to break it?

The idea surfaced so suddenly, like a sharp, cold breath. Phainon paused, his fingers hovering over the butterfly's delicate wings. *Could I be his soft spot*? He thought about Mydei again— *always guarded, always distant* . But that wasn't enough for Phainon, was it? No. He didn't want to be just the constant . He didn't want to be a comfort . He wanted to be the one to shatter him, just enough to claim him entirely.

A soft laugh escaped him, low and unsettling. He glanced down at the butterfly again, its tiny legs scrambling, trying to regain its balance on his hand. His breath hitched, just for a second, as if the mere thought of breaking that delicate form had caused something inside him to tremble.

But it was weak —that's what he told himself. *Fragile. Weak.* He couldn't help but feel the need to control it, to hold it, to claim it for himself.

Phainon's fingers tightened around the butterfly slowly, just a little at first, testing its response. It squirmed, but it didn't fly away. No, it was stuck. Stuck with him.

He leaned down, his voice barely a whisper, a soft murmur just for the butterfly. "I wonder if I could make you my soft spot," he whispered, his voice laced with both curiosity and something worse, something more possessive. "I wonder if I could make you need me… just like I need you."

The butterfly twitched again, its tiny form shuddering against the increasing pressure. Phainon's grip didn't loosen; instead, he applied just a little more force, feeling its wings buckle beneath his fingers.

So fragile, he thought again, the words tasting bitter in his mouth. *I could crush you, just like that. You'd never be able to escape me.*

He held it for a moment longer, letting the sensation of its life beneath his hand pulse through him. His chest tightened again, but this time, he didn't fight it. He didn't want to. He wanted the feeling to last, to stretch out, to savor the power he had over this little creature, this fragile thing that couldn't possibly escape him.

But the butterfly's movements became slower, weaker. It was breaking. It couldn't hold on for much longer.

Without another thought, Phainon squeezed harder, just enough to feel the frail body snap under his touch. The delicate sound of crushed wings filled the air, but the butterfly didn't die. It fluttered weakly, still breathing, still alive .

A low chuckle rumbled from Phainon's chest. He didn't release it. Instead, he held it in his palm as it gasped for air, its movements strained, broken. His fingers curled around it like a cage, keeping it just alive enough for him to watch.

“I’m still here, though, aren’t I? I’ll stay with you till the end because I’m a *good person* , ” Phainon muttered to the butterfly, his voice taking on a strange tenderness. He was gentle now, holding the broken creature with a tenderness that betrayed the violence he’d just enacted. “You don’t get to escape. Not yet.”

The nymph’s wings flapped weakly, but there was no strength left in its body. It was dying, struggling for breath in Phainon’s hand, and he watched it, the twisted, agonizing fascination holding him captive.

He thought of Mydei again— *strong, but so fragile* . How long before Phainon could make him his? How long before Mydei would need him as much as he needed Mydei?

With a soft, almost reverent sigh, Phainon closed his hand completely, feeling the last of the butterfly’s tremors fade. He held it like that for a few more seconds, savoring the sensation of its struggle, before he finally opened his palm to let it fall.

The nymph crumpled, its tiny golden body still and lifeless. Phainon didn’t flinch. He simply looked at it, his mind already drifting back to thoughts of Mydei, wondering just how long it would take before the man would be just as broken, just as lost to him.

I will be everything to you, Phainon thought, his eyes narrowing, his heart beating faster with each passing second. *And when you need me, when you’re completely in my grasp… I will never let you go.*

With one last, quiet glance at the butterfly, Phainon turned and walked away, the quiet weight of his obsession—love, growing bit by bit.

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The world was dim, drenched in an ethereal twilight that flickered between reality and something other . Mydei stood amidst shifting shadows, the

ground beneath him unsteady, as though it could slip away at any moment.

He knew this was a dream.

And yet, the air felt too heavy, thick with something he could neither name nor shake.

The sky above was vast and empty—no stars, no constellations, only an endless black void that pressed down upon him like a weight. The silence here was unnatural, humming with an absence that made his pulse quicken.

Then— a flicker.

Three figures stood ahead of him, their forms wavering as if they were barely clinging to existence.

The Triplets.

Tribbie. Trianne. Trinnon.

At first, they were fused together, their three faces overlapping in an eerie, seamless blend—one entity, three minds, held together by something unseen. Their presence felt familiar yet foreign, as though they weren't supposed to be here , like this.

But as Mydei watched, something began to change.

The force binding them started to slip. A crack split through their unified form, jagged and unnatural, spreading like fractures in glass. Slowly, agonizingly, the Triplets began to **tear apart .**

Tribbie clutched at her head, her fingers digging into her scalp as if trying to hold herself together. Trianne staggered backward, her body flickering, edges curling inward like paper catching fire. Trinnon simply stood still, her eyes hollow, expression unreadable, but Mydei could feel it—the unraveling, the losing.

They are breaking.

A feeling of unease coiled in his chest, something deep and unspoken. He wanted to move, to step forward, to stop this. But his body would not obey.

The crack deepened.

Trianne let out a strangled gasp, her form flickering violently, as though something was **being pulled out of her** . Her lips moved, but no sound came. Her fingers stretched toward Mydei, desperate, reaching.

Trinnon’s expression didn’t change, but her body **collapsed inward** , folding into herself like a dying star.

And then there was Tribbie, the last one standing. She turned to Mydei, her eyes locking onto his, pleading but filled with something else.

Resignation .

Her form trembled. The force holding her in place was slipping, leaking out like light through shattered glass. And in that moment, Mydei understood—she was not trying to hold herself together.

She was trying to hold **them** together.

But it was too late.

A sharp, agonizing crack echoed through the void.

And then, they were gone.

Nothing remained but empty space.

And the whisper.

Faint, curling through the still air, slipping past the void to nestle itself into Mydei’s mind.

“*What is left… when the binding fails?*”

The words slithered against his thoughts, slipping beneath his skin, cold and final.

The emptiness stretched before him, vast and unending. His breath came slow and shallow, the weight of the silence pressing into his chest.

Then—

A new presence.

Something behind him.

He turned.

And woke up.

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The dim light of the early morning filtered through the cracks in the walls, soft and pale. Mydei sat upright, his chest rising and falling in a steady rhythm, but his eyes were wide open, fixed on a point in the room that didn’t exist.

He didn’t move.

The dream lingered, etched into his mind like a fresh wound. The image of the Triplets breaking apart played on an endless loop in his head, each crack, each flicker, as vivid as if it had just happened before him.

But Mydei didn’t panic.

His breathing remained even, controlled, though his hands rested tensely on the fabric of the bedding beneath him, fingers curling ever so slightly.

The whisper echoed faintly in the back of his mind.

“ What is left… when the binding fails?”

It didn’t fade, nor did it deepen. It simply lingered, heavy and quiet, like a storm cloud refusing to break.

Minutes passed. Then an hour.

Mydei stayed exactly where he was, his body rigid but calm, his mind caught in the stillness between denial and acceptance. He didn’t try to make sense of it—not yet. He simply let the silence settle over him, matching its weight to the one pressing down inside him.

Eventually, his fingers loosened, the faintest tremble in their release.

His gaze shifted for the first time, falling to the floor by his bedside. His lips parted slightly, but no words came. There was no one to say them to.

Not yet.

He ran a hand over his face, the touch grounding him back into his surroundings. The faint ache in his chest remained, as though his heart had been clutched too tightly in the grip of something unseen.

Only then did Mydei stand, his movements deliberate, his expression guarded. But beneath the surface, the unease coiled and writhed, a quiet promise that the dream would not be forgotten.

He had questions.

But for now, Mydei stayed silent.

Mydei found Tribbie in the meadow near the colonnade ruins, twirling in circles as if the world itself were her dance floor. Her white robes fanned out as she spun, and she giggled softly to herself, the ornaments on her dress jingling with each step.

“Do you ever sit still?” Mydei asked, his voice low as he approached.

She stopped mid-spin, balancing on one foot like a child caught misbehaving. Her wide, playful grin softened when she saw him. She tilted her head, her hair tumbling like spun silver.

“**We** wondered when you would come to us!” she said, clasping her hands behind her back and rocking on her heels.

Mydei’s lips twitched faintly, the closest he’d come to a smile. “You’re more cryptic than usual,” he said.

She gasped, her expression fake offended. “ **We** are always clear. You’re just bad at listening!”

He sighed, rubbing a hand over his face. “Right. Well, listen to me, then. I need your help.”

Tribbie immediately brightened, bouncing closer. “You do? Finally! **We** were getting bored waiting for you to ask!” She clasped his hand between hers, looking up at him with wide, eager eyes. “So, what is it? Did something spooky happen? Did you see something weird? Tell us, tell us!”

He hesitated, but her sincerity—innocent and honest as it seemed—wore him down. Slowly, he relayed his dream. The splitting of the Tribios. The force that bound them came undone. The whisper that still clawed at his mind.

Tribbie listened intently, her antics momentarily subdued. She nodded along as if she understood every word, her golden eyes shimmering with something unreadable.

When he finished, she took a deep breath, her expression thoughtful.

“**We** know dreams can feel scary,” she said, her tone surprisingly gentle. “But they’re like puzzles De, you know? You just need to figure out what the pieces mean. And the whisper…” She trailed off, tapping a finger against her lips. “The whisper sounds *important* .”

“You think I don’t know that?” Mydei muttered, crossing his arms. “I need more than vague encouragement.”

Tribbie frowned, puffing out her cheeks. “ **We’re** not being vague! You just need to pay more attention! Dreams aren’t answers, Mydei—they’re clues!” She poked him in the chest for emphasis, her voice growing more animated. “Maybe you’re supposed to follow what’s coming undone. Maybe that’s the whole point!”

He stared at her, unamused. “You have no idea what it means either, do you?”

Her pout deepened. “Rude.” She turned away, arms crossed, before glancing back over her shoulder with a sly grin. “But fine. Think whatever you want. **We** still think you’re scared. That’s why you’re asking . ”

Mydei didn’t respond immediately. Her words hit closer than he wanted to admit, but he kept his expression neutral. After a long pause, he said, “If you’re so wise, tell me one thing. Is the dream a warning or a promise?”

Tribbie blinked, her grin softening into something faintly bittersweet. She reached up, brushing a strand of silver hair behind her ear.

“Both,” she said simply. “A warning is a promise if you don’t figure it out quickly.”

That was all she gave him.

Mydei stared at her, the cryptic reply sinking into his chest like a stone. Finally, he nodded once, turning to leave without another word.

Behind him, Tribbie cupped her hands to her mouth and called out playfully, “Don’t forget— **we’re** always right!”

As Mydei disappeared into the shadows, Tribbie’s smile lingered. She lowered her hands, her gaze softening as she murmured to herself, “The bindings are fraying… just like we knew they would.”

She spun again, her laughter trailing into the breeze, as though the heaviness of the moment hadn't touched her at all.

Sighing, Mydei left.

As Mydei rounded the corner, he almost collided with someone, his steps halting just in time to avoid the contact. His eyes flicked up to meet Anaxa's, the scholar's usual distant expression unchanged, though Mydei couldn't shake the odd sensation that prickled down his spine.

"Watch where you're going," Anaxa muttered, adjusting his papers, though his tone was far from irritating. He simply had the air of someone who'd right now prefer to avoid confrontation

Mydei hesitated for a moment, the sense of foreboding still lingering, but he pushed it down. "You're distracted," he said flatly, scanning Anaxa's face for any hint of something unusual, though there was none.

Anaxa looked even more unamused. "Considering the situation, I don't think that's surprising."

"I suppose so." Mydei paused, the uneasy feeling pressing against his chest like an invisible weight. "You're heading somewhere important?" He asked indifferently, though he couldn't quite shake the feeling that something wasn't right.

Anaxa glanced up from his papers, a brief flicker of something in his expression. "I'm always heading somewhere important, but that's none of your concern."

Mydei kept his gaze steady, neither pressing nor backing down. "I'll walk with you, then."

The two continued in silence, Mydei's steps slightly faster than Anaxa's, his mind still distracted by the strange foreboding sensation. He didn't know why he felt compelled to follow the scholar, but the nagging feeling that something was wrong didn't ease, and he couldn't quite shake it off.

When they reached the point where Anaxa's path veered off, Mydei stopped, his eyes lingering on the scholar for a moment longer than necessary. "Be careful," Mydei muttered, his tone flat but not without an edge of concern, though his face didn't betray it.

Anaxa raised a brow but said nothing, simply turning away with a slight incline of his head. "It's just a walk, Mydei. Don't waste your time."

Without responding, Mydei turned and left, his steps quick and decisive. He didn't look back, but the air felt different somehow, thicker, as though something was shifting just beyond his awareness. He kept his gaze straight ahead, trying to ignore the nagging feeling that had settled at the back of his mind.

As he passed through the winding paths, the city was quieter now, the sounds of distant chatter and footsteps fading as he walked deeper into the shadows. The usual weight of things pressing on him—the unease, the heavy burden of recent events—seemed to lift slightly, but not entirely. There was still something gnawing at him, something unresolved.

It was when he rounded a corner and saw Phainon that it returned. The man stood still, his posture tense, and there was no smile, no usual energy in the way he carried himself. Phainon simply raised a hand, offering a brief wave before turning away, and walking off without another word.

It was strange. Mydei felt the familiar pulse of discomfort in his chest—something was off. It wasn't like Phainon to be so quiet, so detached. But Mydei didn't have time to dwell on it. There were too many other things pressing on his mind, too many unanswered questions.

He shook the feeling away and moved on.

Minutes turned into an hour as Mydei walked alone, the city now a quiet backdrop to his swirling thoughts. His footsteps echoed faintly in the empty streets, the weight of silence wrapping around him like a heavy blanket.

And then, suddenly, something changed.

At first, it was subtle—a shifting in the air, a slight blur around the edges of his vision. But it grew, pulling his senses away from the world around him, drawing his attention inward. He couldn't understand it at first. The feeling was intense, sharp, like a jolt of electricity. But his body didn't react the way it should. He didn't jump, didn't flinch. Instead, he felt… disoriented.

And then, as though a veil had been pulled away, Mydei's surroundings began to distort. His body went rigid, the world around him fracturing, splitting, as though it was no longer solid. The pulse of his heartbeat thudded loudly in his ears, so strong that it felt like it was reverberating through his very bones.

Mydei's breath caught in his throat, but before he could react, something else invaded his senses—a vision. And this wasn't like a dream. This was real. This was happening, bleeding into his reality like a poisoned ink spilling into water.

The vision hit him hard, and in that instant, he understood: It wasn't just a vision of Anaxa. It was his pain . He felt it—the sharp, unbearable pain searing through his skull as though his brain was being twisted apart. He could hear the crack of bone, the sickening squelch of blood, the thumping of his own heart going wild in his chest.

And it was Anaxa .

His brain—Anaxa's brain—felt like it was cracking under pressure, the force of it too intense to comprehend. There was a strange pressure building in Mydei's own head, as if his mind were being stretched to its limits. His body reacted instinctively, his knees buckling beneath him, but he couldn't move. He couldn't escape it. The vision gripped him, holding him in place, forcing him to experience everything Anaxa felt.

He gasped as if it were his own pain, his body trembling. The vision twisted, warping his perception. The sense of Anaxa's mind fracturing was almost unbearable—each pulse of agony was like a jolt of electricity running through Mydei's own body. His breath quickened, shallow, desperate to escape the suffocating reality he was trapped in.

The pressure intensified.

And then, through the agonizing haze, a whisper cut through the madness, a voice that didn't belong to anyone Mydei knew. *"It's not what you think. It's never what you think."*

The words sent a chill down his spine, but they only made the pain worse, twisting his thoughts and his body further into a knot of confusion and terror.

No… Mydei thought, struggling against the vision. *No, I can't…*

But it was too much.

Anaxa's mind continued to fracture, the pain—his pain—becoming unbearable. Mydei's head felt as though it were splitting in two. His vision blurred, his body burning with the heat of what should have been impossible.

It felt like dying. The pain, the horror, the brokenness of the vision—it felt like a second death. His breath came in ragged gasps as if he were drowning, suffocating under the weight of it all. His entire body trembled violently, unable to escape the chaos in his mind.

And then, just as suddenly as it began, the vision shattered, the grip on his mind snapping away with a violent force.

Mydei fell to the ground, his palms scraping against the cold stone beneath him. He gasped, each breath painful and shallow, as if he had just returned to life. His heart was still racing, the aftershocks of the vision leaving him trembling, sweat beading on his forehead.

But the image of Anaxa remained—his fractured, broken mind, and the whisper that would not leave.

It took Mydei a long moment to regain his bearings, his body aching from the force of the vision, his head still throbbing with the remnants of the

pain. When he finally stood, his legs unsteady beneath him, he couldn’t shake the feeling that something was wrong.

Whatever this was—whatever it meant—Mydei knew he couldn’t ignore it.

The unease that had settled in his chest grew heavier. He had to find Anaxa. There was no choice. Something was coming, and Mydei didn’t know how much time they had left, and he wasn’t willing to find out.

Mydei’s feet hammered against the cold stone floor, his heart pounding erratically in his chest. He barreled through the halls, the world around him a blur of shadows and distant voices. The usual noise of Okhema, its hum of life and energy, felt miles away, drowned out by the roar of his thoughts. He needed to find Anaxa. He had to.

It didn’t matter that the citizens were staring, their eyes widening as he pushed past them. The disapproving looks, the murmurs behind hands, the way people stepped aside and gave him wide berths—it didn’t matter. None of it mattered. He barely noticed, his focus razor-sharp as he continued searching every room, every hallway, every alley, demanding to know if anyone had seen him.

The sense of urgency clawed at him, the sinking feeling deep in his chest refusing to relent. He couldn’t shake the feeling that something was wrong. That something had already happened.

Time blurred as Mydei darted from one place to the next, his breath coming quicker, his movements sharper. His mind raced, but there were no answers. No clues.

He was about to give up, the ache of failure already gnawing at him when he noticed it—just the faintest streak of golden blood splattered across the wall. His breath caught in his throat, the gold gleaming in the dim light like some kind of sick beacon.

Golden blood.

His hands clenched into fists, and without thinking, he took off again, following the trail. His legs moved on instinct, propelled by something primal, the gnawing feeling of dread growing stronger with each step.

The trail of blood led him to a narrow corridor, the stone walls cracked and weathered. At the end, a door was slightly ajar, creaking faintly in the stillness. Mydei pushed it open without hesitation, his eyes immediately drawn to the horror that awaited him.

Anaxa's body lay crumpled in the middle of the room. The once-dignified scholar was sprawled on the floor, unmoving, his face contorted in an expression of unimaginable pain. The blood around him—the golden blood—had already started to pool around his head, shimmering sickly in the light. The most jarring sight, however, was the deep, jagged gash that ran through the very center of his skull, cleaving it in two.

It was brutal. It was grotesque.

The cut was so clean, so deep, that it seemed as if someone had sliced through him with a blade honed for the sole purpose of destroying his mind. Mydei's vision swam as he took in the details—the blood that stained the floor, the cracked stone around Anaxa's body, and the hollow emptiness where his once-intelligent eyes would have looked. His skull, split in half like an overripe fruit, stared up at the ceiling, a final testament to the violence that had taken his life.

Mydei's stomach twisted violently at the sight, his mouth dry, his legs shaking. He had to force himself to stay upright. He couldn't— *couldn't* —let his body react to this, couldn't give in to the horror that threatened to overwhelm him. But it was hard. Harder than anything, any death, he'd experienced before. He pressed his palm against the wall, willing himself not to throw up, to stay in control. The stench of blood and death clawed at him.

For a long moment, he stood there in stunned silence, staring down at Anaxa's shattered body. It wasn't real. It couldn't be. This wasn't supposed to happen. Not like this.

But the blood was real. The broken skull was real. The unnatural stillness of Anaxa's body was real.

And so was the pain that shot through Mydei's chest, the hollow ache of losing someone yet again.

The days that followed were nothing short of a blur.

Just like Castorice, news of Anaxa's death spread quickly through Okhema, and it wasn't long before whispers began to circulate about Mydei's involvement. He had been the last person seen with both Anaxa and Castorice. The suspicion was palpable, the eyes of the city fixed on him with a mixture of fear and accusation.

The citizens, once warm and welcoming, or as much as they could be to Mydei, now seemed to keep their distance even more. Their glances were sharp and wary. It was no secret that Mydei was different—he always had been—but now, with two deaths on his hands, his mere presence made them uneasy. They didn't know what to believe, but they believed the worst. And it didn't matter to Mydei. He didn't care.

The weight of their stares barely registered. He was lost, his mind swimming with the death of Anaxa, the violence, the brutal way it had happened. He was a mess, his usual calm demeanor shredded by the grief and guilt gnawing at his insides. He didn't have the energy to feign normalcy and didn't care to maintain his usual detached facade. It felt… meaningless.

He wandered the halls, his head heavy with thoughts, until the news of Anaxa's death reached the ears of the other heirs. It was a quick gathering, an urgent meeting held under the heavy weight of grief and suspicion. The heirs all looked at him—at Mydei—with a mix of concern and wariness, but no one dared speak directly to him. They, too, felt the heat of the rumors swirling around him.

And still, Mydei remained silent, the weight of it all pressing down on him.

But he didn’t care about the heirs. He didn’t care about their questions or their doubts. He had lost Anaxa, and that was all that mattered right now.

For now, Mydei was alone again.

Mydei barely noticed the passing hours, his mind a chaotic storm, his heart a hollow pit of dread. The faces of the heirs blurred as they spoke, their voices rising and falling in the background like a muffled noise he couldn’t fully comprehend. He stood among them, unfeeling, disconnected, a silent observer to the grief of others that didn’t reach him. It didn’t matter. Anaxa was dead. Castorice was dead. It was all slipping through his fingers.

As he turned to leave the room, desperate to escape the weight of their looks and words, Phainon’s voice broke through the fog.

“Mydei.”

He froze. The mere sound of his name from Phainon’s lips sent an involuntary shiver down his spine. He didn’t want to deal with him right now—not in the midst of all this. His hands clenched, trying to quell the nausea rising in his stomach. He wanted space.

He didn’t look at Phainon, but the heavy hand on his shoulder made his breath hitch. He flinched.

“Don’t touch me,” Mydei spat, the words coming out rough and hollow, the tone all sharp edges. His body jerked as he tried to pull away, but Phainon didn’t let go. The gesture felt too familiar. Too warm.

Phainon didn’t respond right away. He simply held his ground, his fingers still pressing lightly against Mydei’s shoulder. Mydei felt the weight of his touch, the constant pressure in the air between them. He could feel Phainon’s gaze boring into him, but the mess in his chest refused to allow any response.

For a long moment, neither of them spoke. The tension thickened, stretching long enough that Mydei’s breaths became shallow. Something was wrong—he could feel it again. That same pull, that gnawing sensation

from earlier, when he had seen Anaxa's death. The same feeling that had prompted him to search for him.

It was back.

His heart beat erratically. Panic gripped him, and he couldn't shake the sudden overwhelming sense of urgency. This… this wasn't just a feeling. It was something more.

Before he could stop himself, Mydei grabbed Phainon's wrist, spinning him around with a force that left both of them breathless. The sudden movement felt wild, like the instinctive reaction of a creature trapped in its terror. Mydei's eyes were wide, his pulse racing.

Phainon's voice caught in his throat, confusion flashing across his features as Mydei pushed him back a few steps, slamming him against the wall. "What the hell—"

"Don't leave," Mydei's voice was barely above a whisper, but it carried the weight of something deeper—an unspoken plea, a desperate wish buried beneath layers of cold detachment. His hand was trembling, his body coiled tight with an energy that didn't make sense. The words were shaky, rough with barely contained fear. His throat burned, but his mind couldn't stop racing. *No, not him too. I can't lose him.*

Phainon stared at him, his eyes narrowing with confusion and concern, but there was something else there—something darker, an undercurrent of tension. The uncharacteristic urgency in Mydei's voice made him hesitate, his breath catching for a split second. Mydei wasn't the type to show weakness. Not like this.

"What's wrong?" Phainon asked, his voice low, steady—despite the shock in his gaze. But there was something in his expression now, a flash of worry, of hesitation.

Mydei didn't answer, his grip tightening on Phainon's wrist. The vision, the feeling—something wasn't right. He didn't know what it was, but every

fiber of his being screamed that he couldn’t let Phainon leave. Not yet. Not with the way things had been going. *I need to protect him.*

But even then, his voice cracked a little. “Please… don’t go. Not yet.”

Phainon remained still, his hand hovering uncertainly over Mydei’s, but he didn’t pull away. The weight of the moment seemed to stretch endlessly between them, but Phainon said nothing, only watching him with a faint furrow in his brow.

Mydei’s hand shook again, his breath coming quick, the cold dread clinging to him. And for the first time in what felt like forever, he didn’t know what to do. He didn’t want to let go. But more than that, he didn’t want Phainon to slip through his grasp.

He wouldn’t let him.

Phainon’s pulse raced as Mydei’s hand tightened around his wrist, spinning him against the wall. The raw energy radiating from him sent a rush of excitement through Phainon’s veins—uncontrollable, intoxicating. Mydei was close, so close now, pressed against him with an almost tangible urgency. For a split second, Phainon felt the briefest flicker of confusion, his mind still trying to make sense of the situation, but it was immediately overridden by something much darker, much more thrilling.

Mydei’s breath hitched as he gripped Phainon’s wrist tighter, his fingers trembling—trembling. The tiny detail was enough to send a rush of heat to Phainon’s chest. The pressure between them, the frantic need in Mydei’s gaze, was too much to ignore. Phainon’s heart pounded faster. This—this was exactly what he had been waiting for.

For a moment, he could barely contain the elated smile tugging at the corners of his lips. His chest swelled with an almost manic joy as he let his body lean forward, closer to Mydei. He could feel the warmth of, the rhythmic rise and fall of his chest, the faint scent of him, intoxicating. Without thinking, his mouth brushed against the smooth skin of Mydei’s neck, a shiver running down his spine as he did so. He’d dreamed of this—

of touching him like this—of being this close, of feeling Mydei's tension, his fear, his need.

He could taste it in the air—the rawness of the moment.

"Please… don't go. Not yet," Mydei's voice trembled in his ear, low and almost broken.

Phainon's hand tightened around his wrist, but his heart was racing differently now—this wasn't fear. No, this was something far more dangerous, something deep, something that buzzed beneath his skin.

He was *alive* . Mydei had come to him, clinging to him with a desperation that was almost too much to bear.

Phainon's lips hovered just a breath away from Mydei's neck, the heat of his skin intoxicating. He inhaled deeply, the feeling of his breath against Mydei's skin a rare privilege that made his heart race even faster. *I've finally gotten this close*, he thought, his fingers lightly brushing against the back of Mydei's neck as if savoring the moment.

His mind screamed with the elation of the situation.

He'd taken what he needed. Anaxa and Castorice—they were simply in the way. They always were. All their talk of protecting Mydei, all their attention, made Phainon's skin crawl. Mydei was his. He was always meant to be his.

But no one could understand. No one could see . He couldn't let them stand in the way. He didn't need them. Mydei didn't need them. He only needed Phainon.

The jealousy that had driven him to kill them both now felt justified. They had been obstacles —but now, there was nothing between him and Mydei. Nothing to keep them apart. Phainon had worked tirelessly for this, biding his time. His devotion to Mydei—it was pure. It was righteous.

You don’t know what it’s like to be adored like this, Phainon thought, his chest tightening with the thought. *They could never give you what I can.* Mydei could never see it, not yet, but Phainon would make him. He would make him see, make him understand.

He knew Mydei could never be with someone who wasn’t as strong as him. But Phainon had that strength, that conviction. Mydei didn’t need to fight anymore— *he’d protect him* . He had proven that over and over. And if Mydei ever questioned it, well… Phainon would make sure those doubts didn’t linger. He would burn them away.

He could feel Mydei’s heartbeat under his fingers, pounding faster, and Phainon couldn’t help the elated smile that finally crept onto his lips. Mydei was here, clinging to him with an undeniable urgency. He’d made sure of it. Now, he was going to savor it.

Phainon slowly, almost reverently, let his lips graze Mydei’s neck again, the brief touch enough to send a thrill down his spine. *You’ll understand soon enough*, he thought, his mind spinning with all the possibilities, all the things he would do to make Mydei realize how right they were for each other.

The death of Castorice. The death of Anaxa. They were just the beginning.

For now, he let his fingers trace the lines of Mydei’s shoulder, his grip tightening just slightly. He could feel Mydei’s tremor under his touch, but it wasn’t fear—it was something else, something that drove him mad with need.

The only thing that mattered now was keeping him close, keeping him safe, keeping him for himself. *And no one will take you from me*, he promised silently.

At this moment, with Mydei so near, Phainon was complete. He could feel it in every nerve, every breath he took. The obsession—his obsession—had only just begun.

But it wasn’t enough. Not yet.

Phainon adjusted his grip ever so slightly, leading Mydei forward, careful not to move too quickly. Mydei followed, staying close, his wariness still present but softened by his exhaustion. Phainon didn't speak at first, letting the silence stretch between them, a quiet thread of unspoken understanding. He played it slow, cautious. If he rushed, he'd shatter the moment.

Mydei's gaze remained distant, barely seeing the path ahead, his thoughts clearly elsewhere. Phainon knew exactly where. He could feel it in the weight of Mydei's steps, the tension in his fingers when they'd brushed against his wrist earlier.

Grief.

But grief could be a wonderful thing. It broke people down, made them vulnerable, malleable. And Phainon had every intention of ensuring Mydei turned to him in his weakness.

So he sighed, just loud enough for Mydei to hear, a breathy, almost regretful sound, as if the situation had finally settled in his chest like a heavy stone. "I should've been there," he murmured. "If I had known…"

Mydei finally looked at him. The expression on his face sent something sharp through Phainon's chest—a real reaction, direct, raw.

"Phainon," Mydei said, voice quieter than before. Then, with a weight that could crush bones: "Anaxa is dead."

The words hung between them, heavier than the sky itself.

Phainon could feel the moment shift, as if Mydei were forcing him to understand. The sheer loss. The gravity of it all.

Oh, Mydei. If only you knew how little I cared.

But Phainon didn't let even a fraction of that thought show. Instead, his breath stilled, his lips parting just slightly as if struggling to find the words. Slowly, he lowered his gaze, let his body slacken just a bit, not enough to appear weak—no, never weak—but just enough to seem… affected.

“I know,” he said at last, voice quiet, controlled. “I know.”

He let his hand tremble.

A small, involuntary shake, subtle yet deliberate. Just enough.

It worked.

Without hesitation, Mydei grabbed his hand, fingers curling around it firmly. The warmth of his touch, the way he held on without thinking—it was intoxicating.

Phainon had to focus to keep from shuddering at the sheer intimacy of it.

“Why are you shaking?” Mydei asked, eyes searching his face.

For a fraction of a second, Phainon considered telling the truth—because you’re touching me, and I could die happy in this moment. But that wouldn’t do. That would break the illusion.

Instead, he swallowed, shifting his expression into something more conflicted, something Mydei would believe. “It’s nothing,” he said, voice hoarse, forcing himself to look away as if burdened by thoughts too heavy to voice.

He expected Mydei to let go.

But he didn’t.

Instead, his grip tightened, not painfully, but with purpose. A reassurance.

Phainon barely heard his next words, too focused on the sheer audacity of what was happening.

It wasn’t about Anaxa. It wasn’t about Castorice. Not to him.

No—this was about Mydei.

About how his fingers fit around Phainon’s own. How his thumb rested against his skin absentmindedly, a thoughtless comfort. How his eyes, so tired and lost, still softened just slightly when he looked at him.

It was working.

It was all working.

And Phainon, with all the patience in the world, would let it continue. He would let Mydei mourn. Let him reach for him in the dark, thinking it was his choice.

And then, when the time was right, Mydei wouldn’t even realize he had no one left but Phainon.

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Year: Unknown

The constellation of Janus has gone dark.

Talanton, the Scale of Justice, and Oronyx, the Veil of Evernight, now burned brightly, casting a blazing glow across the sky.

Law and Order had descended into chaos.

Chapter End Notes

> I’m sorry yall, are u alright with me potentially extending this to 4-5 chapters? I went off script and didn’t write everything I wanted, plus I spent like the whole day on this and want a bit more time to flesh everything out before posting, and a bit more free time😢
>
> Give me ur thoughts on this one, it’s hard for me to write in Mydei’s pov, hence why I heavily prefer Phainon😑😑

Thanks for reading <33

What the Gods Forget

Chapter Notes

> Lowkey this is probably my least favorite chapter, but I hope you guys still enjoy it.
>
> This wasn't really planned in my original script so I had to improvise everything and basically bullshit it
>
> Also how do you guys feel about a sports au Phaidei fic? Totally not asking this to see if I should finish writing my draft😢

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The night was quiet, heavy with the unspoken words of all that had transpired. Mydei sat just a little apart from Phainon, watching as his companion slowly drifted into an almost unnatural stillness. The stars above shimmered, scattered fragments of light amidst the dark canvas of the sky, but his eyes were fixed on the figure beside him, as if seeking reassurance from the constellations themselves.

The day had passed slowly, one quiet moment folding into the next as if time itself had become aware of their fragile existence. They had spoken little, but the silence between them felt full—not of awkwardness, but of shared grief. For Phainon, perhaps even more so. He had his own way of carrying pain, a quiet sorrow that often hid behind the sharpness of his words or the easy smile that came too naturally. But Mydei had seen past that mask more times than he cared to admit.

That night, as they sat under the stars, Phainon had been unusually silent. His gaze would flick to Mydei occasionally, and then back to the distant stars, as if searching for answers in their cold, distant light. It was almost as if he were waiting for something—waiting for someone to tell him it was all going to be okay. Mydei couldn't offer that kind of reassurance. Not now. Not when the world itself felt like it was tilting dangerously.

The weight of the day had finally caught up to Phainon. Mydei had been aware of the strain the events had placed on him—the death of Castorice and Anaxa, the entire city falling apart, the uncertainty hanging in the air like a storm that never quite broke. Phainon had insisted on pushing forward, as he always did, instead focusing on reassuring Mydei instead, but now, here in the stillness of the night, he had finally surrendered to the exhaustion of it all. Mydei watched as Phainon's eyelids fluttered, the tension in his shoulders easing, until at last, he slumped against Mydei's side, his breath evening out in the softest of exhales.

Phainon had fallen asleep, just like that.

At first, Mydei had tensed, instinctively pulling away from the warmth that seemed to seep into him from their proximity. The urge to distance himself, to leave this fragile moment behind, was almost overwhelming. He wasn't good at this. Not good at letting people in, not good at holding someone so close and allowing them to lean on him when he was barely standing himself. The chaos of the day still clung to him like a thick fog, and the weight of it was suffocating.

But then he exhaled, letting the moment settle around him. He didn't pull away. For once, he allowed himself to remain where he was, close to Phainon, feeling his warmth radiate through the thin layers of clothing they both wore.

There was something about the way Phainon had leaned against him, so vulnerable in his sleep. Mydei couldn't quite put his finger on it. Maybe it was the way Phainon's heart beat just a little too fast, the way he was always on the edge of breaking, despite the confidence he projected. Maybe it was the fact that Phainon would never let anyone see how fragile he was, how much of himself he buried under layers of charm and confidence, as if the world would crack him open if it saw the truth.

In that moment, Mydei allowed himself to feel something he rarely did: a strange, unexpected tenderness toward Phainon.

It wasn't that Mydei wasn't used to being alone—he had spent years living in solitude, detached from everyone and everything that mattered. He had

trained himself to be this way, to remain distant and untouchable, so that the world and its demands could never break him. But Phainon was an exception. And perhaps that was what terrified him the most.

For once, it wasn't about the city falling apart or the looming darkness that seemed to hang over their lives. It was about Phainon's heart, which Mydei feared was just as fragile as his own. He knew Phainon better than most—maybe even better than Phainon knew himself—and he could see the cracks in the other's facade. He had seen the way Phainon's eyes had softened whenever they spoke of those they had lost. He had seen the guilt, the self-blame that was written on Phainon's face when he thought no one was looking.

So Mydei stayed there, with Phainon's head resting gently against his shoulder. He let the warmth of his presence fill the space between them, just as much for Phainon as for himself. It was a small thing, really, a quiet act of support that no one else would have noticed, but to Mydei, it was everything. It was the only way he knew how to be there for the one person who had stood by him through everything, despite his own carefully built walls.

Phainon had always been the one to keep others at a distance, never fully allowing anyone to see past the surface. But Mydei had learned long ago that Phainon's smiles, his easy jokes, and his confidence were just masks. Beneath it all was someone who cared too much, who carried the weight of the world on his shoulders, even when he pretended to shrug it off.

And Mydei… well, Mydei had his own reasons for staying close, for holding Phainon as he slept. He wasn't a fool. He knew the risks involved in allowing anyone into his world. But there was something in this fragile, quiet moment that made him feel, if only for a second, like he wasn't alone in all this.

It wasn't about love—at least not in the way he had always thought about it. This wasn't some grand gesture of affection or passion. It was a quiet understanding between two people who had seen too much of the world's darkness to ignore it anymore. It was the shared understanding that they needed each other, even when they couldn't articulate why.

The sound of Phainon’s breathing, steady and even, was the only thing that broke the silence. Mydei allowed his mind to wander, to drift through the haze of memories that plagued him—the faces of those he had lost, the endless weight of duty that pressed on him every day, the constant need to maintain control over his emotions. But in this moment, in the calm of the night, he didn’t have to be in control. He didn’t have to be the cold, distant observer.

For just a few hours, he could let himself feel something.

He glanced down at Phainon, who had curled up even further, now resting with his head tucked beneath Mydei’s arm. His face was relaxed, free from the mask he always wore, and for a moment, Mydei thought he could almost see what Phainon might look like without the weight of the world pressing down on him. It was a soft, vulnerable expression, and something deep inside Mydei stirred in response to it.

After a while, Phainon shifted slightly, his breath warm against Mydei’s skin, as he murmured something unintelligible in his sleep. Mydei froze for a moment, the words lingering in the air as if trying to make sense of them. He had never been one for lingering on the quiet moments—always too preoccupied with the noise of the world—but tonight, something about the stillness felt different. It was as though the world had momentarily paused, allowing them both a breath to themselves.

Then, just as suddenly as it had begun, Phainon’s eyes opened, their usual clarity slowly returning, though there was a softness to them. They met Mydei’s gaze, and for a brief instant, Mydei was unsure what to do with the intensity in them.

“I didn’t mean to doze off,” Phainon said, his voice rough but warm, offering a sleepy smile. “You should have woken me.”

Mydei shook his head, his gaze softening as he looked at Phainon. “It’s fine,” he replied, voice quieter than usual. “You needed the rest. You’ve been running on empty.”

Phainon’s smile faltered for just a moment, replaced by something more solemn, as if he too understood the weight they both carried. “We all need rest sometimes,” he murmured, eyes slipping closed again for just a second before he looked back up at Mydei. “Even you.”

There was something unspoken in those words, a recognition of the quiet struggle that both of them carried—one that never seemed to let up. Mydei didn’t respond, but he didn’t need to. He simply nodded, letting the quiet of the night settle around them once more.

As Phainon curled a little closer, his head resting just below Mydei’s shoulder again, Mydei allowed himself to breathe in the warmth of his presence. Despite everything—despite the chaos, the looming uncertainty—there was comfort here. For just a moment, they didn’t have to be the leaders, the ones everyone looked to for answers. They could just be.

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Morning came slowly, sunlight bleeding through the cracks of the city like golden ichor, too soft for the weight pressing on Mydei’s chest. He had left before Phainon stirred, slipping away as the dawn stretched thin across the sky. He wasn’t sure why he hadn’t lingered—why he hadn’t let himself stay in that rare moment of warmth—but something restless clawed at the edges of his thoughts, urging him forward.

It had been the first time in too long that he’d slept without dreams.

No visions, no echoes of blood-slicked stone, no whispers of something watching him from the dark. He hadn’t even realized it at first, only noting the strange clarity in his head as he walked through the quiet streets of Okhema. It should have been a relief. It was a relief. But instead of comfort, a gnawing unease settled in its place.

Because the dreams had stopped the moment he’d been with Phainon.

He exhaled sharply, trying to shake the thought, but it clung to him like damp cloth, an itch he couldn’t scratch. His nightmares had plagued him for as long as he could remember, creeping into his sleep like an inevitability. They weren’t just visions—they were warnings, signs of something unraveling, glimpses of things that had happened and things that would happen. He had long since stopped questioning why he saw them. He only knew that they had never stopped.

Until now.

His fingers curled at his sides as he walked, brows furrowing. It had to be coincidence. Maybe exhaustion had finally claimed him. Maybe—just maybe —his body had given him a mercy for once. But the timing was too precise. Phainon, always Phainon, lingering at the edges of things he couldn’t explain.

He shook his head, pushing the thought away. He didn’t have the energy to unravel that mess right now. There was already too much shifting beneath his feet.

The city stirred around him, its heartbeat slower than usual, weighted by the grief and uncertainty that had been plaguing Okhema. Murmurs followed him through the streets, hushed voices curling at his back, the weight of their suspicion thick in the air. He ignored them. Let them talk. He had no patience to ease their wariness when there was something far more pressing twisting in his gut.

Something was wrong.

He felt it before he understood it, a slow, creeping dread curling in his stomach, dragging his steps in a direction he hadn’t intended. The streets blurred past him, shifting between the familiar and the unknown, until his feet carried him somewhere he hadn’t meant to go—

An old alleyway, tucked between the ruins of a collapsed building and a disused path leading toward the outskirts. The air smelled of stone and dust, of damp earth and something sharp beneath it. The place was empty,

forgotten, but something about it set his nerves on edge. His heartbeat quickened, his breath coming shallow.

It was quiet.

Too quiet.

His fingers twitched at his sides, instinct flaring in his veins as his gaze swept the area. There was nothing here. No signs of struggle, no remnants of anything wrong , but the feeling wouldn't leave him. His skin prickled, a slow unease washing over him as he turned his head—

And saw it.

A mark, barely visible against the worn stone wall. Small, subtle, almost imperceptible. It wasn't fresh, but it wasn't old either—something carefully left behind, meant to be seen by those who knew where to look.

His breath hitched as he stepped closer, his heart stuttering in his chest.

A symbol. Janus's symbol.

Deliberate. Familiar.

His pulse roared in his ears. *Tribbie*.

She had been here.

And she had left this for *him*.

His fingers ghosted over the carving, his body stilling as the weight of the realization settled deep in his bones.

Tribbie was meticulous. If she had left a message, it wasn't by accident.

It wasn't for anyone else.

It was a warning.

His breath came sharp, the air suddenly too thin. The world around him blurred, narrowing down to the faint indentation on the stone, to the proof that she had been here—alive, thinking, *leaving a message —*

And yet, she was nowhere to be found.

A slow, cold dread crept up his spine.

Where *was* she?

He traced the symbol with his fingertips, his mind working through a dozen possibilities. Had she been in danger? Had she been watching someone? *Had someone been watching her?* The thought sent a sharp pulse through his chest, panic curling at the edges of his ribs.

She had always been careful. Always a step ahead, always knowing things before they happened. But if she had felt the need to leave something behind—if *she* had thought there was a risk she wouldn't be able to tell him in person—

Then whatever had happened had come fast.

Too fast.

The silence around him pressed in, suffocating.

And for the first time since the dreams had stopped, Mydei wished they would return.

Because he had a terrible, sinking feeling that they would have already told him what he was about to find.

He exhaled slowly, forcing his pulse to steady. *Think.*

The symbol was clear—left behind on purpose, meant to be found. If Tribbie had taken the time to carve it, it meant she hadn't been taken by surprise. She had seen something, realized something, and left this behind as a precaution. *That meant she was still alive when she made it*.

His fingers curled into a fist as he forced himself to hold onto that thought.

She wouldn't have left this without reason. So what was the reason?

If she had been in immediate danger, she wouldn't have wasted time on subtlety. A hastily scratched warning, blood on the wall, *something* more urgent—she would have made sure whoever found it *knew* to act fast. But this was calculated, deliberate. It wasn't meant to set off alarms; it was meant to be a breadcrumb.

Which meant she had expected to have some control over her situation.

That, or she had expected *him* to figure it out in time.

He ground his teeth, mind racing. He needed to act fast, but recklessly throwing himself into something unknown would do nothing but get him caught in the same trap. If he was right, and Tribbie was still alive somewhere, then his next move had to be exact.

First—what did he already know?

1. Tribbie had been here. Recently.

2. She had left this mark intentionally.

3. There were no obvious signs of struggle.

4. She was nowhere to be found.

That left a few immediate possibilities. Either she had hidden herself away and left this as a message, or someone had taken her, and she had left this as a *trail* .

Neither option was good.

His jaw tightened. *Then what's the next move?*

Find where she went.

This was only the first clue. If she had time to leave a message, she likely had time to leave *another* . He just had to figure out where she would go next.

He stepped back from the wall, scanning the alleyway, his mind already mapping out the most likely routes she could have taken from here. The path leading to the outskirts? Risky, too open. She would have stayed close to the denser parts of the city, where there were more places to hide.

His eyes landed on a set of uneven cobblestones leading into a narrower alley, half-covered in shadow.

There.

It wasn't much, but it was the only direction that made sense. If Tribbie had been running, she wouldn't have gone *outward* . She would have stayed where she could blend in, where she could keep moving unseen.

He inhaled sharply.

One step at a time. No rushing, no reckless decisions.

He *would* find her.

He *had* to.

And if someone had taken her—

Then he was going to make them regret it.

The deeper Mydei moved into the city's forgotten veins, the more the air thickened, pressing against him like a silent warning. It was late—too late for him to be walking alone like this—but he didn't stop.

The streets were empty. No lanterns flickering in windows, no voices echoing between stone walls. Even the city's distant hum had dulled to nothing.

Too quiet.

Still, he pressed forward, following the faint disturbances in the dust, the marks left by someone moving in haste. He wasn't imagining them—these were real, leading him deeper into the alleys.

Then—blood.

His breath caught. A smear against the wall, a streak across the ground. Small at first, then more.

A *trail*.

His hands clenched.

Move.

His feet carried him forward before his mind could catch up. The walls narrowed, closing in. His pulse drummed against his skull.

Then he saw them.

The bodies.

Three of them, laid out side by side.

Too neat.

Too still.

His breath locked in his throat. He took a step closer—

They were wrong.

At first, it was subtle. The way Castorice's limbs bent just slightly *off*, like his joints had been twisted too far before rigor mortis could settle in. The way Anaxa's throat gaped *too wide*, dark and glistening, like something had *torn it* open instead of slicing clean.

Tribbie was the worst.

She was *watching him*.

Not staring—her head had tilted, ever so slightly, toward him. Her lips parted, just a fraction, like she was about to speak.

Mydei's stomach twisted violently.

The air *rippled*.

A sound—wet and *wrong*.

Anaxa's arm moved.

He choked back a breath, stumbling backward—

His fingers *snapped* into motion, clawing at the stone like a marionette yanked upright. Castorice followed, his limbs jerking with sick, unnatural clicks.

Then, Tribbie.

Her lips stretched, curling into something that was almost a grin.

" Found you."

Mydei's body locked. His lungs squeezed, refusing to pull in air.

Anaxa *lurched* , half-rising, a guttural noise tearing from what remained of his throat. Blood bubbled from his mouth as his body *twisted inward* , his ribs bending the wrong way, snapping sharp through his skin like jagged teeth.

Castorice convulsed, her chest splitting open in a wet, *awful* sound. A hand —her own—crawled out of the wound, fingers twitching, nails digging into the muscle as if trying to *pull herself apart.*

Tribbie just laughed.

Something gripped Mydei's ankle.

His mind shattered into instinct, *move, move, damn it move,* but the second he tried to wrench away, they were on him.

Hands—too many hands—grabbing, clawing, *tearing*.

Anaxa's shattered ribs pierced through his side, burying into his flesh like a serrated maw. Castorice's twisted limbs wrapped around his own, locking him in place as her nails sank into Mydei's skin, peeling it back like delicate parchment.

Tribbie was at his throat.

Close enough to whisper.

" I told you you'd die for us. "

Pain.

Sharp, searing *pain* , driving straight into his chest.

His breath left him in a choked, gurgling gasp.

His body convulsed. The world tilted.

Then—

A flicker.

A shift.

A sound.

Like static snapping in the back of his skull.

The pain *vanished*.

He was standing.

Alone.

No bodies. No blood.

Just silence.

His entire body was trembling. His hands were clutching his sides, expecting to feel ribs piercing through, but there was nothing. No wounds. No torn flesh.

Just sweat. Just his own shuddering breaths.

And then—

His eyes caught it.

Scratched into the stone at his feet.

A message.

Short. Haphazard.

Written in *her* hand.

His stomach lurched.

The words weren't normal. They were just like before, just like the ones in his dreams—cryptic, twisting in his mind the longer he looked at them.

But this was real.

Tribbie had been *here*.

He knelt, running his fingers over the etchings, his breath still uneven.

The words didn't make sense. Not yet.

But he was going to *figure it out.*

Because now, *he knew.*

This wasn’t just murder.

It wasn’t just coincidence.

Something was wrong with the world itself.

someone—something—had just made sure *he knew it.*

The etchings burned behind his eyes.

Even after he had turned away, even as his feet carried him forward, he could still see them. The way the letters dug unevenly into the stone, the pressure growing desperate toward the end, as if the writer had known they were running out of time.

He swallowed hard.

There were more. There *had* to be more.

Tribbie wouldn’t have left a single clue. She wouldn’t have counted on him to understand right away.

So he followed.

At first, it was walking.

His steps were steady, deliberate. His eyes swept over every surface, every shadow, his fingers trailing against stone as if he could feel the next clue before he saw it.

Then—another.

This one wasn’t written. It was carved—deep, sharp, frantic—into the wooden frame of a narrow doorway.

Three lines.

The middle one slashed through like a blade had cut it in two.

Something about it made his stomach twist.

He moved faster.

Down an alley. Another mark—this one in chalk, half-smudged, but *pointing* toward a turn in the street.

His heart picked up. His breath felt shallower.

His walk became a brisk pace.

Another symbol.

This one looked hastily drawn, uneven as if someone had been *shaking* when they made it.

He barely processed it before he was *striding* ahead, scanning every wall, every street corner, his fingers flexing at his sides.

Another. This time *blood*.

Small—just a smear on the stone—but unmistakable.

Something sharp jolted in his ribs.

He was *jogging* now.

The city blurred around him, the tight corridors winding in ways that should have been *familiar*, but he barely registered them. His pulse was too loud. His breath too short.

More signs. More symbols.

All leading *somewhere*.

She's leading me somewhere.

His stomach twisted tighter.

Then—

The scent hit him.

Metallic. Faint but thick —lingering in the air like something had seeped into the very stone.

His chest clenched. His legs moved before he could think.

His jog turned to a *sprint*.

Faster.

Faster.

Faster.

The smell grew stronger. The air felt heavier.

His stomach dropped.

The alley stretched ahead, long and dark. Something in his gut screamed at him to stop, but he couldn’t.

He couldn’t.

He *ran*.

Then—

The ground ended.

An open space.

The scent was *everywhere*.

He saw them.

And stopped breathing.

His whole body locked, his muscles snapping taut like he’d hit an invisible wall.

There, crumpled beneath the dim light of a shattered lantern—

The Tribios.

Still. Silent. *Fresh.*

His lungs wouldn’t expand. His ribs ached with the force of how hard his heart was beating.

Too still.

Too silent.

This wasn’t a crime scene long since abandoned.

This had just happened.

A moment ago.

Maybe minutes.

His head spun. His fingers *twitched*.

Then—

A drip.

A slow, heavy drop of blood from above, splattering softly against the stone beside his foot.

Still wet.

Still warm.

Something deep inside him *fractured*.

The drip continued.

It fell slowly, in heavy, grotesque splatters that broke the silence. And then, the rest of the world fell away— paused, almost—as his eyes darted from the darkness above to the bodies before him.

The bodies.

Tribbie.

Her limbs hung from the low beam above, suspended in midair like a grotesque puppet. The blood didn't drip from her body—it *poured* — raining from the jagged wound that slashed through her throat, staining her clothes and pooling beneath her feet.

But the worst part wasn't the blood.

It was her face.

The stillness in her expression. The eyes—half-lidded, frozen in place—*staring* at him as if begging, even in death, for him to *do something*.

But it wasn't her face that made his stomach twist.

No, it was the bodies that surrounded her, scattered in pieces like dolls carelessly discarded after their use.

Trianne.

Her arms splayed out from where they had been torn at the joints, her fingers stretched wide in impossible angles, hands twisted in strange postures.

Trinnon.

Her body was almost entirely dismembered, with only the remains of her torso left intact. Her legs—once proud and strong—had been severed clean at the knee.

And their heads.

Together.

Side by side.

Their eyes staring at each other in a grotesque, unnatural calm that felt far too intimate. Too close.

He couldn’t move.

He couldn’t breathe.

He stood there—frozen.

The scene felt *wrong*.

Everything *wrong*.

The whole world seemed to be suffocating him. The stench of blood, thick and choking. The weight of the bodies, unreal, like they didn’t belong in this space, like they were never meant to be this close to him.

His feet felt as though they were sinking into the stone, rooted in place. He should have moved, but the moment was too much.

Too much to take in. Too much to understand.

He could have stopped this.

The thought came like a bolt to his chest, raw and jagged, cutting through his calm facade.

If he had just… *been faster.*

If he had just *seen it coming.*

If he hadn’t spent the night— spent all that time with Phainon, comforting him, keeping him safe when the real danger was in the city, right here in

front of him—he could've—

He could've stopped this.

The thought clawed at him, scraping away at the walls he had built, but it didn't matter. His hands felt numb. His chest ached. His mind was a swirling mess of what-ifs, the burden of failing crushing down on him.

He couldn't breathe.

He couldn't move.

The blood. The bodies. The shattered bodies.

Why hadn't he seen this before?

He stood there, looking at the carnage, his whole body stiff. He didn't hear anything except his own breath—shallow, ragged, painful in his chest.

How could he have let this happen?

How could he have let this happen?

The question spun around in his mind like a broken record, playing over and over, growing louder with each passing second. His throat felt tight, like it was being squeezed. His stomach lurched, threatening to send him into a spiral of nausea, but he didn't move.

He just stood there.

Frozen.

The drip of blood was the only sound now, steady, relentless.

The world was a blur, spinning too fast around him. He couldn't make sense of it, couldn't gather himself long enough to act.

Until—

A voice.

Not a real voice.

An echo, like a distant memory.

You were supposed to protect them.

His chest constricted.

I should have protected them.

His eyes closed, tight, as if somehow the act of shutting them could block out the grisly reality before him. But it didn’t. The images stayed, burned into the backs of his eyelids. The blood. The bodies. Tribbie’s still face.

His legs trembled.

The tightness in his throat swelled, and he stumbled back— away from the bodies, away from the blood, away from the unbearable weight of what he had failed to do.

A wrong step.

His feet caught. He tripped.

He fell.

For a moment, he was just falling, his body too numb to feel the ground beneath him. His hands reached out in a futile attempt to catch himself, but he didn’t feel the stone, the dirt, the blood—it was as if everything around him had been swallowed up by the same suffocating horror.

When he hit the ground, he didn’t immediately rise.

He just stayed there.

Eyes open.

Staring at the carnage, at the dismembered bodies.

And as the reality of what had happened set in, so too did the icy truth.

He was the one who had failed them.

And now—now they were gone.

Gone forever.

Mydei's fingers trembled as he reached forward, pressing them into the blood-slicked remains of Trinnon's dismembered arm. The cold, sticky feeling of skin—*alive* just hours ago—was wrong. His mind couldn't make sense of it. How could something so… so human now feel so *alien*? It wasn't skin anymore. Not flesh. It was just *meat* —cold, detached from anything that once had meaning. Like an animal carcass, slaughtered and left to rot in an alleyway, forgotten and discarded.

This isn't them. This isn't them anymore.

He tried to push the thought away, but it clung to him like the blood soaking through his clothes. The flesh under his fingers, no longer holding any semblance of its former self, felt lifeless. The smell of iron and decay hung in the air. Mydei willed his body not to recoil, not to pull away, but the bile rose in his throat as he pressed on, the dismembered limbs slipping under his hands, more detached than ever.

He gripped another piece—Trinon's torso this time—its once-lively form reduced to a mangled mess of broken bones and shredded skin. The stomach had been torn open, the entrails spilling out like something discarded from the butcher's table. The whole body, an abomination, nothing but a shell now. He almost couldn't bring himself to touch it, but he had no choice. He needed to know. He needed to see . What had happened here?

With a wrenching, gut-twisting motion, Mydei shoved aside a severed leg, his stomach flipping as he felt the skin squish under his palm. It was like touching an animal— flesh, unworthy of humanity, just meat now. He

couldn’t focus. The stench, the texture of it all—this was no longer his friend, his ally, his fellow Tribios. There was no trace of their souls here. Just—

Meat.

The thought ran in a maddening loop, spiraling him deeper into the madness. He forced his fingers to slide across the bodies, desperately, feverishly, searching for something. Anything. His hands were slick with blood, and his heart was pounding so hard, it felt like it might burst from his chest.

He saw it.

A flash.

A distortion.

A crack in time.

His vision wavered, and his breath caught in his throat. He saw them—alive .

Trionne, Tribbie, Trianne. Their faces, alive, full of life . Laughing. Smiling. Existing . And then—

Then it all went wrong.

He saw it. Every detail. Every brutal second.

A figure— a shadow —looming over them, a sword raised high in the air. He couldn’t see the killer’s face, but he saw their hands—black, gnarled hands, slick with blood. They had been quick. Too quick. They attacked without hesitation, without mercy.

The blade came down in a blur of motion, plunging into Trinnon’s side. He heard the sickening crack of ribs breaking, the wet gurgle of blood as it spilled from Trinnon’s mouth. Trinnie screamed, a desperate, piercing

sound that was swallowed by the blade tearing through her. Her body jerked and spasmed, but there was no escape.

Then, Tribbie—Tribbie had screamed. Her body, cut open, her blood staining the ground, her eyes wide with terror as her breath came in short, panicked gasps. Her arms flailing, desperately trying to ward off the invisible assailant. Her mouth opening, trying to call for help—but the sound was drowned by the blade that had already plunged into her chest.

And Trianne—oh, Trianne.

Her body had been tossed aside like a ragdoll. She was the last. She barely had time to scream. Only an incoherent gasp escaped her lips before she was butchered, cut down like an animal. There was no mercy, no hesitation. The killer was relentless, each slash sending blood spraying into the air, painting the walls and the floor with crimson.

And just as the killer's hand was poised to bring the final strike down on her, Mydei— he saw it all —felt it in his gut, the sheer horror of knowing, of realizing too late, of being utterly powerless to stop it. He could do nothing. He hadn't been there. He hadn't been fast enough.

And just before he could see the killer's face—before the identity was revealed, the truth of it—the distortion stopped.

It vanished.

Everything stopped.

Mydei's breath caught in his throat, his mind reeling as he stumbled back, shaking uncontrollably. His vision snapped back to the blood-soaked room, his hands still trembling as he stared at the bodies—their broken, desecrated forms. He felt the rage surge in him like an unstoppable tide, rising from deep within. He could feel the heat in his chest, the fire in his veins, and then—

He punched the ground.

The impact was brutal. The force of his fist against the cold, hard floor made the ground give beneath him. He felt his knuckles crack under the strain, felt the bone grind against bone. Blood poured from his hand as he dug it deeper into the stone, his vision swimming in the red mist of his own fury.

This is your fault. This is your fault.

The words whispered in his mind, but he couldn't let himself say them out loud. He was choking on the bitterness, on the disgust of it all. He had failed them. He had failed them, and now it was too late. He couldn't change it. The killer was still out there, somewhere. The person who had torn his world apart.

The rage was unbearable. It tore through him, savage and untamed. Mydei's breath came in sharp, ragged gasps, and for the first time in his life, he felt like he was drowning—not in water—but in rage . He couldn't think. He couldn't see straight. His body burned with the need for revenge, for justice. For them.

His fist hit the ground again, harder this time, his knuckles cracking once more as he hit the stone with everything he had left in him. The pain surged up his arm, but it didn't matter. Nothing mattered but finding the one responsible, the one who had destroyed everything.

Nothing would stop him.

He would hunt them down. He would destroy them.

He would make them *pay*.

And as the pain in his fist subsided, as his breathing slowed, he understood one thing, one thing above all else:

He would *kill* them.

Whoever it was. Whoever dared to hurt his family, his people. The Tribios.

They would *die*.

He couldn’t stop the vision. He couldn’t stop the time distortion. But his body, his mind—they were caught in the aftermath. Mydei barely registered the blood that smeared across him, the way it clung to his clothing, how it soaked his hair. It didn’t matter. He barely noticed how the scent of iron and decay lingered in the air like a suffocating blanket. All he could feel was the anger burning in his chest, consuming everything.

He didn’t even hear the footsteps at first. Not until the sound grew louder, the echo of boots on stone.

A figure appeared in the doorway—a soldier? A civilian? A child? Mydei didn’t care. They were a blur, just another person, just another witness to the horror that had been left in the wake of the Tribios’s slaughter. Their eyes locked onto him—covered in blood, standing amidst the dismembered corpses of the Tribios—and then—

They *screamed*.

The sound was high-pitched, a frantic, panicked cry that tore through the air like a knife. They staggered backward, hands flying to their mouth as they stumbled and fell, their face contorted in pure, unadulterated terror.

Mydei didn’t even flinch.

He didn’t try to stop them. Didn’t try to explain. Didn’t try to calm them down or give some half-hearted excuse for why he was there, drenched in blood, surrounded by the brutalized bodies of the Tribios. It didn’t matter.

All that mattered was the rage. The cold fury that was still bubbling, that was still rising inside him.

He let the figure scream. Let them run.

His eyes remained fixed on the ground in front of him, on the broken bodies, on the mess of blood and shattered flesh that had once been his family, his comrades. The only sound he could hear now was the pounding of his own heart—each beat a drum in his chest, each thump a reminder of his failure.

The figure turned and ran.

Mydei didn’t chase. He didn’t try to stop them. There was no point. It was too late. They had seen it. They had seen him—the monster he was becoming. There was no going back from this.

He closed his eyes for a moment, letting the cold rush over him. His fingers twitched, and blood dripped from them onto the cold floor. He didn’t care.

Everything was gone. He had lost everything. And now the world would see him for what he really was.

The monster.

The murderer.

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The rumors swirling around Mydei only grew more vicious with time. Whispers followed him in the street, eyes full of suspicion. It didn’t matter to him anymore. The accusations were hollow. Mydei had learned, long ago, to push the noise away, but even now, when all of Okhema seemed to be against him, he couldn’t shake the gnawing anger.

There were four things that kept him from being torn apart, literally and figuratively. The first was that, despite everything, he couldn’t die. Immortality was a gift—and a curse—he had grown to accept, though it did little to ease his pain. The second: he was an heir, and Okhema had no other choice but to keep him alive, despite the evidence against him. Third was Aglaea, whose influence had proven invaluable in keeping him out of immediate danger. She fought tooth and nail for him, a silent defender even when it put her own position at risk. And lastly, there was Phainon—his words a desperate plea that left Mydei numb with rage and guilt.

Phainon had threatened to end it all if anyone dared harm Mydei. The words hung in the air like an ultimatum, and though Mydei didn’t need saving, the idea of Phainon suffering for him ignited something ferocious inside. Mydei had given Phainon a brutal thrashing for even thinking of such a thing—how could he ever make such a sacrifice? Yet Phainon had only looked at him with those same unwavering eyes, his emotions buried beneath a shield of devotion.

Now, Mydei continued, not out of necessity but because he had no other choice. Time marched on, and so did he.

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Mydei sat alone, hidden in the darkness, a secluded corner of Okhema that felt far removed from the chaos of the world. The stars above stretched endlessly, but his focus was on a single constellation: Kephale. The one that had begun it all. The first seed of the storm that had thrown his life into this unrelenting spiral. The events that followed felt like a dream, a nightmare, and now, they weighed on him like a crushing force.

He was tired. Too tired. Physically, mentally—he couldn’t summon the energy to feel anything anymore, let alone rage or guilt. The nightmare of the Tribios’s death played on a loop in his mind, and the only thing that kept him from falling apart completely was the cold, steady silence of the night.

But then, a sound. Soft footsteps, a familiar presence. His gaze shifted, but he didn’t move. He didn’t have the strength to. Phainon, the last person he expected to find him in this moment of despair, appeared on the edge of the roof, his figure silhouetted against the starlight.

Phainon waved, a gesture so simple and quiet that Mydei felt the weight of it more than any forceful attempt at comforting words. For a few moments, Phainon didn’t speak, just climbed up beside him with his usual grace, settling in without any fanfare.

“Hey,” Phainon’s voice broke the silence, so soft, so hesitant, it almost didn’t feel real.

The words hung between them like a fragile bridge, and for the first time in what felt like forever, Mydei allowed himself to acknowledge the presence next to him. He could feel the cracks in his hard shell, the walls he’d built after Tribbie’s death, starting to form, crumble. He didn’t look at Phainon, couldn’t—afraid of what he might see. Instead, he focused on the sky. Kephale, still burning bright in the night.

For what felt like an eternity, they sat there, neither speaking. Just the quiet hum of the world around them. The weight of the past pressing down on Mydei, but for the first time in what felt like forever, it wasn’t suffocating.

Kephale had been the start of everything, but Mydei felt nothing now. No anger, no vengeance—just an emptiness that had consumed him. He hadn’t known how to keep going, but Phainon’s presence, without needing to say anything, had somehow offered him the smallest sliver of peace. It was strange, unsettling even. But for now, it was enough.

Mydei didn’t speak. Not yet. Not while the quiet stretched between them, while the constellations watched from above. The quiet was just as much a comfort as it was a prison.

And in that stillness, Mydei couldn’t help but feel the unbearable pressure of everything that had been lost.

The silence between them was thick, but it was a kind of silence that felt almost necessary. Phainon sat next to Mydei, close enough that he could feel the subtle weight of his presence, but Mydei was still trapped in his own thoughts. His gaze remained fixed on Kephale, and though he wanted to retreat further into his mind, there was something about Phainon being there that kept him anchored, even if he didn’t want to admit it.

After what felt like an eternity of quiet, Phainon moved. His hand gently brushed Mydei’s cheek, the touch so light, so tender, that it startled him. Mydei stiffened, not expecting the contact. Phainon’s thumb traced the curve of his face as he spoke, his voice soft but with an undercurrent of

something more—a kind of pleading Mydei hadn’t expected. “Don’t cry, please.”

The words hit him like a punch to the gut. Something in him—something he hadn’t even known was there—shifted. It was ridiculous. He wasn’t weak. He couldn’t be. He couldn’t afford to be. His face burned with a sudden heat, and his heart stuttered in his chest. The very last thing he wanted was for Phainon to see him like this, exposed in some way he couldn’t control.

Without thinking, Mydei shoved Phainon’s hand away. His voice came out more forceful than he intended. “I’m not weak,” he muttered, refusing to look at him.

Phainon didn’t immediately respond. For a long moment, Mydei’s heart pounded in his ears as he tried to steady his breath, his thoughts in disarray. Phainon hesitated, his gaze lingering on Mydei before he slowly began to get up, perhaps sensing that the space between them needed to be respected.

But as Phainon moved to leave, something inside Mydei snapped. Fear, paranoia—he couldn’t tell. He couldn’t let Phainon leave. Not now. Not after everything that had happened.

In a single, fluid motion, Mydei grabbed Phainon’s hand, his grip tighter than intended. He didn’t care. He couldn’t let him go. He didn’t trust that the world would let him have anything—anyone—left.

Phainon turned to face him, an unreadable expression on his face, but Mydei didn’t look at him. He couldn’t. He was afraid of what he’d see in Phainon’s eyes, and even more afraid of what he might find in his own heart.

“Come with me,” Mydei said, his voice quieter now. It wasn’t a question. It wasn’t even a request. He didn’t want to be alone. Not anymore. Not with everything that was happening.

Phainon didn’t say anything right away, but after a moment, he simply nodded, as if he understood more than he could put into words. Mydei

pulled him along, silent and unsteady, but with a certainty he couldn't explain.

As they walked, the world seemed to shift. The tension between them hung thick in the air. But for once, Mydei didn't care. For once, he wasn't thinking about the consequences. He just needed Phainon there—beside him, next to him. Even if he couldn't protect himself, maybe, just maybe, he could protect Phainon.

And for a moment, everything else faded.

Hey," Phainon said, breaking the silence. "You know, when this whole mess is over, I think we should get out of here for a while. Just… go somewhere quiet, far from all this." His voice was light, but there was something deeper behind it, an undercurrent of care. "Maybe the southern coast. I heard it's peaceful there. Sunsets are supposed to be incredible."

Mydei glanced over at him, surprised by the sudden shift in tone. Phainon was trying to steer the conversation away from all the chaos, trying to keep things light. It was almost like Phainon couldn't stand seeing him this way—distant, consumed by anger and, well for lack of a better word—tired. So tired.

Phainon continued, his voice steady. "I bet you'd look good in the sunlight there. Maybe even smile."

Mydei found his lips quirking up at that, a fleeting thought that vanished as quickly as it came. He didn't know why Phainon had to talk about something like that, but he didn't mind. Maybe it was nice to think of something—anything—besides the endless turmoil surrounding them.

"Maybe," Mydei said softly, though he wasn't quite sure he could ever feel at peace again. Not after everything.

The conversation drifted after that, with Phainon bringing up lighter topics—places they could visit, odd places he'd heard of, food he'd tried that Mydei probably wouldn't touch. For once, Mydei didn't resist. He let

Phainon’s words wash over him, distracting him from the ever-looming dread that haunted his every step.

Phainon looked over at Mydei, his voice casual, though laced with a subtle curiosity. “So, where’s your earring?”

Mydei shifted slightly, feeling the absence where it once hung. He didn’t respond right away, his eyes flicking downward, as if the answer was suddenly heavy. Then, after a pause, he sighed, a mixture of resignation and indifference in his tone. “It was stolen.”

Phainon’s gaze softened, but a quiet question hung in the air. “How? You didn’t just… lose it, did you?”

Mydei hesitated for a moment, then finally spoke again, his words flowing out as if they didn’t matter to him at all. “I let it happen.”

The words hit the air like a stone dropped into still water, and for a moment, the world itself seemed to freeze. Phainon’s eyes locked onto Mydei with a stillness that made everything else feel distant. His gaze, once soft and understanding, now darkened for just a fraction of a second—sharp, like a knife being drawn from its sheath.

Mydei felt it—felt the shift in the air, the weight of the silence hanging between them. For that split second, Phainon’s usual composure faltered, and something deeply unsettling passed between them, something raw and almost dangerous.

Phainon’s fingers twitched just slightly, and Mydei’s stomach tightened, like a knot being pulled. He couldn’t pinpoint why, but the atmosphere around them suddenly felt much colder, sharper. Phainon didn’t say anything, but Mydei could feel the unspoken question hanging in the air—Why?

Then, as quickly as it happened, Phainon’s expression softened again, returning to its usual calm. He nodded, as if he hadn’t just looked into something dangerous, something dark inside of Mydei. “I see,” Phainon murmured, his tone gentle, almost soothing. “You did what you had to.”

But Mydei could feel it—the way the air had shifted, the fleeting darkness in Phainon's eyes that he couldn't quite forget. It was like a shadow lingering, just out of sight. The normalcy returned too quickly, too smoothly, but something in Mydei felt disturbed by the moment, as if it had cracked open something he wasn't prepared to face.

Phainon continued as if nothing had changed, his voice light as he casually shifted the topic. "So, anyway, I heard the new shipments arrived in the market today. What do you think of the fabrics they brought in?"

Mydei could barely focus on the words, his mind lingering on that brief, intense moment. He wasn't sure if it was Phainon's gaze or his own internal storm, but something had changed. It wasn't just about the earring anymore —it was about the way things could change so quickly between them.

And as Phainon spoke, Mydei couldn't shake the feeling that, for a second, he'd seen too much.

Phainon had noticed his silence, his tiredness, his eyes scanning Mydei's face as if trying to read him. The softness in his voice broke through the haze. "You've been going for days, haven't you?" Phainon said, his tone quiet, but there was no mistaking the concern there.

Mydei didn't answer right away, only looking away, his gaze lingering on the distant horizon. His jaw tightened. The truth was, he hadn't slept in days, not since the Tribios's deaths. Not since the nightmares had started. Not since everything had fallen apart.

He had tried to keep going, pretending he was fine, but he wasn't. Not anymore.

Phainon shifted beside him, noticing the subtle shift in his posture. "You should rest, Mydei."

"I can't." The words slipped out before Mydei could stop them, and he immediately regretted it, his throat going dry. He didn't want to sound like a child, but the exhaustion—no, the desperation —seeped into his words. "I can't… I need…" He trailed off, but Phainon didn't push him to finish.

The silence stretched, and for a long moment, Mydei didn’t speak. Then, something inside him cracked. He didn’t want to admit it. He didn’t want to ask for something so… childish. But the words slipped out before he could stop them.

“Phainon,” Mydei started, his voice barely audible, “will you… will you stay with me tonight?”

He immediately regretted it. His cheeks flushed with embarrassment, and he immediately looked away, as if the words hadn’t even left his mouth. He felt stupid, childish, weak. He could feel his heart racing, his skin burning with shame. He wasn’t supposed to need anyone. Not like this.

For a long moment, he didn’t hear anything, only the distant sounds of the city below, the wind brushing through the trees. He almost thought Phainon hadn’t heard him. Or worse, that he’d laugh or brush it off as some whim Mydei would forget about in a second.

But then, Phainon’s hand gently touched his shoulder, a quiet, steadying presence. “You don’t need to be ashamed of that,” Phainon said, his voice soft but grounded, filled with an understanding that Mydei couldn’t quite grasp. “You don’t have to do this alone.”

The words made something inside Mydei snap—a sharp ache in his chest that he couldn’t explain. He felt something twist, something he didn’t want to acknowledge.

“I’m not weak,” Mydei muttered quickly, looking away. “I just… I just thought you might—”

He stopped himself, his words getting caught in his throat. He felt embarrassed, stupid, and so incredibly small in that moment. He wanted to take it back, wanted to bury the request somewhere deep and pretend it had never happened.

But before he could do anything else, Phainon gave a small, knowing smile. “You don’t have to explain yourself to me.”

Mydei’s chest tightened. His face burned. It didn’t matter how many times Phainon had said something like that before—it still felt like a weight was pressing down on him.

And yet, before Mydei could speak again, Phainon stood up, turning toward him with a small, reassuring smile that wasn’t soft or too understanding. It was gentle. “Come on. Let’s go.”

Mydei opened his mouth to protest, to maybe back out of it, but the words died on his tongue. Something inside him—something deep, something he hadn’t realized—made him reach out. His hand brushed against Phainon’s arm, hesitating for a moment before he spoke.

“Don’t leave me tonight,” Mydei said, his voice quieter now, barely a whisper.

Phainon turned back to him, his expression steady, his eyes soft. “I’m not going anywhere.”

Without waiting for a response, Phainon reached out, taking Mydei’s hand in his. Mydei didn’t pull away. He didn’t want to. He followed Phainon, not saying anything else, not wanting to say anything else.

But as they moved together, Mydei couldn’t shake the feeling that something had shifted. He had asked for something, and Phainon had given it freely. It wasn’t weakness. It wasn’t childish. It was… just necessary.

If his heart started beating faster after that, no one needed to know.

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The first light of morning pierced through the curtains, casting soft beams across the room. Mydei’s eyes fluttered open, a weight on his chest that had nothing to do with sleep. He blinked, confused for a moment, before his gaze settled on the familiar figure beside him—Phainon, still asleep, his

features soft in the gentle morning light. There was a quiet warmth in the room, a strange, unspoken peace that felt almost fragile, like it could shatter if Mydei so much as breathed too loudly.

Last night felt distant already. The dreams had stopped the moment Phainon had fallen asleep beside him. It wasn't just the absence of nightmares. It was the absence of everything —the weight of his responsibilities, the constant gnawing feeling of impending doom that had lingered ever since the Tribios's deaths. It had been… just a night. A night with someone who didn't ask for anything in return.

It was the first night in weeks where Mydei had let his guard down, even just for a moment.

He glanced at Phainon once more, his heart tugging with something he refused to acknowledge. Phainon had been there when he needed him most, offering not just comfort, but something else—something that Mydei couldn't quite place. In a way, it was easier not to think about it too much. He had learned long ago that giving in to soft moments like these only led to weakness. Weakness, however, seemed a little less terrifying when Phainon was beside him.

With a reluctant sigh, Mydei pulled himself out of bed, careful not to wake Phainon. The air was cool, the smell of the city creeping in through the window. Mydei dressed in silence, gathering his thoughts, preparing himself for the day ahead. The past few days had been a blur of grief, pain, and endless searching. The weight of it was still there, but for now, it was easier to carry. It didn't feel so suffocating anymore.

He left the room, quietly closing the door behind him, and found himself wandering the streets of Okhema. It wasn't a conscious decision; he didn't know where he was going, just that he needed to be out in the open. The city was waking up around him—people rushing to their daily routines, the distant calls of vendors selling their goods, and the hum of life still continuing regardless of…

Mydei was walking aimlessly through the city streets, the bustle of the market district swirling around him. He was tired. Tired of the rumors, tired

of the whispers, and most of all, tired of the unrelenting sense of dread that had been gnawing at his insides since the death of the Tribios. His thoughts were heavy, his body tired, and he longed for nothing more than some semblance of peace.

He didn't even know where he was going. His feet simply carried him through the familiar streets, his eyes half-lidded in quiet contemplation, when something caught his attention. A shadow flitted past him in a blur—a child, small and lithe, darting through the crowd like a phantom. It was the same child.

The one who had taken his earring. Huh, what a coincidence.

Mydei's first instinct was to ignore it. The child had already taken from him once, and Mydei was in no mood to make a scene. Maybe he'd just let it happen again. Maybe he'd sneak a few extra coins into the child's pocket while they were at it—an unspoken bargain of sorts, one that didn't require gratitude, just an understanding.

But when the child darted back into his path again, Mydei sighed, resigned. He knew the signs. The pride in their movements, the way their gaze flickered, like they were ready to steal, but didn't want to admit it. Some kids could sense when they were being watched—when someone could offer a hand without pity. This one wasn't ready for it.

So Mydei gave no more thought to it as the child snuck closer, his eyes lazily scanning the market again. A flicker of movement in his peripheral vision caught his attention—before the child's nimble fingers slid into his coat pocket, swiping another piece of his jewelry.

It was in that moment, just before he realized the theft, that Mydei heard a sound. A sickening, *wet snap.*

His stomach lurched, and before he could react, a sharp, agonized scream split the air. Mydei turned sharply, instinctively reaching for his side as the sound cut through the bustle. The child had frozen, a look of utter horror flashing across their face, blood spurting in a thick, crimson arc.

The child's hand was gone— *severed*. The small arm that had been so nimble a moment before was now a jagged stump, the limb lying discarded in a pool of blood.

It was impossible. The child had been so quick—Mydei hadn't even realized it until the damage was done. A blade had cleaved through the air with such force that it had severed the child's hand at the wrist, leaving nothing but a mangled mess of flesh and bone.

The child's scream echoed in the chaos, but it was cut short as they collapsed to the ground, their body convulsing in shock and pain. Blood poured from the stump, staining the street with dark crimson, and Mydei's breath caught in his throat. He hadn't seen it coming. He had barely processed what had happened.

He didn't know what to do. The child's panicked sobs, their cries for help, filled the air as their body shook, clutching at the remaining part of their arm, trying to stop the blood that poured like a flood.

People had started screaming now too, running in every direction as the chaos erupted around them. Mydei was frozen for a moment, caught between the brutal sight of the dismembered child and the instinctual horror that rose in him. His heart was pounding so loudly in his chest he could barely hear himself think. His eyes kept flickering between the child's severed hand and their face—still twisted in agony.

It was like a nightmare. A nightmare he couldn't wake from.

The smell of blood, coppery and sharp, filled his nostrils as he finally snapped to attention, rushing toward the child's side. Someone else had already arrived—an older man, perhaps a shopkeeper, kneeling beside the child, trying desperately to stop the bleeding with nothing but his hands.

Mydei didn't know what to do. What happened? One second everything was normal but now—his mind was blank. *He should be helping now*. But it was too late. The damage had been done.

The city seemed to move in slow motion around him as he staggered back. His legs were like lead. The world felt too big and too small at the same time. People were running, shouting, pulling away from the scene. Mydei stood there, frozen, staring at the mess. His fingers trembled, and his breath came in short, shallow bursts.

Before he realized it, he was being dragged away. He didn't resist as he was pulled into the hospital—though he wasn't sure how it had happened, or who had gotten him there. It was a blur, his mind too overloaded, too numb to process the details.

The sterile, cold air of the hospital did nothing to ease the sickening feeling in his stomach. They had tried to patch the kid up—hadn't even bothered to check on Mydei for any injuries. His hands were still covered in blood, but they didn't ask. They didn't need to.

Mydei barely felt the passing of time. He was left alone in the quiet room, the sound of his ragged breathing the only thing that reminded him he was still alive.

The world outside the hospital window was calm. The sky was a pale blue, the sun creeping through the clouds as if it hadn't noticed the darkness that had descended upon the streets.

He couldn't get the image of the child out of his mind. Couldn't stop thinking about the violence, about the severed hand, the life that had been forever changed in an instant. And it made something inside him twist, something dark and deep that he couldn't quite name.

He stood up and left the room, slipping out into the hallway, though he had no destination in mind. He was suffocating.

Why.

It was one simple word.

Why?

Mydei staggered through the hospital halls, the faint smell of antiseptic mingling with the coppery scent of blood. His movements were jerky, as though his body had forgotten how to function, yet his mind remained eerily still, fixated on the events that had just unfolded. The sight of the child—so innocent in their appearance but now lying broken, their stump raw and twitching where their arm used to be—was burned into his memory.

He hadn't even realized what had happened at first. A quick motion, a flash of nimble fingers on his sleeve. And then— *screaming*.

It was only after the child's shriek that Mydei's mind registered the horror. His eyes traced the gory stump, the blood still dripping in slow, rhythmic pulses, as though the injury itself had become a ticking clock. He blinked, trying to will away the horror, but the image clung to him like a shadow, refusing to be erased.

Something had been wrong from the very beginning.

The child's arm hadn't been severed by some crude weapon or violent force—it had been cleanly *sliced*, almost as though the skin had been peeled from the bone. No jagged edges, no rips in the muscle. It was as if it had simply been *removed*. The flesh was intact, yet impossibly, the limb had been cut away, as if the natural order of things had been warped, like a scene too perfect to be real.

Impossible.

Mydei's mind recoiled, unable to understand how it could have happened. The violence was too precise, too perfect. It wasn't just some child's wild, desperate strike. There was something else—something more refined. Something *unnatural*.

The sickening thought shot through his mind like a bolt of lightning: *The coreflame.*

When Oronyx and Talanton had first been lit, they hadn't wielded the full extent of its power—not yet. They had still been learning, still tentative

with its manipulation, stumbling and unsure in their newfound strength. But this… *this* was different.

The cut was too clean. The *way* the arm had been severed wasn't just brutal—it was deliberate. Surgical. Like it had been undone as if the body was some inanimate object, a doll whose parts could be ripped away with no regard for the consequences.

It was then Mydei realized what had changed.

The wielder—whoever they were—had unlocked the coreflame's true potential. The balance had shifted. They were no longer just dangerous—they were the one who made the rules. No longer confined by mortal limits, they had learned to rewrite the laws of reality itself. Their power wasn't bound by the flesh. It was above it.

The child's body—the severed arm, the blood pooling unnaturally beneath it—was a message. The act of violence was *nothing* compared to the true horror of what it represented. This wasn't just a brutal attack. It was a demonstration of control, a test run for something far worse. It was a demonstration of a power so perfect, so unnatural, that it made Mydei's stomach churn.

His chest tightened with the realization. He could feel the walls of the world around him shifting, bending in ways that should not be possible. *The rules*—those comforting certainties that had always held the world together—were being torn apart.

And it was only going to get worse.

His hands shook at his sides, and for the first time, he felt truly small, not just physically, but in every sense of the word. The power of the coreflame had taken a step further than anyone could have imagined. It had transcended what was possible.

The air around him seemed to grow heavier, a pressure in his chest that didn't come from the fear alone. It felt like the very atmosphere had been warped, like reality itself was holding its breath.

A sickening chill ran down his spine. *This is just the beginning.*

The world had changed. And Mydei could already feel himself losing his grip on it.

No, calm down. Even if they can wield this power now, they still have limitations—restrictions that can't be ignored. Every heir has a flaw, and they'll have one too, meaning they can't control it entirely by will. Any time a divinity's power is used like this, it places an immense burden on the user. This is no different. They're not omniscient. (The traitorous part of his mind whispers, not yet.)

Still, the words don't bring the relief they should.

Mydei walked in slow, deliberate circles, his thoughts a blur as he tried to piece everything together. The more he considered it, the less it made sense. Two of the Titans' coreflames had been snuffed out. It wasn't supposed to happen like this. There were rules. There were limitations. He felt the anger bubbling beneath the surface, the sense that he was missing something, something crucial.

But it wasn't right. It didn't make sense.

Then the thought struck him—Reason.

His mind stilled as the pieces clicked into place. *The Bough of Rift*, he thought. *Cerces*. The Titan who governed Reason itself, whose flame represented the structure that held everything together. If that flame had been taken—no, if it had been extinguished—then it would explain so much. A world without Reason would lose its order, its logic. Chaos would reign. Things wouldn't work the way they should. The fabric of existence would begin to unravel, and things that shouldn't be possible would become… so.

It was clear now, almost too clear. If Reason was no longer in place as it should be—if Cerces's flame had been snatched from its rightful place—then nothing about this situation made sense. It fit. Cerces's coreflame had been taken.

But then… it wasn’t enough. Not yet. That wasn’t the whole story.

His gaze darkened. *Zagreus*.

The Titan of Mischief. Whimsy. A chaotic force of trickery, turning rules upside down with no regard for the consequences. If Cerces’s coreflame had been snuffed out, Zagreus’s flame could be next. His was the Coin of Whimsey, a spark of the unpredictable. And if Reason had been lost, if the rules of the world were becoming less reliable by the second, then Zagreus’s trickster flame might just be the catalyst to turn everything even more violently upside down.

Mydei’s hands clenched into fists. *Two more coreflames have been taken.*

The realization hit him like a blow to the chest. It was happening. The Titans, the foundation of everything, were falling apart. He needed to act. But how?

Mydei stares at his hands.

They are clean now—washed of the blood, the filth, the remnants of the past few days. Yet, no matter how many times he scrubs them, he still *feels* it. The warmth, the way it clung to his skin, the *sickening* stickiness between his fingers.

The Tribios had died screaming.

He clenches his fists, forcing the thought away, forcing himself to breathe. He can’t break now. Not when things are unraveling like this.

But then—his mind flickers back to something. Something wrong.

There was a detail. A single, strange inconsistency. It had been right in front of him, something he should have noticed before. A crack in the story, a misalignment in the truth. His heart begins to pound as his thoughts piece together, falling into place—

And then he *freezes*.

Not by choice. His breath catches in his throat, his body locking in place as something shifts at the edge of his vision. A presence—*wrong, unnatural*—slides into the periphery of his awareness, and even though he can't turn his head, can't move his eyes, he knows it's there.

A shadow. No, a figure.

Its shape is jagged yet fluid, moving like liquid ink barely holding form. The darkness clings to it like a living thing, pulsing, distorting, as if the world itself is rejecting its presence. It doesn't belong. *It shouldn't be here.*

Yet it is.

It leans close. Too close. Its nonexistent face should be featureless, but Mydei feels its gaze.

A gaze that sees through him.

And then— it's gone.

Just like that.

Mydei gasps, stumbling back as control of his body returns, his lungs burning as though he'd been suffocating without realizing it. His mind spins, racing to grasp onto what he'd just been thinking about—

But it's also gone.

The realization that had been forming, the truth he'd been so close to grasping— vanished.

Erased.

His pulse pounds in his ears.

Something is wrong.

He places a hand to his temple, trying to focus, but there's a pressure in his skull, something he's never felt before. An intrusion. A foreign presence

wrapped around his thoughts like a vice.

And then the horror truly sinks in.

His thoughts are not just his own anymore.

Every time he draws close to the truth, every time he begins to unravel the mystery, something will stop him. Something will ensure he never gets too far.

And if he pushes too hard—if he dares to defy whatever force is watching him—

He will die.

Just like that.

just like what's been happening.

He has no evidence. No proof. But he knows it to be true, deep in the marrow of his bones.

A chill settles in his chest, spreading outward like ice.

And then the final thought strikes him, stark and absolute:

He was being watched.

Chapter End Notes

> Rahhh I feel like I'm relying only on shock value😭
>
> Be honest is the pacing bad? Cause I feel like it is and I'm wondering maybe if I should revise this chapter before posting the next one-
>
> Point out any grammar or formatting issues you see and as always, thanks for reading

Beneath The Golden Blood

Chapter Notes

> Sorry for any gore lovers, this chapter doesn't have much of it and the next one is also probably gonna be tamer too
>
> But yippyyyy I finally finished this chapter after spending like a whole day zoning out abt what to do next😍😍
>
> Point out any mistakes you see and enjoy❤❤

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The hairs on the back of Mydei's neck stood straight, a cold, gnawing sensation crawling across his skin like a thousand unseen eyes. He had been watched before. He had known it. The sensation of being followed, of being studied, was nothing new. But this—*this* was different.

It wasn't the usual subtle feeling of eyes trailing him from a distance. No, this was something else, something far more suffocating. It felt as if the very air around him was thick with presence, as if something—someone—was watching, waiting, observing his every move, down to the way his chest rose and fell with his shaky breaths.

Mydei slowed his pace, eyes darting across the street as his heartbeat quickened, the panic slowly creeping in. He tried to tell himself it was just his paranoia, just the residue of everything that had happened. But deep down, he knew. He *knew* something was wrong. A knot formed in his stomach, a cold, clammy feeling that made his body want to move in a frantic, erratic way. But he forced himself to stay calm, forcing his legs to walk as if nothing were out of the ordinary.

The moment he turned a corner, though, the sensation intensified. His hand twitched, as if compelled to reach for his blade, but the weight of it at his

side only reminded him of the fact that the feeling had nothing to do with a physical threat.

What's going on?

The world around him felt still. Too still. Even the bustle of Ampherous's streets seemed to have gone quieter, the normal hum of city life muted, as if everyone had been swallowed by the same eerie presence. The usual chatter of vendors, the footfalls of passersby—everything was drowned out, as if the very pulse of the city had been suppressed.

He kept walking, but each step felt heavier, as if the ground beneath him was pressing back. The tension in his chest continued to build, a constant pressure threatening to suffocate him. He could feel the gaze upon him now, almost tangible. It was like a phantom breath on the back of his neck.

His eyes flicked from side to side, scanning the shadows that clung to the narrow alleyways, the doorways, the corners. But there was nothing. No movement. No sound. No trace of the presence that was suffocating him. And yet, it was there—right in front of him, just beyond his line of sight.

Then, without warning, his pulse skipped.

There.

He caught a glimpse of something—no, someone—a figure standing in the distance. For a brief moment, it looked as if they had been watching him all along, standing motionless in the shadows. His heart stuttered, a cold dread curling up his spine as he froze, staring at the figure. It wasn't clear, just a vague silhouette against the backdrop of Ampherous's dimming light.

But that was enough.

His breath hitched in his throat.

Was it them?

The figure didn't move. Didn't speak. Didn't even blink. It was almost as if it were… *waiting*.

He stepped forward, cautiously, his muscles tense as if poised to spring at the slightest provocation. But with each step he took toward the figure, something within him screamed to stop. This was wrong. There was something fundamentally wrong about the way this person—this *thing*—stood there, utterly still.

And that's when Mydei realized it.

The figure wasn't human. It was wrong in a way that was almost impossible to explain. The shape of its form seemed almost too smooth, too perfect in a way that his mind couldn't quite comprehend. Like a shadow given life, its edges too sharp, too… fluid. The way it shifted, the way it loomed, was something unnatural, something that made his stomach churn and his skin crawl. The uncanny feeling of something other wasn't just present—it was *radiating* from the figure.

His heart began to pound again, faster now, too fast, as the air seemed to grow colder. He took a step back, then another, before he realized his feet were moving quicker than he had intended. He spun around to run, but—

The world went black.

A sudden, overwhelming force washed over him, and for a split second, he couldn't breathe. Couldn't move. Everything froze in place. His limbs turned to lead, his throat constricting as he gasped for air that didn't seem to come. His eyes widened, but he couldn't blink, couldn't look away.

Then, the sensation was gone, and he was left standing in the same spot. Alone.

Mydei's breath came in shallow gasps, his chest heaving as he slowly, cautiously, turned around. The figure was gone. Vanished, as though it had never been there at all. But the feeling of its presence lingered, still pressing in on him, something he couldn't shake.

He shook his head, trying to clear the fog from his thoughts. His heartbeat hammered in his ears, the frantic rush of blood making everything else sound distant, muffled.

Was it a hallucination?

He couldn’t know. Couldn’t be sure. The only thing he did know was that whatever that thing was, whatever *they* were, it wasn’t something he could ignore. The hairs on his neck prickled again, his body still on high alert as his mind scrambled to make sense of what had just happened.

And then, the thought hit him.

It wasn’t just the figure. It wasn’t just the presence. It was everything—the way he couldn’t shake the feeling that he was *always* being watched. That someone, somewhere, was pulling the strings. And the more he thought about it, the more he realized it wasn’t just paranoia.

No, this was something far more sinister. Something that reached far beyond anything he had ever known.

Something was watching him.

And it wasn’t just watching— it was *controlling*.

He stumbled, his legs unsteady as the realization smacked into him. He had been too distracted. Too absorbed in the immediate threats, the loss of the Titans. But now, now he understood.

They were being controlled. Every movement, every decision, was being manipulated, and this unseen force was pulling the strings, controlling the rules of the very world he had once thought to understand.

In that moment, Mydei didn’t know whether he was still safe or if the world around him was already slipping through his fingers. But one thing was clear.

The shadows were closing in.

Mydei stood frozen in place, his breath caught in his chest as his pulse quickened, the silence around him suddenly deafening. The air was heavy, thick with something he couldn’t quite put a name to. It felt like the world itself had shifted just out of his reach, like the shadows were no longer

simply dark corners of the city but living, breathing things. *Watching. Waiting.*

His heart hammered against his ribs, frantic, as his eyes flicked wildly from shadow to shadow, desperate to catch a glimpse of whatever lurked in the dark corners of his mind. Every sound—every creak of the stone beneath his boots, the rustle of wind through the dead trees—sounded too loud. Too close. His breath came in sharp, shallow gasps, each exhale more desperate than the last as if he could push the feeling away with just the force of his will.

It's just your mind playing tricks on you, he told himself, trying to calm his shaking hands. You've been through too much. *It's the stress. It's just paranoia.*

But the feeling of being watched… that didn't feel like paranoia. The hairs on the back of his neck stood on end, his skin crawling with the prickling sensation of eyes that weren't there—*yet*.

His gaze darted again, scanning the shadows, willing himself to see nothing. Nothing but the empty streets, the quiet city, but the longer he stared, the more it felt like the silence had turned against him. The space around him seemed too still, too suffocating, like something was waiting for the right moment to pounce.

His breathing became erratic, his chest tightening as if the world itself was slowly closing in on him. He could feel it then—*something*, the presence pressing down on him like the weight of a thousand unseen hands. The air felt colder, darker. *Closer*.

Where are you? His thoughts were frantic, each one slamming into his mind in an avalanche of raw fear. He wanted to move, to run, but his legs felt like stone. He couldn't feel the ground beneath him. The weight in his chest was unbearable.

No. No, not now.

He tried to take a step, but his legs wouldn’t obey. The world felt like it was tilting, spinning on its axis as the shadows around him seemed to grow, stretching, folding in on themselves. The oppressive feeling of being watched deepened, sinking into his bones until it was all he could feel. *They’re here. They’re real.*

He jerked his head toward the sound of a distant footstep, the sound so sharp it felt like it was echoing in his skull. His chest tightened even more, suffocating under the feeling of the dread that clung to him. He couldn’t take it anymore. He wanted to scream. He wanted to *run*.

But then the sound stopped. The silence was all-consuming again. His heart pounded in his ears, each beat reverberating in his skull until it felt like the walls were closing in around him.

Please. Please, let it end.

And then—*crack.*

The sound shattered the silence like a thunderclap. Mydei spun around, eyes wide, fists raised, ready to strike, but there was nothing there. Only darkness. Only empty streets that seemed to stretch on endlessly, mocking him, trapping him in this world where nothing felt real. The sound was gone, but the presence remained. It lingered, like an icy breath down his spine, freezing him in place.

His stomach churned, bile rising in his throat, but he fought it back. His body trembled, sweat beading on his forehead, as he tried to make sense of it all. *It’s in my head. It has to be.*

But then the whisper came.

It—that soft, mocking whisper that seemed to brush against his ears, as though it were inside his mind. The voice was no longer a distant murmur. It was close. Too close.

“You’re running out of time, Mydei.”

The words slithered through him like poison, sinking deep into his heart, twisting it in knots. His eyes scanned the shadows again, searching for the source, but it was always just out of sight. Always just behind the veil. *Closer. Always closer.*

His hands clenched into fists at his sides, his knuckles white, nails biting into his skin as he tried to ground himself. *It's not real. It's not real.*

But the sound—the whispering—was back, louder now. It echoed around him, bouncing off the walls of his mind, getting louder, closer, until it was all he could hear.

"Do you feel it?"

"They're coming."

"You can't hide."

The voice pulsed with a mocking, hollow laugh that curled like smoke in his veins, stealing the air from his lungs. He gasped, trying to pull in a breath, but the air felt like it was thickening around him, turning to tar, pulling him deeper into the suffocating darkness. He was drowning, suffocating, trapped in this nightmare where nothing made sense, where the world was shifting around him, warping in ways he couldn't understand.

His mind reeled, each thought slipping away, the pressure building, overwhelming, suffocating. His heart pounded harder, faster, as the sounds grew louder, more insistent. The ground beneath him seemed to tremble, and in the back of his mind, something was whispering, laughing. Mocking.

What is it? What's happening?

The answer never came.

The pressure mounted until Mydei couldn't hold it anymore. He screamed—once, twice, until his throat burned with the effort, until his lungs begged for release. But it was as if the scream was swallowed whole by the dark. There was no escape.

And then, just as suddenly as it began, it all stopped.

The silence was deafening, a vacuum of stillness. The weight lifted. The shadows receded. His lungs burned for air as he collapsed to his knees, gasping, hands clutching at his chest, his body shaking uncontrollably. Was it a hallucination? A dream? He couldn't tell. The world seemed so wrong.

The presence was gone. But the dread lingered, thick and heavy in the air around him, as if something had left its mark. His body trembled, cold sweat clinging to his skin as he fought to steady himself, to calm the frantic beat of his heart.

I'm not safe, he thought. *None of us are.*

Mydei didn't think. He just *moved*.

His legs carried him forward on instinct, his body acting before his mind could catch up. He needed to be *anywhere but here*. The empty streets felt suffocating, the lingering dread gnawing at his bones. His heart pounded as he pushed himself forward, his hands trembling at his sides, his breaths coming too fast, too uneven. He was dizzy, *wrong*, the world around him twisting in ways he couldn't fully grasp.

The voice was gone, but its absence was worse. It was like a stain on the back of his mind, something *watching* him from just beyond the edge of awareness. No matter how far he went, it felt like it was still there. A presence curling around the corners of his thoughts, waiting.

He swallowed hard, forcing himself to focus on his surroundings. He'd wandered further than he realized. The city streets had given way to a quiet, secluded garden—a place tucked away from the world, untouched by the chaos that brewed beyond its walls. The scent of damp earth and crushed petals filled his lungs as he stumbled forward, his legs finally giving out beneath him.

He sank onto a low stone bench, his hands pressing into his temples as he tried to still his racing thoughts.

You’re running out of time, Mydei.

The whisper slithered through his mind again, unbidden, unwelcome. He sucked in a sharp breath, fingers digging into his scalp as if he could claw the thought away. The knowledge of what had just happened pressed down on him like a hand against his throat. His mind was no longer his own. His thoughts—his *suspicions*, his *curiosity*—had been turned against him. *Something* had stripped him of the right to even think freely.

How many times had this happened before?

How many times had he been close to an answer, only to be *erased*?

A sickening realization churned in his gut. *How much has already been taken from me?*

The nausea rose again, thick and choking, but he forced it down. He clenched his jaw, digging his nails into the stone bench beneath him, grounding himself in the rough texture. He couldn’t let this consume him. He needed to *think*. To find a way around this.

But if his thoughts weren’t safe, then what was?

A flicker of movement caught his eye.

Mydei’s head snapped up, his body tensing on instinct. His breath hitched as he spotted a figure just beyond the hedges, moving toward him with careful, measured steps. The moment his eyes focused, his stomach twisted into knots.

Phainon.

The sight of him should’ve been grounding—*should’ve* been familiar, something solid in this unraveling nightmare. But all Mydei could feel was *suspicion*. A deep, gnawing unease coiled in his gut, colder than anything he’d felt before.

Phainon had always been an enigma, a puzzle with pieces that never quite fit together. Mydei had let it slide before, let himself believe that Phainon’s

presence, his attentiveness, was nothing more than what it seemed. But now… Now, everything felt wrong.

Phainon's gaze softened the moment he saw him. "There you are," he murmured, as if relieved. "I've been looking for you."

Mydei didn't respond.

Phainon approached slowly, his steps cautious, like he was trying not to startle a wounded animal. "Are you all right?" he asked, voice low, carefully measured. "You look pale."

Mydei's eyes flickered over him, searching—for what, *he didn't know*. His mind screamed at him *to pay attention, to watch closely.*

His fingers curled against the stone. "How did you find me?"

Phainon blinked, tilting his head slightly. "You always come here when you need to think."

It was an easy answer. A reasonable one. Mydei had sat in this garden countless times before, had sought its quiet solace more than once. But the unease only deepened.

Something in Phainon's expression was too *careful*. Too controlled.

Mydei swallowed the bitterness rising in his throat. "And what exactly do you think I need to think about?"

Phainon hesitated. It was brief—so brief that anyone else might have missed it. But Mydei *didn't.*

His breath stilled.

He narrowed his eyes, leaning forward just slightly. "Go on," he said softly. "Tell me."

Phainon's gaze flickered, just for a second. The shift was almost imperceptible—the kind of mistake only made when someone thought they

weren't being watched.

Mydei *was watching.*

And then, too quickly, Phainon smiled. It was gentle, reassuring—*wrong*. "I only meant that you've been through a lot. Anyone would need time to process things."

Liar.

Mydei's hands curled into fists. "Is that all you meant?"

Something passed through Phainon's expression, something fleeting but sharp. He held Mydei's gaze, unwavering, as if he could will him into *believing*. "Of course."

Mydei didn't breathe.

He felt it then—that deep, sickening drop in his stomach. *There it is. There it is.*

Phainon had slipped.

It was small, subtle, but wrong. Like a single crack in a flawless mirror.

And Mydei *knew*.

His pulse quickened, rage and dread twisting together in his chest, his suspicion sharpening into something more dangerous. He had been right to be wary. Right to watch.

Phainon wasn't just here by chance. He knew. He had known *something*.

Mydei's voice was low, sharp as a blade. "You're lying to me."

Phainon's smile didn't falter, but Mydei could see the shift—the way his muscles tensed just slightly, the way his fingers twitched as if resisting the urge to move.

“Mydei,” Phainon said evenly, “you’re not making sense.”

The gaslighting was immediate.

Mydei’s jaw clenched so tightly it ached. “Don’t do that.”

Phainon’s brows furrowed in concern—*false concern*, Mydei realized with a sickening certainty. “Do what?”

His voice was too soft. Too understanding. It made Mydei’s skin crawl.

“You know what.” His voice was shaking now, his anger barely held in check. “You let something slip. I heard it. You knew.”

Phainon didn’t speak.

The silence stretched between them, tense and electric.

And then, slowly—too slowly—Phainon’s expression shifted.

The concern melted away, giving way to something quieter. Sharper.

He took a step closer. “You’re paranoid,” he murmured.

The way he said it, so gently, *so certainly*, made Mydei’s blood run cold.

Because for the briefest moment, *he almost believed him.*

Mydei’s breath was tight in his chest, a cold sweat gathering on the back of his neck. The more he pressed, the more he could feel the suffocating tension in the air. The flicker of unease in Phainon’s gaze was subtle, but it was enough to make the hairs on Mydei’s arms stand on end.

“I know you know something,” Mydei said, his voice low and sharp. “You’ve been too careful. Too *predictable*.”

Phainon gave a soft, almost disbelieving laugh, but it didn’t reach his eyes. “Predictable? Mydei, you’re not making any sense.”

You’re lying. You’re lying, and I can see it.

The thought surged in Mydei’s mind, but the moment he let his suspicion settle, his pulse picked up again. *Why*? Why would Phainon—of all people—be involved? But the more he looked at him, the more he noticed the little things. The way Phainon’s shoulders tensed when Mydei spoke too frankly. The slight hitch in his breath whenever the conversation veered too close to something real.

“You’re deflecting,” Mydei said, his voice quieter but no less forceful. His fingers gripped the edge of the bench, knuckles white with the force of it. “Stop trying to sidestep the question. You know more than you’re letting on.”

Phainon’s expression shifted, just slightly, the calm mask cracking at the edges. For a second, there was something flickering behind his eyes—something that wasn’t quite human. But as fast as it appeared, it was gone, replaced by that same patient, concerned expression.

“Mydei,” he said, and there was a softness in his voice now, almost too soft. “You’re stressed. You’re reading into things.”

It was like a knife to Mydei’s chest, that gentle tone. It felt wrong, too wrong. Phainon was too smooth, too perfect in his manipulation. But that didn’t stop the crack in his composure from showing, just a flicker of something deeper—something more sinister—beneath the surface.

“No,” Mydei pressed, his voice rising a little. “No, I’m not. You *know* something. You’re hiding something from me. And it’s not just a slip-up. You’ve been hiding it for a while now.”

Phainon’s face tightened, just the smallest twitch in his jaw. “Mydei, please,” he said, stepping forward just enough to close the gap. “This isn’t the time for this. You’re not in the right frame of mind.”

Mydei’s pulse thrummed in his ears. *This isn’t right. I know this isn’t right.* But even as the nagging voice inside his mind tried to piece everything

together, another part of him—the *real* part of him, the part that *should* have been clouded by the strange forces—held on.

It wasn't working.

Phainon was trying to get to him, trying to disarm him, to make him doubt himself, but it wasn't working. Mydei's suspicions were still there.

"You're not convincing me," Mydei muttered under his breath. His words hung in the air, thick and heavy. "You've been playing me for so *long*, Phainon."

The shift was barely noticeable. One second, Phainon's expression was just shy of worried, the next, there was a tension in his stance—a flicker of something sharp, dangerous. For the briefest moment, Mydei saw it. Phainon's lips parted, but the words didn't come.

Then, his voice softened again, but now it was colder, more controlled. "You've been under a lot of pressure, Mydei. You're letting your mind play tricks on you."

"Shut up," Mydei hissed, his eyes narrowing, muscles coiling with anger and suspicion. "I'm not *crazy*."

Phainon's calm facade cracked again—just enough to make Mydei's blood run cold. His eyes widened for a split second, an almost imperceptible flash of something beneath the surface. Mydei caught it. That's when he realized —*this* was the lie. Phainon was trying to hide the truth behind the mask of sympathy, pretending he didn't know what was really going on.

But Mydei saw through it.

The silence stretched between them, thick and unbearable. Mydei was sure now. He was *almost* certain. Whatever was happening, whatever Phainon was hiding, it was tied to the darkness, to the twisted forces that were pulling at the fabric of his reality.

Phainon was involved. *He was part of it.* And he had been all along.

But the question remained: How?

“Mydei…” Phainon’s voice was barely a whisper now, an attempt to regain control, to smooth over the crack. “This isn’t healthy. You need to rest. Think about this with a clear mind. You don’t know what you’re saying.”

But Mydei didn’t listen. He couldn’t. He knew, deep down, that if he didn’t press now, if he didn’t expose the truth, then he might never get another chance.

“*You know something, Phainon*,” Mydei said, every word like a dagger. He leaned in, his face cold and sharp. “And you’re not fooling me anymore.”

The deflection was clear, but it didn’t matter.

Phainon’s smile faltered just a fraction, the edge of his patience wearing thin. There was something darker behind those eyes now—something that *wanted* to break free, but it was contained, locked behind a smile that was just a little too tight.

Mydei’s fingers trembled, but he didn’t look away. He wouldn’t. “You’re hiding something from me,” he repeated, voice like steel. “And I *will* find out what it is.”

Phainon’s expression tightened, but he said nothing more.

Mydei’s heart pounded in his chest, his mind racing. For a moment, just a fleeting moment, he thought he could see through Phainon’s calm facade, but the next, it was gone.

Mydei stood from the bench, his eyes still fixed on Phainon. His suspicion was absolute.

But he still didn’t know the truth. And that was the only thing that kept him from going over the edge.

Phainon remained silent, watching him with that soft, unreadable expression.

It wasn’t over. Not yet.

The tension between them had broken, and now Mydei was all rage. Every word Phainon refused to speak, every evasive glance he cast, only fed Mydei’s fury. He couldn’t let it go. *He couldn’t.*

“Tell me, Phainon,” Mydei snarled, his voice low and guttural, barely containing the fury that surged beneath the surface. “What is it you’re hiding from me? What is it you *know*?”

Phainon’s lips parted as if to answer, but no words came. The silence between them stretched longer than it should have, thick with unspoken tension. Phainon just stared at him, eyes defiant, cold, unafraid.

Mydei snapped.

With a brutal motion, he threw Phainon to the ground, slamming him against the dirt so hard that Phainon’s breath was knocked out of him. Before he could recover, Mydei was on top of him, hands curling into fists around his throat.

“Answer me!” Mydei roared, his eyes wild with fury. The words were like poison, laced with accusation. His fingers tightened around Phainon’s throat, but not enough to choke—just enough to force compliance. Just enough to make him *feel* the threat.

But Phainon still said nothing, still didn’t fight back. He simply looked at Mydei with that same detached, almost amused expression.

It was maddening.

Mydei’s anger surged again, and before Phainon could even react, he grabbed the nearest weapon—Phainon’s own sword—and drew it free from its sheath. The cold, sharp steel glinted in the dim light, its edge gleaming with the promise of violence.

Phainon’s eyes widened ever so slightly, but still, no fight. No resistance. No fear. It made Mydei’s blood boil even more.

“Mydei,” Phainon’s voice was calm, unnervingly so, even with Mydei’s grip tightening. “This is beneath you.”

The words hit Mydei like a slap, and his anger only deepened. His grip on Phainon’s hair tightened painfully, yanking his head back. The gauntlets on his hands dug into Phainon’s scalp, the pressure enough to pull the skin taut, a sharp burn of discomfort that made Phainon wince, but he didn’t cry out.

Mydei’s rage was at the breaking point. With a snarl, he pressed the sword against Phainon’s neck, just hard enough to draw blood. The thin line of red welled up, staining Phainon’s skin. Mydei’s fingers were still tangled in his hair, pulling hard enough to make Phainon’s neck arch painfully back.

“You don’t get to stay silent anymore,” Mydei growled. His voice was hoarse, the edges of it cracking with the anger of his frustration. “You’ll talk now. Now. Or I’ll make you.”

Phainon coughed, a strangled sound that made his chest tremble. Blood spattered onto the ground, and he winced at the pain, but his eyes never left Mydei’s face. There was no fear in them. No desperation. Only that same expression of passive amusement, like a cat watching a mouse squirm in its claws.

Phainon coughed again, this time harder, the blood dripping from his lips.

“You’re hurting me, Mydei,” Phainon whispered, his voice laced with a softness that was almost mocking. “This isn’t like you.”

Mydei’s grip tightened on Phainon’s hair, pulling harder, forcing Phainon to look up at him. The sword pressed into his skin, the sharp edge biting deeper now. Blood spilled down his neck in steady rivulets, but Phainon didn’t make a sound. He just stared back at Mydei, unblinking, as though Mydei’s violence were nothing more than a trivial inconvenience.

The silence stretched, suffocating, and Mydei’s hand trembled with the effort it took to stay in control. The words were bubbling up, his mouth dry, his throat tight.

“Why aren’t you fighting back?” Mydei hissed, his voice cracking with the sheer intensity of his fury. “Why aren’t you—” He broke off, his breath coming in ragged gasps.

Phainon coughed again, blood splattering onto Mydei’s gauntlet, but still, he said nothing. He let the blood drip from his mouth as if it didn’t matter, as if Mydei’s rage was just another thing to be endured. And that *calm*, that *resignation*, only made Mydei angrier.

With a roar of frustration, Mydei moved the sword up and shoved it deeper against Phainon’s shoulder, the tip slicing into the tender flesh, the blood flowing more freely now. His gauntleted hand pulled Phainon’s hair with a violent tug, forcing Phainon’s face upward as if trying to break him open.

The sound of the blood dripping onto the ground was deafening in the otherwise silent space.

“Tell me what I need to know!” Mydei shouted, his voice shaking. “Why are you hiding this from me? You think I can’t see it? You think I can’t tell when something’s wrong? Who are you working with, Phainon? Who the hell is pulling your strings?”

Phainon’s eyes met his, calm, collected, and full of an emotion Mydei couldn’t quite place.

And then Phainon spoke, the words just loud enough to make Mydei’s breath catch.

“You’re the one who’s wrong, Mydei,” he said softly. “You’re the one who can’t stop. You’ve already made up your mind, haven’t you?”

Mydei’s anger boiled over. With a shout, he slammed Phainon’s head against the ground, the force of it shaking the dirt beneath them. He stood over him, chest heaving, sweat dripping from his brow, as the sword slipped from Phainon’s neck.

For a long moment, the only sound in the air was the ragged breathing of the two of them, and the wet, sickening sound of Phainon’s blood dripping

onto the earth.

Phainon didn’t move, didn’t even flinch. He just looked up at Mydei with an almost curious expression, as though he were waiting for something.

But Mydei wasn’t going to let up. Not yet. He wanted answers. And he was going to get them—no matter what it took.

Mydei stood over Phainon, chest heaving, his hands trembling slightly from the intensity of his own actions. The sword, now coated in blood, slipped from his grasp as his grip faltered. His breath was ragged, uneven, like a beast on the edge of collapse. His body was tense with adrenaline, every fiber of him still strung taut from the violence, the need for answers.

Phainon’s face was a twisted mess of cuts, bruises, and blood. His once-pristine skin was marred, eyes half-lidded and unfocused, struggling to stay conscious beneath the weight of Mydei’s blows. Blood pooled around him, staining the ground, yet he hadn’t moved. Not once had he fought back.

Mydei’s pulse throbbed in his ears, the adrenaline still pumping through his veins. For a moment, he couldn’t understand what had just happened. His hands were shaking, his heart pounding in his chest like a drum of war.

He had lost control. *No,* it was more than that. *He had let himself lose control.*

For a brief second, Mydei just stood there, frozen, staring down at the wreckage that was Phainon. His breaths were harsh and labored, but it wasn’t from the exertion. It was the sick realization that he had gone too far. His mind flickered—*What was he doing? What had he just done?*

He crouched down, trembling, as he slowly reached out and touched Phainon’s blood-soaked skin, his fingers brushing against the wreckage of the other’s face. His heart slammed into his ribcage as he stared down, watching Phainon’s labored, shallow breaths. Phainon’s chest rose and fell in fits, a ragged rhythm, as if trying to stay conscious but failing.

This was too much.

What the hell was he doing? His eyes, wide with panic, flicked to Phainon's. Phainon's once-fiery gaze was now dull, and the light in them had nearly faded, leaving behind a haunted, lost expression. His face, usually so composed, now looked helpless, broken, like something drained out of him with every drop of blood that fell to the ground.

Mydei's pulse pounded in his ears, and for a second, the entire world seemed to tilt. He swallowed, his throat dry, as he realized just how far he had crossed the line. The storm inside him was still howling, but something —*something*—in him had snapped. And now he was left staring at the consequences of his own violence.

He pressed his hand against Phainon's throat, feeling the faint pulse beneath his fingers, just to confirm that he wasn't dead. Phainon's weak cough confirmed it, but Mydei's stomach twisted in a tight knot as he realized how close he had come to crossing that line.

The rage slowly drained from him, replaced by an overwhelming sense of dread, disgust, and a sinking, suffocating guilt that clawed at his chest. What had he done? What had he almost done?

Phainon's lips parted, barely able to speak, his voice a strained whisper that barely reached Mydei's ears.

"It's… alright."

Mydei froze, his chest tightening. His breath caught in his throat. The words —so soft, so weak, so… absurd—ripped through him like a blade. It wasn't right. Phainon should've been begging for mercy, cursing him, fighting back. But instead, Phainon, battered and broken, was telling him it was alright.

Mydei's hand dropped from Phainon's throat as if burned. He pulled away, his face flushed with shame and confusion. It wasn't alright. *This wasn't alright. What had he done?*

Phainon's eyes fluttered, his body twitching faintly. His lips barely parted again, but no words came out. Instead, his expression remained a mask of

exhausted acceptance, like he had seen this all before. Maybe it was pity. Maybe it was something else entirely.

But that line… *It's alright.*

The world swam before Mydei's eyes. His hands clenched into fists, his heart pounding in his chest as guilt crashed over him, raw and relentless. His mind spun, grasping at anything to make sense of it. *This was his fault. This was his doing.*

Mydei stood there, utterly lost, his entire body shaking, trembling from what he'd just did.

Phainon, barely conscious, gazed up at him through half-lidded eyes, his voice almost a whisper. "I'm… not mad…"

Mydei closed his eyes, unable to look at him any longer. This wasn't how it was supposed to be. *He wasn't supposed to feel this way.* He wasn't supposed to care.

The silence stretched, thick and suffocating, as Mydei stood there—trapped in his own chaos, wondering how much more of this he could bear.

-

Phainon let out a soft breath, his fingers absently tracing the jagged edges of his bruises, the warmth of his own blood still staining his skin. The marks Mydei had left on him—each one, a claim. Each one, a reminder of who held power, of who held him in their grasp. It was intoxicating. Pain, in its purest form, was a balm for something far deeper, a hunger that festered beneath the surface.

He couldn't remember the last time he'd felt *alive* like this. Mydei's touch —relentless, cruel, unforgiving—had sparked something in him. It wasn't just about the beating. It wasn't about the violence, or the way Mydei's hands had gripped him, yanked him, forced him into submission. It was something else. Something more fundamental. The intimacy in that kind of control, the suffocating proximity of *being broken*, of being shaped.

Phainon's lips parted in a languid smile. *It's almost too easy*, he thought, eyes fluttering closed as he let the sensation of Mydei's touch linger in his mind. He could still feel the weight of those hands, the violence of it, but more than that—the guilt, the hesitation in Mydei's movements. It was in that pause, that crack in the armor, that Phainon could see the truth: Mydei was not untouchable. Not in the way he thought.

He cares.

The thought washed over him slowly, a realization that both unsettled and exhilarated him. Mydei—ruthless, powerful, merciless—*cared*. Just a little. And that made him even more dangerous. More precious. Because Phainon knew that even in the silence, even when Mydei carried him to the hospital and said nothing, there was something there. Something unspoken. Mydei's touch had shaken him. He could feel it in his bones. The way his fingers had trembled just slightly as he'd carried him, as if to say: *I've done this to you. I've hurt you.*

Phainon exhaled, letting the thought hang in the air like a cigarette's last drag, inhaling the feeling of it. He thought about Mydei, his expression hardened, unreadable, but underneath that—tension, guilt, confusion. *Mydei had doubts*. Phainon hummed softly to himself, licking his lips in contemplation. That brief flicker of weakness—it was delicious. Mydei was slipping, and Phainon had seen it, had *felt it*. That had been his victory, hadn't it?

He shifted slightly, wincing as his body reminded him of the cost, the blood, the bruises. But he smiled. Oh, how *good* it felt. To have those marks, to wear them like a trophy, like proof that he was willing to be taken, willing to *suffer* for the illusion of power. To be molded into something for Mydei. It was the only way he knew how to give himself meaning, to make the pain worth it.

But that was not enough. It was never enough. He could feel the hunger rising again, that gnawing need, the same need that drove him to chase after Mydei, to push him further and further into that abyss.

Phainon's thoughts swirled in the dim light, spiraling out of control as he considered the next step. *Another heir. Another death.* It was necessary. The world would bend to Mydei's will, to their shared ambitions. And Phainon would do whatever was required—*whatever*—to make sure that happened.

But the question lingered. How to do it? How to make it hurt? The previous one had been satisfying, but this death needed to be more. It needed to be… more *memorable*.

Phainon's lips curled into a wicked smile as he mused, eyes narrowing thoughtfully. He could do it again. Do it the same way. His methods were simple, direct. And Mydei would be none the wiser. But then… no. There was no thrill in that. There was no *fun*.

He paused, letting his thoughts settle. What would make Mydei feel the loss the most? What would cut the deepest? He could already picture it—Mydei, standing at the edge, watching helplessly as his world collapsed beneath him. Oh, yes. That would do. Phainon's chest fluttered, a violent pulse of satisfaction at the thought. He could feel his heart race, his hands tremble just slightly. The anticipation of it, the need to make Mydei suffer just as he had suffered, to tear at the very fabric of his control—it was almost too much to bear.

But… no. He couldn't make it too easy. No. *I want him to hurt. I want him to suffer, just like I have.*

Phainon chuckled to himself, the sound low and drawn out. Such a mess, Mydei, he mused, his voice soft. *The things I'll do for you.…*

But even in the midst of that darkness, there was something softer, something far more vulnerable—something Phainon wasn't entirely sure he wanted to acknowledge. It was the way Mydei had carried him. The way he had shaken ever so slightly when his hands had brushed across Phainon's broken form, the moment that lingered between them.

Phainon closed his eyes, a faint smile curling at the edges of his lips as he recalled the soft tremor in Mydei's touch. The guilt. The care. He couldn't

help it—it made him feel possessed. It made him feel alive. *He wants me. He needs me. And he doesn't even know it yet.*

He licked his lips again, but this time, there was something deeper behind it. Something dangerous. Mydei would never truly know how far Phainon would go. And Phainon intended to keep it that way.

As for the next heir? Phainon already knew how it would go. The thrill of it, the satisfaction, the power of it—it would be more than just another death. It would be the end, the breaking point that would undo Mydei.

But even then, there was a deeper truth to it: *I will be the one to bring you to your knees, Mydei. I will be the one to consume you.*

And maybe, just maybe, *I'll love you for it* too.

-

Mydei stared down at his hands. They were still trembling, the raw skin of his knuckles flushed and sore from the violence he'd unleashed. He couldn't shake the image of Phainon, broken beneath him, eyes clouded with pain and confusion as Mydei's hands gripped his hair like it was nothing—like he had every right to tear into him, to make him submit.

But that wasn't what haunted him. What haunted him was the feeling of Phainon—alive, yet so still beneath him, the faint warmth of his body growing colder as the moments dragged on. What haunted him was the tremor in his own hands, the unsettling panic rising in his chest when he realized he'd gone too far.

What have I done?

His breath hitched as his mind replayed the moment, over and over, the desperation, the violence, the rage. He couldn't remember the last time he'd felt that out of control. There had been something dark in his eyes then, something he'd never seen in himself before. Something primal. It was like he was another person, someone he didn't recognize.

And Phainon…

He remembered how Phainon had looked up at him, bloodied and bruised, his lips swollen and raw, his body nearly lifeless, yet there was something in his eyes—a look Mydei couldn't quite place. *Was it pity?* No. It wasn't pity. It wasn't weakness.

It was something more dangerous.

Phainon had just… let him. Let him do whatever he wanted. He hadn't fought back. In fact, Mydei had seen the faintest glint of something—*something strange*—in those eyes. Something that unsettled him even more than the fight itself. A strange, almost *delirious* gratitude? The thought of it made Mydei shudder.

He'd left him there, unconscious, not knowing what else to do. He had carried him to the hospital like a fragile doll, too shaken by what had happened to speak, too ashamed to look at him.

He couldn't stop thinking about the way Phainon's skin had felt beneath his fingertips, how *gently* he'd placed his hand on Phainon's shoulder after the fact.

He had *comforted him*. *Comforted Phainon*.

A hollow laugh escaped Mydei's lips, bitter and self-deprecating. What kind of monster was he? His heart clenched as he recalled the faint touch—so delicate, so uncharacteristic of him, but there it had been, his hand hovering over Phainon's bruised skin like he was afraid of breaking him further.

And yet—and *yet*—the suspicion wouldn't leave. It gnawed at him, that gnawing feeling in the pit of his stomach. He couldn't shake the idea that Phainon wasn't as broken as he appeared, that there was something else going on. Something more than just defiance. More than just rebellion.

Mydei closed his eyes, trying to push the thoughts away, but they clung to him like smoke. There was something… off. Something he couldn't put his

finger on.

Why does he never fight back?

He thought about it now. Phainon should have been *furious*. He should have been begging for his life, trying to claw his way out of the pain Mydei had inflicted on him. But instead, he'd looked up at Mydei with those wide, almost confused eyes. A look that made his blood run cold.

And when he'd left him in the hospital? Phainon hadn't even screamed, hadn't cursed him. He'd accepted it, almost as if he wanted it. Mydei's fingers curled into fists as the memory came back—Phainon, lying there, *broken,* and yet… *alive*.

Mydei's heart pounded, a sickening feeling of dread wrapping around his ribs. *Was Phainon playing him? Was this some twisted game to see how far Mydei would go?*

The idea seemed absurd. But then again… nothing about Phainon was ordinary.

Mydei's eyes narrowed as his thoughts darkened, his gaze hardening. He didn't want to believe it, but the feeling of suspicion pressed harder on his chest with each passing moment. *Could he have been manipulated?*

Mydei stood up suddenly, his chair scraping against the stone floor, his heart beating a little faster than usual. He couldn't get out of his head. The feeling that something was terribly wrong, that Phainon wasn't just some *prize* to be won or broken—no. He wasn't a prisoner, wasn't a mere toy to be discarded.

Phainon had made him feel something. And that terrified Mydei more than any of the violence he had inflicted. He'd seen that little spark in Phainon's eyes—the familiarity of it. The way Phainon had submitted, yes, but also how his body had *given in*, as if there was some kind of sick pleasure in it.

Mydei didn't want to think about it. He didn't want to feel it.

But he had. And now, it was a part of him, a ghost that wouldn't leave, a puzzle he couldn't solve.

"Dammit…" Mydei muttered under his breath, pacing in the dimly lit room. His fists clenched tighter, the muscles in his jaw tightening at the uncertainty of everything pushed against him. He couldn't trust anyone. Not Phainon. Not himself.

Not even his own *mind*.

The sound of his own footsteps echoed in the silence as he stopped near the window, staring out into the darkened courtyard. But even as the night stretched on, even as the distant hum of the palace seemed to calm him, he could still feel it—the eyes on him. Watching. Waiting.

He looked down at his hands again. The blood still stained them. And this time, it wasn't just the blood of his enemies. It was his own, *his own guilt*—a stain that wouldn't wash away so easily.

Mydei swallowed, the taste of iron lingering in the back of his throat. He could feel the heat of a new emotion creeping over him now, one that twisted his insides in a way that made him want to scream.

If I'm not careful, I might lose myself entirely.

And yet… a small part of him knew that even as he fought it, Phainon would always be there. Just out of reach. Always waiting.

-

For weeks, Mydei avoided Phainon when he could.

He convinced himself it was just caution, that he needed to be smart about this. He still didn't trust Phainon. If anything, he trusted him *less* now. The bruises on his skin, the blood at the corner of his lips, the way he'd *looked* at Mydei after everything—it was too much. Too uncanny. Too unnatural.

But if that were the case, why had his hands shaken when he reached for Phainon? Why had he tried to comfort him, when he was the one who had

been hurt?

The thought made Mydei's stomach twist. He'd been avoiding it, just as he was avoiding Phainon.

When he spoke to him, it was in passing, cordial, distant. Interrogations were clinical—sharp words exchanged but nothing more. He still pressed Phainon when he could, prodding at the edges of his patience, testing, watching. But outside of that? He kept away.

And Phainon let him.

At first.

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He had been *patient*.

Weeks passed, and he let Mydei have his distance. Let him believe he had some kind of control, some kind of say in the matter.

It was amusing at first. Mydei avoiding him like some cornered animal, only speaking when necessary, only meeting his eyes when absolutely forced. But Phainon had been fine with it, indulging Mydei's defiance as one would a child throwing a tantrum.

Because, in the end, Mydei would always come back.

Except now, it wasn't amusing anymore.

It was *irritating*.

Because this time, when Phainon reached for him—just the slightest extension of his hand—Mydei *hesitated*… and then turned away.

Didn't look at him. Didn't speak.

Just walked.

Phainon stood there, hand still midair. His fingers twitched slightly, as if deciding whether to clench or remain open.

For a moment, nothing.

And then, the shift.

His smile slipped away, peeled off like a dead thing. His shoulders relaxed, too casual, too loose. His bright blue eyes darkened—not in anger, but in something worse.

Something entirely unreadable.

A single vein pulsed at his throat. His tongue ran idly over his teeth, feeling the sharp edges, and a breath left him—soft, almost thoughtful.

The amusement was *gone*.

And for the first time in weeks, Mydei had genuinely, truly *pissed* him off.

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The world had become a maelstrom of chaos.

The oceans—vast, endless, untamable—had begun to destabilize. It started with the tides. Small at first, barely noticeable, but then the waves began to shift unnaturally. Coastal cities saw rising water levels, and the once predictable flow of the seas had turned erratic. Soon, violent storms began to churn on the horizon, unpredictable and fierce, tearing through the lands like hungry beasts. Floods swept entire villages away, and the weather became a terrifying force. The air itself seemed to tremble with something ancient and lost.

Phagousa, the Chalice of Plenty, the Titan who governed the oceans and bountiful resources, was gone. Their coreflame had been taken.

People cried out for help, frantic for answers, as they watched the world around them unravel. Resources dwindled. The oceans—once teeming with life, full of abundance—began to empty. Fish disappeared. Crops withered.

The earth trembled in its own grief, unable to keep up with the sudden imbalance. The rich tides that once nurtured civilizations now churned with violent, uncontrollable currents. Communities at sea and along the shore found themselves suddenly trapped in an unforgiving world, with no clear path to safety.

Rumors spread like wildfire, murmurs of Titans falling, of something dark reshaping the world. But no one could understand the full scope of what was happening. They only felt the terror in their bones, the unnatural storms that ripped through their lives, the resources slipping through their fingers.

And the world began to panic.

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The chaos had only grown, and Mydei had been forced to deal with it in the only way he knew how: relentlessly working, guiding, and assessing every possible fallout from the loss of Phagousa's coreflame. But even in the flurry of reports, meetings, and endless tasks, there was one thing he hadn't been able to shake—Phainon. His absence from Mydei's thoughts had been unintentional, but the longer they went without speaking, the heavier it felt.

Two weeks passed since their last exchange, two weeks of constant missions, planning, and running from one disaster to the next. Mydei had barely had time to breathe, much less think about why Phainon hadn't been in his line of sight.

Now, as he returned from guiding a merchant group back to Okhema, the familiar ache of exhaustion settled in his bones. The market square was bustling with activity as he passed through it. He made his way to Aglaea's chamber to give his report, briefly summarizing the disastrous state of the seas. When he finished, he made to leave—only to be halted by a hand placed firmly on his shoulder.

Mydei stiffened, a reflex more than anything else. His body tensed up at the touch, his heart rate spiking for a fraction of a second before he turned to face Phainon.

Phainon’s usual warmth radiated from him as he asked, “How were the conditions? It sounds like you’ve been through a lot.”

Mydei narrowed his eyes, his instincts immediately on edge. His voice was clipped, almost defensive. “The waves are erratic. The currents are unpredictable, and it’s growing more dangerous by the day. The sea isn’t the same, it’s more… volatile.”

Phainon didn’t look satisfied with the brief response. His gaze sharpened, his hand still resting on Mydei’s shoulder. “And the merchants? What of them?”

Mydei shifted uncomfortably under the questioning look, like something pressing against him. He felt the slight compulsion to offer more, but his lips were tight. “They’re fine. We made it back in one piece.” His voice was short, attempting to dismiss the conversation, but Phainon didn’t let it go.

“Fine is hardly a description,” Phainon said softly, his eyes narrowing as he leaned in slightly, as though trying to get past the walls Mydei was trying to build. “You look like you’ve been through more than just a storm. What happened?”

Mydei couldn’t hide the annoyance in his expression now. He shifted again, ready to pull away from the hand, but before he could move, his eyes locked with Phainon’s—he didn’t know how to describe it. Something about the way Phainon was looking at him made his stomach churn.

With a resigned sigh, Mydei dropped his shoulders, defeated for the moment. His jaw tightened, but he spoke anyway, voice low. “The waves—they grew… they were overwhelming. We tried to navigate through, but the intensity was too much. I went under for a while. Drowned. Took a few lives.” He didn’t like the way the words hung in the air, as if they were a part of him he had to get rid of, something dark that followed him around. “One of the merchants stayed behind, though. Ifigeneia. She was a strong swimmer and resuscitated me.”

The mention of Ifigeneia was an afterthought, barely a detail in the bigger picture. The waves, the danger, the destruction—those were the focus. But

Phainon was still staring at him with an unnerving intensity, his gaze locked on Mydei as if he was trying to pull every last thread from him.

“She… saved you? How?” Phainon asked, voice quieter now, his hand still resting on Mydei’s shoulder, as if it were an anchor.

Mydei blinked at him, irritated, but there was something about Phainon’s insistent focus on the woman’s actions that struck him. “Yes, she did,” he replied curtly, his voice even colder now. “But that’s not what I’m trying to tell you. It’s the ocean, Phainon. The ocean.” His tone sharpened as his frustration began to seep through, desperate to bring the conversation back to where it should be—on the larger issues.

But Phainon didn’t seem to hear him. Or rather, he wasn’t listening to that.

“Ah, I see. Mouth to mouth. How interesting,” Phainon murmured, his voice taking on a strange note, his lips curling just slightly at the corners. “How kind of her.” His fingers flexed on Mydei’s shoulder before he finally removed his hand, the gesture oddly deliberate, slow, as though savoring the moment.

Mydei narrowed his eyes. Something wasn’t right. The way Phainon focused on Ifigeneia—on the details of her saving him, of all things—struck him as off. Phainon always focused on the details, but this was different. The subtle shift in his demeanor, the way his gaze lingered on Mydei, made the hairs on the back of his neck stand up.

“I’m not interested in what she did,” Mydei bit out. “I’m telling you about the ocean. Focus, Phainon.”

But Phainon just smiled, the expression in his eyes deepening into something unreadable.

“Of course,” Phainon said with a soft chuckle. “You’re right. The ocean is what matters, isn’t it?”

But to Mydei, it felt like Phainon was speaking in riddles, and every word was a piece of something far more unsettling than just a simple

conversation. He couldn’t shake the same suspicion creeping into his mind over and over—the thought that Phainon knew more than he was letting on.

Phainon’s gaze lingered on him, as if weighing the truth in Mydei’s words. For a moment, Mydei thought he saw something shift in his expression, something dark and elusive that flashed before Phainon smoothed it over with a slow, practiced smile.

“You’ve always been so focused on the big picture, Mydei,” Phainon said with a soft chuckle, his tone still warm but distant. “I suppose that’s why you’re so valuable to Okhema.” His hand slipped away from Mydei’s shoulder, but the contact felt too deliberate, too final.

Mydei swallowed the suspicion creeping up his throat. He didn’t let his gaze waver. “I’ve always thought the details were important too, Phainon,” he replied, quieter now, a hint of question buried in the casualness of his words.

Phainon’s eyes flared for just a second, before the mask was back in place. “Of course. I’m sure the ocean will make you see that too.”

With a final glance, Phainon turned on his heel, walking away without another word.

Mydei stayed still for a moment, staring at his retreating figure. He hadn’t gotten the answers he wanted, but something felt off. The exchange wasn’t over. Not for him.

Phainon was playing a game, one Mydei wasn’t sure he could win.

As the door closed behind him, Phainon’s hand clenched into a fist. His nails dug so deep into his palm, golden blood seeped from the scratches. He sighed heavily, his shoulders sagging for the briefest moment before he straightened. With a quiet, almost imperceptible shake of his head, he left.

Mydei had no idea how far Phainon was willing to push this.

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The world had barely caught its breath after the devastation of Phagousa's coreflame when the next titan fell. Georios, the Pillar of Stone, was taken, and with his fall, the world began to tremble under the weight of his absence.

Earthquakes rattled entire regions, cracking the foundations of cities, and landslides swept away villages as mountains groaned and erupted in fiery chaos. The skies darkened with ash, and volcanic eruptions painted the horizon in shades of red and orange. Economies, already struggling from the earlier upheavals, now lay in ruins. Communities were scattered, displaced by the relentless shaking of the earth beneath their feet.

Mydei, still recovering from the turmoil of his recent mission, now found himself plunged into the heart of the chaos once again. Reports flooded in from all sides, and the urgency in his work reached a fever pitch. It was no longer just about the seas. The very ground beneath them was breaking apart.

As the tremors of Georios's fall shook the world, Mydei felt his own body beginning to crack under the weight of it all. Exhaustion had become his constant companion, but now it was no longer a dull ache in the background. It was all-consuming. In the days following the eruptions and earthquakes, he had been thrust back into the chaos—an endless cycle of rescue missions, assessments, and endless reports. But this time, the earth itself seemed to want him buried in its wake.

He had been in the middle of a village when the ground began to quake, the earth splitting open beneath him. He could still feel the jagged edges of rocks scraping against his skin as he dove to shield those around him. The sound of the earth groaning, shattering as if it were alive, echoed in his ears. Mydei had never experienced anything like it—mountains collapsing, the ground swallowing whole settlements in a single breath. And yet, he kept moving, kept fighting.

But when the volcano erupted, things took a darker turn. The molten flow threatened everything, and Mydei found himself trapped, the heat searing his flesh as he tried to pull survivors from the wreckage. The cracks in the

earth were deep, their edges sharp, and the volcano's eruption sent waves of heat so intense they felt like being thrust into a furnace.

He'd barely been able to escape the molten flow in time, his body scorched, the skin on his back ripped and torn as he crawled, dragging another lifeless body with him. His breath had been ragged, each inhale burning his lungs as if the very air was trying to destroy him. The stench of sulfur and smoke choked him, but it was the pain that gnawed at him most—flesh ripped from muscle, a sharp, relentless ache that didn't let up.

The worst, though, was the lives lost in his attempt to save them. People he couldn't reach in time, bodies trapped beneath rocks or swept away by the molten tide. Their faces haunted him in the stillness of the nights, the knowledge of their deaths heavy on his chest. Each life lost felt like a piece of his soul had been torn away. He had tried—he had always tried—but sometimes, trying wasn't enough.

Still, he pushed forward. There were more to save, more to help. But somewhere in the back of his mind, Mydei felt something cracking inside him, too. How long could he go on like this? How long could anyone go on like this? Or would he become just another casualty of the world he was desperately trying to protect?

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The world had been shifting beneath Mydei's feet for weeks now, each day dragging him deeper into exhaustion. The loss of Aquila, the Eye of Twilight, was the final blow to what little stability remained. The sky itself had darkened in places, never fully releasing the hold of twilight, and the stars blinked in and out, their flickering light as unstable as the earth beneath him.

But Mydei barely registered it anymore. His body had long since given out on him. His muscles screamed, his bones ached with every single one of the deaths, the wounds, and the losses he had borne. His steps felt heavy, like the very ground was pulling him down, trying to drag him back into the earth.

He hadn’t slept properly in weeks. There hadn’t been time. Not with the endless missions, the constant moving, the fights, the lives lost in every corner of the world. His eyes were bloodshot, the dark circles beneath them more pronounced than ever. His shoulders sagged with the weight of an invisible burden that seemed to grow heavier with each passing day.

Each breath was a struggle, shallow, ragged. Every time he moved, his body screamed in protest—torn flesh, cracked ribs, bruised muscles—every injury compounding on the others. The wounds from his most recent death—a landslide that had buried him under tons of rubble—still burned, the memory of the crushing weight and the agonizing pain vivid in his mind. But that pain was nothing compared to the constant throb of his exhaustion, gnawing at him relentlessly, pulling at his mind, his body, his will.

He could barely keep his eyes open, and yet he kept walking, kept moving, kept going. But the moment he stepped inside the dilapidated safehouse, something in him snapped. His knees buckled as if they had simply forgotten how to hold him upright, and he barely caught himself on the rough stone of the wall before he crumpled to the ground.

Every joint in his body felt stiff, as if the very act of moving required more energy than he had left to give. His head throbbed, a constant, pounding ache that blurred the edges of his thoughts. His arms were leaden, his chest tight. He could feel his heartbeat in his fingertips, his pulse a slow, laborious rhythm that seemed to drag him deeper into the darkness.

The moment he sat down, he knew he couldn’t stand again. His body felt like it had been hollowed out, drained of everything. He let himself collapse into the nearest chair, his back slumping with the heaviness of it all. His armor—still caked with dirt and blood—felt like it was part of him now, each strap digging into his skin, each piece pressing into him as if trying to remind him that he couldn’t escape this.

His eyes fluttered, closing for just a moment, just long enough for the room to spin around him, the sounds of the world outside fading into the background. He tried to resist it, to hold on for just a bit longer, but his body had other plans.

The weight of his own eyelids, the pull of sleep, was irresistible. He didn't even bother to remove his armor. He barely had the energy to take off his boots before he let himself fall forward, his face hitting the table with a dull thud. His breath came in uneven gasps, shallow and labored, as if each inhale were a struggle, each exhale a victory.

And then, as the room seemed to spin around him, he let go.

The pain, the fear, the grief—they were all drowned out by the merciful pull of unconsciousness. Mydei's body finally surrendered, and the weight of the world no longer mattered.

It was just him and the darkness.

The world shifted. There was no sound, no air—just the oppressive hum of golden threads stretching infinitely into a darkness that swallowed everything. They twisted and pulsed like living veins, thick as ropes, their glow seeping into his very soul.

Mydei wasn't standing on solid ground anymore. His feet sank into the threads, each step dragging him deeper into their suffocating grip. The threads tightened around his legs, biting into his flesh, pulling him forward with an unnatural force. His heart thudded violently in his chest, the beat ringing through his body like a death knell, but there was something else—something wrong.

He had to keep moving. *This was a dream*, he reminded himself, struggling against the pull of the golden strands. It was all a nightmare, a reflection of his fears, and he couldn't let himself get caught in it. But every step felt heavier than the last, each movement more painful, like his body was being torn apart from the inside out.

But despite the terror clenching his chest, the pressure in his mind, there was a gnawing thread of *clarity*—he knew. He knew this was a dream. This wasn't real.

Yet, somehow, the pain *felt real*. It cut deep into him as the threads wound around his body, digging into his flesh like talons. His breath hitched, his

throat raw as the threads constricted tighter and tighter. He could feel his muscles burning, straining against the unnatural weight of the dream.

And then—*she appeared.*

Aglaea.

Her form shimmered in the distance, twisted and caught in the golden threads that snaked through the air, like a puppet trapped in its own strings. She was struggling, her body trembling as the threads wound around her, suffocating her. Her once regal figure was bent, her hair tangled and matted, her eyes wild with fear, desperation.

Mydei's heart cracked. *This wasn't real*, he reminded himself again. She couldn't truly be here—she couldn't truly be suffering—but as he moved toward her, his legs trembling beneath him, the feeling of inevitability sunk into his chest.

He could barely walk. His feet dragged through the threads, each movement a struggle. His body screamed, muscles burning with pain, but still—he pushed forward, because he *had* to get to her.

Her cries were muffled, swallowed by the hum of the threads, but he could see her lips moving, feel the rawness of her agony in the air. Her eyes locked on him, *pleading* with him, asking him to *save* her, to free her from whatever nightmare they were both trapped in.

But Mydei knew this was no salvation.

The threads—*they were killing her.*

They had burrowed into her skin, ripping her apart from the inside out. Her blood—her golden blood—spilled from her wounds, dripping onto the floor below her, pooling like liquid light. The sight was nauseating. The air was thick with the stench of death.

"Aglaea," Mydei whispered, voice trembling, though he knew it wouldn't reach her. It couldn't.

And yet, his body moved as if of its own volition. The dagger appeared in his hands, cold steel, foreign in his palms. It felt wrong, but his fingers wrapped around it with sickening familiarity. It was too heavy, too cold.

This isn't real. He tried to tell himself again, but the dagger didn't feel like a dream anymore. It felt like something he could feel, something that was anchored in this twisted nightmare.

Aglaea's hands reached out, her fingers shaking as they brushed against his chest, her eyes still wide with shock. She *knew*. She knew what was happening. Her mouth moved, but no sound came. Her eyes—those golden, all-knowing eyes—looked at him, full of regret, full of pleading.

And then, before he could stop it, before he could scream, his hand lifted, the dagger in his grasp, the cold steel reflecting the dim glow of the threads.

Her eyes widened as the steel sunk into her chest.

The world froze.

The blade drove through her flesh, deep, too deep, and Mydei could feel the sickening warmth of her blood as it sprayed across his hands, his face. He could hear the sound—the wet, sickening sound—of the steel cutting through her. Her body jerked, her mouth opened, but no sound came. Only blood.

Golden blood.

It gushed from her wound, hot and thick, coating his hands, staining the threads, covering him completely. The sensation of it, the heat of her life draining into him, was enough to make him gag, to make him want to scream—except his voice had been stolen.

She was still staring at him. Those eyes. They were still full of disbelief. *Why*? The word hung in the air like a poison, but it never escaped her lips. She reached for him again, but it was too late. The light in her eyes flickered, dimmed, and then—*she was gone.*

Her body collapsed, her head tilting back as the last of her life drained away, mixing with the golden threads beneath her. And then—the world began to collapse.

This is a dream, Mydei thought, but his chest constricted with guilt, with horror, as his hands trembled violently, the dagger still clutched tightly in his grasp. His legs buckled beneath him, his body giving way to the agony that was no longer a dream.

But it was too late.

As her blood soaked into the threads, and the last of her essence faded into nothingness, Mydei's heart shattered. He knew what he had done. There was no escape from it now. Ut was a dream, only a figment of his imagination, but fuck if that still didn't hurt him.

And in her final moments, Aglaea's lips moved again.

His name.

But it wasn't enough. She was already gone.

And Mydei was left in the dark.

-

The smell of salt in the air was soothing, grounding. Mydei inhaled deeply, the familiar scent bringing him a brief sense of comfort. For a moment, he felt like everything was okay, like the chaos of the world outside had been nothing but a dream, a terrible, nightmare-like distraction. It had to have been. Everything had felt so surreal, too sharp, too heavy. But as the fog of sleep faded from his mind, reality began to tug at him, gently at first.

He was back in the safehouse. He had to be. He could still feel the warmth of the fire crackling somewhere in the distance. The sheets beneath him were soft, familiar, and the air—yes, the air was normal. No golden blood. No cold, lifeless body in his arms. Just the usual quiet hum of the house, the peaceful stillness of safety.

Just a dream.

He let out a shaky breath, closing his eyes again, willing himself to push the nightmare away. It was just a dream. He was fine. The chaos, the death—it wasn't real. He wasn't holding her. She wasn't dead in his arms. He wasn't drowning in the guilt of his own hands.

A sharp breath caught in his throat. His eyes snapped open, wide with panic, but the room around him remained undisturbed, the flickering warmth of firelight dancing across the walls. He had to get a hold of himself. This wasn't real. He was in the safehouse, just like before.

But something felt off. *The blood.*

His hands were sticky, his fingers coated with something slick, warm. He looked down, still half believing it was a trick of his mind, a ghost of the dream.

Golden blood.

The thought slapped him awake with brutal force. He blinked rapidly, his mind struggling to comprehend. His breath caught in his chest as he looked down to see the source, and there she was—*Aglaea*.

No.

It was impossible. *No*.

Her body was limp in his arms, her pale face marred by the blood that stained the skin beneath her, as if the color had been drained from her completely. His hands were soaked in it—golden blood, just like before. But this time, there was no escaping it. His heart thudded painfully in his chest, his breath shallow and ragged.

No.

The air grew thick and oppressive as the weight of her body, lifeless in his arms, became an unbearable presence. He tried to make sense of it, to reconcile what he was seeing with what his mind told him should be true.

She couldn’t be dead. She couldn’t be in his arms, bleeding out with his hands soaked in her life.

This is a dream. His thoughts trembled, disjointed. *I just have to wake up.*

But the weight of her was too real, too heavy. The warm slickness of her blood against his skin grounded him, each drop an undeniable truth. His chest tightened as he tried to move, to get away from the suffocating weight of it. He wanted to wake up, to force himself back into the safehouse, into the lies. *Please let it be a dream.*

But it wasn’t. The blood wouldn’t stop. It flowed from her wound, staining his arms, his clothes, his soul. He couldn’t breathe. The pain in his chest was suffocating, not from the physical weight of her body, but from the weight of the reality that he had done this.

I killed her.

The words felt alien on his tongue, distant as they reverberated in his mind, but they wouldn’t leave. The guilt gnawed at him, sinking its teeth into the marrow of his bones. Her lifeless eyes stared back at him, the softness in them gone, replaced by a cold emptiness. Her body was still, and there was no undoing it.

The desperation in his chest tightened, pulling at the very core of his being. He needed to wake up. He needed to escape. He didn’t want this. He didn’t *want* her in his arms like this, *dead* in his arms.

With trembling hands, he reached up to his neck, feeling the pulse of his own heartbeat, trying to ground himself, trying to make the reality slip back into a dream. He needed the pain. He needed to feel something. Anything that would make him feel alive again, something to snap him out of this nightmare that had become too real.

His fingers dug into his skin, sharp nails pressing into the flesh, but the sensation didn’t reach him. It was nothing. Nothing like the terror, the coldness, the grief that was flooding his mind. He could feel the blood beneath his nails, but it didn’t matter. It was too much. He needed more.

His mind screamed at him, *This is a dream. This isn't real.* But his body betrayed him. The pain that he inflicted on himself only brought him further into despair, deeper into the nightmare he couldn't escape. It wasn't enough to erase what he'd done, to erase the life he'd stolen. He dug harder, the raw sting of the pain spreading up his neck, the crimson flowing from the cuts, but still, the tears came.

And with them, the truth.

He had killed her.

The reality of it shattered him. His breath hitched, his chest constricting tighter than before. He couldn't stop the flood of tears that came after that—real tears, tears that came with the realization that this was no longer a dream. He wasn't waking up. This wasn't a nightmare he could run from.

This was his reality.

The golden blood soaked into his skin, the warmth of it growing colder with each passing second. He could feel it on him, all around him, filling the cracks of his brokenness.

Aglaea's body grew colder in his arms, and as his tears continued to fall, his heart broke a little more with each drop, each breath that rattled in his chest.

The terror didn't end. It couldn't.

This was real.

Mydei's body shook, each breath coming in jagged, gasping sobs. The reality of it was crashing in on him with a force he couldn't contain, couldn't escape. He could feel her—Aglaea—so cold and lifeless in his arms, her blood still seeping out onto his skin, soaking through the fabric of his clothes. The golden liquid had long since turned darker, a sickening shade of crimson pooling beneath her, and every drop felt like a weight on his chest.

He couldn’t move. He couldn’t think. The truth was sinking in, and there was no turning away from it. *I did this*. The words were like a broken record, playing over and over in his mind, louder each time. His hands, shaking and trembling, refused to let go of her. His fingers were locked around her, gripping her as though if he just held on long enough, the nightmare would end. But it didn’t. The weight of her body, the coldness spreading through her veins, was a stark reminder that it was *real*.

She was gone.

And it was his fault.

His stomach twisted as his mind tried to force some semblance of logic, something to save him from the crushing weight of guilt. But it was no use. There was no justification. No reason. He had struck the fatal blow. He had chosen to end her suffering, but in doing so, he had destroyed everything that had ever mattered.

I killed her. I killed Aglaea.

The realization hit him like a hammer to the skull, and his entire body recoiled in horror. A guttural, animalistic cry tore from his throat as he collapsed against her, his face buried in the coldness of her neck. His hands gripped her tighter, as though by some miracle, he could pull her back, reverse the damage. But nothing could undo it.

The world outside—every voice, every scream, every ounce of pain—faded into a blur. The only thing that existed now was Aglaea’s lifeless body and the overwhelming truth of his responsibility. The tears came in waves, but they weren’t enough. Nothing was enough. It wasn’t enough to wash the blood from his hands. He couldn’t escape the horror.

He couldn’t stop the sobs. They tore through him like a relentless storm, shaking his body violently as he curled into himself, clutching her like a lifeline even though she was already gone. His chest was tight, as if the very air around him had become too thick to breathe, every breath stolen by the grief that consumed him.

I did this. It kept repeating, louder, clearer. *I did this. I killed her.*

His throat was raw, his chest heaving with the force of his cries. The tears didn't stop. They kept falling, endless, a torrent that wouldn't end. The sobs wracked his body, sharp and desperate, as if he were trying to expel the guilt, to somehow rid himself of the horror he'd unleashed. But it only made it worse. The more he cried, the more the weight of it pressed down on him.

Aglaea's body was cold. So cold.

It felt like hours had passed. How long had he been sitting there with her? Hours? Days? His mind couldn't keep up. Time had lost all meaning. There was nothing but the suffocating reality of her death and his role in it.

He tried to pull himself together, to pull away, to stop, but he couldn't. His fingers refused to release her, as if the act of letting go would make it all more real. And so, he held her—held her in silence as his sobs filled the empty space around them. The only sound in the world was his heart breaking, over and over again.

Eventually, the tears ran dry, leaving only the aching emptiness. His face was blotchy and raw, his eyes swollen and red, but still, his chest heaved with the weight of the grief. His mind was numb, broken in ways he couldn't understand, but the knowledge of what he'd done never left.

I killed her. The words, empty and hollow, echoed through his mind like a death sentence. There was nothing left. He had nothing left.

The world outside was fading, distant and irrelevant. All that mattered was the emptiness inside him, the hole that Aglaea's death had left in his heart. He didn't know what to do with himself anymore. He didn't know how to exist in a world where he had taken her life.

He wanted to die. He wanted it all to end. But he couldn't. Not when the world had already taken so much from him.

Mydei's arms grew weak. His chest, already tight, felt as though it was collapsing under the sheer amount his guilt. His body ached, but it was a hollow pain. He wanted to sleep, to escape, but there was no escaping this.

I killed her.

The tears came again, softer now, but endless. The realization was a slow burn, sinking deeper into him, making him wish he could simply vanish into the air. But he couldn't. He was here. Still here.

And nothing would ever be the same again.

The hours stretched, turning into a day. Mydei didn't move.

The world outside Okhema continued, the city pulsing with life beyond the temple walls, but to him, it may as well have been a distant dream. He had not spoken. He had not eaten. He had not moved from where he sat, Aglaea's lifeless body cradled against him, golden blood long dried in sickly patches across his arms, his chest, his face.

He didn't even register time anymore. His mind had been on the edge of breaking for hours, each second pulling at the frayed edges of his sanity. There was nothing left in him. He had screamed until his throat was raw, cried until his body physically could not shed another tear. He had tried everything—digging his nails into his own skin, dragging a blade across his arm just to feel something, anything, that wasn't this. It hadn't worked. The pain wasn't enough. It was never enough.

But he couldn't leave. He couldn't. Not even to clean the blood from his hands, to clear the haze from his mind. He had killed her. If he left, then it would be real. If he left, then he would have to accept what he had done.

The doors creaked open.

Mydei didn't react.

He could hear the low murmurs of voices, the cautious, hesitant footsteps. Elders. They must have come for their usual business with Aglaea, unaware

that she was no longer capable of meeting them. He barely noticed. They didn't matter.

Then—gasping. Quick, hurried whispers, panicked scrambling of feet. The unmistakable sound of someone tripping over themselves in a desperate attempt to flee.

Mydei barely turned his head, just enough to catch the sight of the elders bolting out of the room as if they had seen death itself.

Or rather—*him*.

A pause. The rush of footsteps. Then a voice.

"Mydei?"

At first, he didn't register it. His mind was so fogged over with exhaustion and grief that the voice didn't even feel real. But then—again, closer this time, laced with something that made Mydei's stomach churn.

"Mydei—what have you done?"

The words should have struck something in him. Should have sparked a reaction, a defense, *something*. But all Mydei could do was stare down at Aglaea's lifeless body, blankly, like he had long since become disconnected from himself. His thoughts were empty. He had no response. There was nothing left to say.

Phainon stepped forward.

Mydei *wanted* to feel something at the sight of him. Relief, maybe. A flicker of hope that Phainon—who always had something to say, always had some way to lighten the weight on his shoulders—would do something. But when he finally looked up, when he finally saw Phainon's expression—

His heart shattered all over again.

Phainon was *terrified*.

Not just at the sight of Aglaea's body. Not just at the blood smeared across the floor, the walls, Mydei *himself*. But at *him*.

For the first time, Phainon looked at him with fear in his eyes.

The way Phainon stiffened, the way his throat bobbed as he swallowed down his nerves, the way he hesitated, visibly fighting some deep-rooted instinct to take a step back instead of forward—Mydei felt it. He felt the shift, and once again everything a about it pressing down on his already fragile mind.

Phainon was *afraid* of him.

The realization hit like a blade to the gut.

Mydei's breathing grew shallow, erratic, his hands curling into fists against Aglaea's cold skin. He tried to say something, anything, but his throat was too dry, too raw, too broken to form words. He wanted Phainon to fix this. He wanted him to say something, to crack some stupid joke, to make light of the situation the way he always did.

But Phainon just stood there, struggling, like he didn't even know what to do with him.

And *that*—that was what finally broke him.

The one person he had left. The one person he had still been clinging to, desperately hoping for even the smallest shred of reassurance—*Phainon couldn't even look at him the same way anymore.*

A choked sound clawed its way up Mydei's throat. A dry, pathetic half-sob, his body shaking violently as his fingers dug so hard into Aglaea's skin that they might as well have broken through.

Phainon took another slow step forward, cautious, hesitant, like he was approaching a wounded animal. His expression flickered between fear and something deeper, something pained, something he was clearly trying to suppress.

“Mydei,” Phainon murmured, voice shaking just enough that it cut through the haze of Mydei’s mind. “Come here.”

But Mydei couldn’t move. He just shook his head, lips trembling, *tears spilling again even though he thought he had none left to cry.* His shoulders convulsed as he tried to breathe, but the air wouldn’t come, and for the first time since this nightmare had begun—

He wanted to die more than he ever had before.

But he couldn’t.

So instead, he just broke apart completely, curling in on himself as the sobs overtook him once more. Every tear was a manifestation of the pain that cut through him, but it was also a release—a futile attempt to rid himself of the agony that would never leave. He felt as though the world was collapsing around him, and in this fragile state, his mind could no longer hold onto the illusion that he was still alive, that he still mattered.

Phainon’s hand reached out, gently placing it on his shoulder, his grip firm but cautious. “Mydei…”

For a moment, Mydei didn’t respond. He didn’t even acknowledge Phainon’s touch. His world was too far gone, too broken to care. The only thing that remained was the unbearable weight of Aglaea’s death and his own unbearable guilt.

But Phainon, despite the trembling fear in his voice, didn’t let go. He stayed with him.

And that’s when Mydei realized—despite everything, despite all the horrors, *Phainon was still here.*

Phainon’s gaze flickered to Aglaea’s body, a somber look crossing his face as he watched Mydei clutch her tighter. His eyes softened for a fraction of a second, before the cold, calculated resolve took over. He knew this moment had to come—he just hadn’t anticipated how much he’d have to break through.

“Mydei…” Phainon’s voice was gentle, coaxing, but there was something else lurking beneath it—a quiet, unsettling tension. He reached for Aglaea’s body, fingers brushing lightly against Mydei’s arm.

The second his fingers made contact, Mydei’s head snapped up, eyes wide with desperation. He tightened his grip, his arms trembling. “No,” he whispered, a broken sob in his throat. “No, don’t take her. She… she’s not gone. She can’t be gone.”

Phainon’s face was unreadable, but there was an edge to his calm that made Mydei feel vulnerable, exposed in a way he hadn’t felt since before all this began. He didn’t understand why Phainon—why anyone—would want to take Aglaea from him, when she was the only thing that kept him tethered to what was left of his sanity.

“Let her go, Mydei.” Phainon’s voice was firm now, the kind of command that cut through the air. “We have to… we have to let her go.”

Mydei recoiled at the thought, clutching Aglaea’s corpse harder, his tears spilling anew. “I won’t let her go. I can’t… She’s… she’s *mine*.”

Phainon’s eye almost unnoticeably twitched when he’d said that, but other than that his hand hovered over Mydei’s, cold but steady. “You’re not alone in this anymore. You have to let her go.”

There was a pause—a long, heavy silence. Mydei’s breathing quickened, his chest tight, and for a moment, he almost thought Phainon would force him. But the tenderness in Phainon’s voice kept him from pushing away, as if the other man was pleading with him in the only way that didn’t make him feel like an intruder.

Slowly, agonizingly, Mydei’s grip loosened. His heart twisted as he pulled away, hands shaking uncontrollably as he let Aglaea’s body slip into Phainon’s embrace. Every inch of him recoiled from the motion, but he was too numb to fight it anymore.

let it end please.

-

Time passed in a blur. The funeral was held in the sacred halls beneath Okhema, where the air was thick with incense and grief. The procession was silent, filled with tight-lipped elders and weary onlookers who bowed their heads, but none of them mourned like Mydei.

Because no one else had killed her with their own hands.

He barely registered the words spoken, the rites performed. Aglaea's body was laid to rest in golden wrappings, her features untouched by death, serene in a way that made Mydei's stomach turn. Her blood, her golden blood, had long since been cleaned from his hands, but he still felt it there, caking under his nails, burning his skin. He stared at her, waiting for something—anything—to feel real again.

It never did.

She was lowered into the tomb with quiet reverence. Mydei didn't cry. He didn't move. He only watched, hollow, as the stone door slid into place, sealing her away forever.

And then there was nothing.

He should've left. Should've walked away, as the others did. But he stayed, standing before the tomb, staring at the carved engravings of Aglaea's name until his vision blurred. His body swayed slightly, exhaustion gnawing at his bones, but he barely felt it.

He didn't want to feel anything anymore.

Wouldn't it be easier if he just—

Mydei exhaled sharply, pressing a trembling hand to his forehead. He was immortal. There was no escape for him, no matter how much he wanted it. Even if he burned, even if he shattered every bone in his body, he would wake up again. Every time. Over and over and over—

A sharp breath caught in his throat, and for the first time since the burial began, his fingers curled into fists. His shoulders trembled, and for a single, horrifying moment, he swore he could still feel the knife in his hands, feel the way Aglaea's body had gone slack, how her blood had pooled around him like a golden sea—

A hand touched his shoulder.

Mydei flinched violently, nearly staggering backward. His head snapped up, eyes wild, only to meet familiar green ones staring back at him.

Phainon.

He didn't say anything. Not at first. Just stood there, quiet, watching him with something unreadable in his expression. Then, carefully, gently, he guided Mydei down, pressing him to sit on the cold stone steps.

Mydei let him. He let Phainon press a hand against the back of his neck, grounding him, steadying him. He barely noticed the way Phainon's grip was firm but deliberate, the way he handled him as though he were something fragile, something on the verge of shattering.

Because he was.

"You're still here," Phainon murmured, voice low.

Where else would he go? What else was left for him?

Mydei swallowed, throat tight, the words sticking there, too much, too heavy to say. He squeezed his eyes shut, shaking his head.

"I don't know who I am anymore," he whispered, voice hoarse.

For a moment, there was only silence. Then, Phainon's voice, soft but unyielding:

"Then let me be your anchor."

The words settled deep in his chest.

Mydei had nothing left. No reason to keep going, no future, no purpose. He was drowning in his own grief, his own mistakes. And yet Phainon stood before him, offering something steady. Something real.

For once, Mydei didn’t hesitate.

He nodded. Slowly, but without doubt.

And then—he *moved*.

Not away. Not to flee or fight or run. But toward Phainon, towards the only thing still standing in the wreckage of his world. His hands gripped Phainon’s sleeves, clutching tightly, shaking, as if afraid that if he let go, he would disappear entirely.

Phainon didn’t pull away. He let Mydei cling to him, let his body tremble against his own, let him bury his face in his shoulder like a broken man grasping at the last thing tethering him to existence.

It didn’t fix anything. It didn’t erase what had been done.

But Mydei believed him.

And for the first time in what felt like centuries—

Phainon truly smiled.

Just barely, just for a flicker of a second, before it melted into something softer, something crafted to be seen.

Mydei didn’t realize it, but in this moment, Phainon had *won*.

There was no more need for manipulation. No more need to nudge, to twist, to push Mydei into place.

He was already where he needed him.

Phainon buried the satisfaction under layers of concern, wrapping an arm around Mydei’s shoulders, holding him close. “I’ll help you,” he murmured.

“We’ll move forward, together.”

And Mydei, shattered and lost, believed him.

Because there was nothing else left.

And Phainon? He had never been happier.

Chapter End Notes

Real question y’all, who should top if I write a smut scene? Or should they both just switch if I add that.

How’d you feel abt this chapter btw? Was it too abrupt/unexpected? Also am I missing any tags?? Idk what to put there😭

Other than that, ty for reading <333

In His Hands

Chapter Notes

> For my Phaidei shippers, I promise I didn't forget u guys He'll get his turn next chapter (or chapter after that if I split the next chapter into 2 parts).
>
> speaking of 2 parts, this chapter was meant to finish up the fic, but I wasn't able to fit everything in, I got tired of writing, and I got a bit sick (So excuse the repetition of words plz I'll fix that in like a month when I got time) so I decided to change the # of chapters since idk if I'm gonna end it at 6 or 7 depending on how much I write😭
>
> Plz enjoy <33 (Yeah but quick warning, this is definitely not my best work)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The world had lost its color.

Days bled into nights, nights into days, but Mydei hardly noticed. Time moved around him like a slow-moving tide, pulling and receding, dragging him along without resistance. He did what was necessary—he protected what little remained of Okhema, shielded those who still clung to its broken remnants. That was all he had left.

The air always smelled of smoke and damp rot, the weight of the city's slow decay pressing down on him with every breath. Ruin stretched across the streets, buildings hollowed out like carcasses, their bones left to crumble. The people were quieter now. The grief that once screamed had settled into a whisper, into vacant stares and shuffled steps. They were like ghosts haunting their own bodies. Mydei wasn't sure when he had become one of them.

He moved where he was needed, fought when it was required. But he was hollow. Detached. The world was muted, blurred at the edges, as if he were

walking through a dream he couldn’t wake from. He felt neither hunger nor exhaustion, only a constant, quiet ache—a weight in his chest that never lifted. It didn’t matter. None of it did.

But then—Phainon.

Phainon was the only thing sharp in the haze, the only presence that cut through the numbness. He was steady, solid, there. Always there.

Mydei wasn’t sure when it had started—the way Phainon lingered, the way his voice, rich and grounding, was the one thing that seemed to reach through the fog. He wasn’t pushy. He didn’t demand. He simply existed alongside him, offering help where he could, easing the burdens Mydei refused to acknowledge.

When Mydei was too lost in his own head to eat, Phainon would place food near him, making some offhanded remark about how much weaker he looked. When Mydei moved through the streets like a shadow, Phainon was at his side, as if making sure he didn’t fade into nothing entirely. When the silence in his mind became too vast, Phainon filled it, speaking about things that didn’t matter—stories, observations, meaningless little things that, somehow, still kept Mydei tethered.

Phainon never pushed him to move on. Never told him to forget.

But he never let him slip away, either.

And Mydei, without realizing it, started letting him in.

-

The city had always been a cradle of fire and blood, but now it was a shell of what it had once been. Mydei was no different.

Sitting on the edge of a stone wall overseeing the outside world from Okhema, his hands clasped loosely in his lap, he gazed out over the wreckage that sprawled before him. Okhema was holding on by a thread, but everything else? Shattered. Not even worth mentioning. It was

everything he was, everything he had once been, crumbling to dust. He couldn't feel it anymore. There was only the quiet hum of emptiness.

Behind him, Phainon's footsteps were soft, purposeful. He didn't intrude—never did—but his presence was undeniable, like a shadow falling over the smallest corner of Mydei's world.

"Mydei," Phainon's voice, rich with concern, stirred the stillness, a gentle tug on the threads of Mydei's consciousness. He glanced over his shoulder, meeting Phainon's gaze.

Phainon's expression was unreadable, but there was an undercurrent of worry there—so subtle, so quiet, that Mydei could have easily missed it if he wasn't paying attention. The soft lines around his eyes, the way his posture had softened, the slight tremble in his usually steady hands—all of it spoke of a care that Mydei couldn't quite fathom, couldn't truly understand.

Phainon stepped closer, his movements slow and deliberate, as if trying not to disturb something fragile. "Would you like something to eat?" His voice was low, coaxing, as if testing the waters. "Or perhaps… some rest?"

There was no force in his tone—no demand. Just a soft invitation, a suggestion. He wasn't trying to make Mydei feel anything he didn't want to, but his words lingered in the air suffocating with a kind of unspoken plea.

For a long moment, Mydei said nothing. He didn't even really acknowledge the offer, his gaze drifting back to the ruined skyline. He could feel Phainon's eyes on him, watching him with a kind of intensity that shouldn't have been so comforting, but somehow was.

Phainon took a step closer, just enough for Mydei to feel the warmth of his proximity. His next words were softer still, almost a whisper.

"I care about you, Mydei." There was a pause, the weight of those words settling between them, unspoken yet understood. "Please… take care of yourself. At least for my sake."

The way Phainon said it was… different. There was nothing like the cautious or poisonous conversations that had become their norm, nothing like the manipulation or the power games. This was something else. It was care—pure, genuine care—something Mydei hadn't realized he needed until that very moment.

Mydei's chest tightened, a dull ache blooming in the pit of his stomach. He tried to shove it down, to ignore it, but it wouldn't go away. Phainon's presence, his concern, was a kind of lifeline Mydei hadn't known he was clinging to. And it terrified him.

He pulled in a breath, his throat dry. "I'm fine," he said, his voice hoarse. It was a lie—he knew it. Phainon knew it too, but neither of them called it out.

Phainon didn't respond at first. Instead, he just stood there, letting the silence stretch between them like a taut wire. The kind of silence that spoke louder than words ever could. Then, quietly, almost tenderly, Phainon placed a hand on Mydei's shoulder. Not to command, but to offer something—comfort, support, maybe just the feeling that Mydei wasn't alone in the dark.

"I don't think you are," Phainon said softly. His voice wasn't accusing, wasn't pushing—it was simply the truth. "But that's alright. You don't have to be. Not with me."

Mydei swallowed hard. It was impossible to ignore how close Phainon was, how his warmth seeped through the thin fabric of clothes the other was wearing. He could feel the faint thrum of life in Phainon's touch, steady and sure, something Mydei had forgotten how to be.

There was a long pause.

"I…" Mydei started, but the words caught in his throat. What could he say? How could he explain this… this strange vulnerability that Phainon had awakened in him without even trying?

“I’m not… ready,” he managed to say finally, his voice barely above a whisper.

Phainon’s eyes softened, the hint of a smile tugging at his lips, though it was laced with a sadness Mydei didn’t fully understand. He squeezed Mydei’s shoulder once, then let his hand fall away.

“That’s alright,” Phainon said, his voice still gentle, his tone unwavering. “Take your time. I’ll be here when you’re ready.”

Mydei didn’t know why, but the words stirred something in him. Something warm, something that made his chest tighten all over again. He wanted to pull away, to retreat back into the fortress he had built around himself. But instead, for just a moment, he stayed.

“Thanks,” Mydei muttered, more to himself than to Phainon.

Phainon’s gaze softened even more. “You don’t have to thank me.” He paused, then added, with a rare tenderness that sent a shiver down Mydei’s spine: “Mydei. Let me help.”

The words hung in the air, a silent promise, one Mydei wasn’t sure he was ready to accept but somehow couldn’t reject. Not now.

-

Time was something that slipped through Mydei’s fingers, no matter how hard he tried to hold onto it. The city—Okhema—still stood, but there was a palpable tension in the air, a constant shiver of instability beneath the surface. Phainon and the Elders had managed to keep the worst of it at bay, holding the city together, but Mydei knew better than to trust the calm. It felt like a breath held too long, waiting for a snap.

There was nothing to tether him anymore.

Some days, he would wake up, his body heavy with the weight of unspoken exhaustion, as though he hadn’t slept at all. He could feel the silence

pressing in from all sides, filling the empty spaces with echoes of things he'd long since forgotten how to name.

The darkness was so much easier to face when the world was quieter. When everything felt far away.

He would stand, sometimes, at the edge of a ledge high above the city, just watching the slow drift of clouds, the light wavering over the horizon. His gaze would fall to his hands—tan, rough from years of use, scars etched into the skin like a map of battles lost and won. It didn't matter how many times he tried to wipe them clean, they never felt right, never felt… whole.

They felt like something broken. Something that would never fit together again.

There were nights when he couldn't sleep, his bed too warm, too comforting for the emptiness that curled like a weight in his stomach. He'd get up, sometimes, and walk the halls of Okhema, the air still and cool against his skin. The flickering lanterns cast long, shifting shadows, but even their light felt alien, as if he wasn't supposed to be here anymore. It was easy to disappear into the dark, but no matter how far he walked, he always ended up in the same place. The quiet was too loud, the stillness too heavy, and it pressed against his ribs until he couldn't breathe, couldn't think.

One evening, he stood at the edge of a balcony overlooking the heart of the city, his fingers tightening on the stone railing, a thin tremor running through him.

His breath was slow. Deep. But in the silence that followed, all he could hear was the faint hum of his heartbeat—steady, always. Unyielding. It was the only thing that wouldn't let him go.

The knife was on the counter in his room, though it wasn't the first time he had thought about it. It wasn't the first time he'd felt the overwhelming need to break the silence, to feel something sharp and real, to take a moment where he could focus on the sting of it, the way it would remind him that he was still here.

It wasn’t the first time he’d wondered if he should do it. But his skin—his cursed, eternal skin—wouldn’t let him. The immortal curse that kept him bound, bound to a world that felt too heavy and a heart that felt too cold. Nothing could end it.

Not even a knife.

-

The Elders and Phainon tried their best to keep him stable. They talked to him, sometimes. They tried to make him feel human again, though it was like trying to patch a cracked vase with tape. He could see their concern, but all their efforts fell flat in the face of the quiet storm that raged inside him. No one understood what it was like to have a mind that wouldn’t slow down, that wouldn’t stop chewing on itself.

It wasn’t even about the city anymore, or the war, or the loss. He could barely remember what it had been like before—the sharp clarity of a purpose, a cause to fight for. Now, there was only the hollow ache in his chest, the pull of memories that refused to die. The idea of moving forward seemed absurd—how could you move forward when everything around you kept folding in on itself?

Some days, he would look in the mirror and not recognize the person staring back at him. The face was his, but the eyes—those weren’t his. He didn’t know them anymore. They were just a reflection of someone who had given everything away, piece by piece, and was now too tired to pick it up again.

It was an ordinary morning when Mydei stepped out into the city streets once more, exhaustion pulling him down like an anchor. The buildings loomed over him, the city holding its breath, fragile and uneasy in a way he had come to know all too well. The quiet was different now. It was like the city itself was waiting, waiting for something to crack. Waiting for something to break.

Mydei didn’t want to be here. But he couldn’t remember where else to go.

As he walked, the motion of his legs was automatic, but the world around him was a blur. The footsteps behind him didn't feel like they belonged to anyone, the voices in the distance too muffled to make sense of. The air tasted like metal and smoke, and the scent of blood—always blood—hung thick on his tongue, even when there was nothing to smell. It was as if it was seeping out of his pores, never leaving.

There were days, like today, when the memory of it—the feeling of being lost in the aftermath of destruction—would come crashing down on him. When his thoughts would scatter, jittery, desperate for a distraction, for something to fixate on before the urge to break became too much.

Before he could think too much about it, his body would carry him back to his room, back to the heavy silence, to the solitude that let him rest in a kind of mindless quiet. But in that quiet, sometimes, the world felt too close.

And then, sometimes, he could hear Phainon's voice—a whisper, barely audible, but there, always there.

"Stay with me," it would say, soft and insistent. *"Don't leave."*

He groaned, placing his hand over his head.

His chest tightened as the words echoed in his mind. The softness, the care in them—it wasn't what he was used to. It wasn't what he *wanted* to be used to. A low groan left his throat as he pressed the heels of his palms to his forehead, trying to ground himself.

Of course, he was thinking about that. Of course. Phainon had a way of slipping into his thoughts like a shadow, lurking in the corners of his mind when he least expected it. But the way he'd said it—the gentleness, the almost tender insistence—it was like a splinter lodged in his brain, impossible to ignore.

He squeezed his eyes shut, trying to shut it all out.

Focus. Focus on something else.

His heart thudded faster, an erratic pulse racing beneath his ribs. He could feel his pulse in his throat, the familiar ache of frustration building in his chest, pushing him toward the same restless place he'd been circling for weeks. For months.

It wasn't real. It couldn't be. There was no place for that kind of behavior in his life anymore. Not after everything that had happened.

The words still lingered, curling into his thoughts like smoke.

"Don't leave."

A sharp exhale hissed from his teeth as he shoved them aside. *Not now. Not like this.*

He ran his fingers through his hair, pulling at it almost violently, as though the act of doing so might purge him of the thoughts, of the soft, *careful* way Phainon spoke to him, as if Mydei still deserved kindness. He had to force it out, pushing the feeling away with every ounce of will he had left.

He didn't need it. He didn't want it. Not from him. Not anymore.

-

Blood spattered across his gauntlets, the warmth seeping into his skin as the body beneath his hands went still. He barely registered the gurgled final breath of the last enemy before he wrenched his gauntlets free, a sharp twist of his wrist ensuring the damage was irreparable. Another one down. Another obstacle erased.

It wasn't enough.

His breath came slow, steady. Too steady. He was beyond feeling, beyond caring—his body simply moved on instinct, cutting through anything that dared cross his path. Phainon was somewhere behind him, watching, silent, as Mydei dispatched enemy after enemy before they had a chance to react. He didn't give them a chance. He didn't need to.

By the time the last corpse hit the ground, the battlefield had quieted. The only sound was the distant crackle of fire and the crunch of dirt beneath his boots. He wiped a hand across his gauntlet, smearing away blood that had already begun to dry, and turned away without a word.

The mission was done. That was all that mattered.

The walk back was quiet—at least for a while. Mydei strode ahead, his pace unrelenting, his mind already locking itself back into the cold void he'd grown accustomed to.

Then—

"Mydei," Phainon called from behind him, his tone firm but edged with something else. Concern.

He ignored him.

"Mydei," Phainon said again, quickening his pace to catch up. "Stop. Talk to me."

Still, Mydei walked.

He heard the faint shift of movement before Phainon's voice rose, not in anger, but in frustration.

"Damn it, *listen* to me!"

He didn't think. He didn't hesitate.

One moment, Phainon was standing behind him, and the next, Mydei had him slammed against the nearest wall, fingers twisted into his collar, his gauntlet pressing against Phainon's throat—not enough to hurt, but enough to remind him who he was dealing with.

Phainon let out a small grunt, but he didn't resist. He didn't even look *surprised*. His eyes were locked onto Mydei's, watching, searching, as if trying to unravel something only he could see.

“You think you can *order* me around?” Mydei’s voice was low, sharp, each word dripping with venom. “You think I owe you an explanation?”

He leaned in closer, his grip tightening ever so slightly.

“You just want to feel better about yourself, don’t you? Like you actually *give a damn?”*

Phainon’s lips parted slightly, his breath coming faster—but it wasn’t fear. It wasn’t even defiance.

It was something else entirely.

Before Mydei could pull back, Phainon moved.

A kiss.

Not to his lips, but to his cheek.

Soft. Simple. Deliberate.

It sent a shock through his entire body, his grip on Phainon’s collar going slack, hesitatingly raising his arm to Phainon’s cheek.

His first instinct was to push away, to hit him, to snarl and snap and take back control of whatever this was, but—

He couldn’t.

His body refused to move, frozen in place as the warmth of Phainon’s lips lingered on his skin. His pulse roared in his ears, and for once, he was *silent.*

Phainon had *known*. Known he wasn’t ready, known anything more would have been too much, *too close*, and yet—

The realization struck hard and fast, and suddenly, Mydei couldn’t *stand* to be here anymore.

He released Phainon as if burned, taking a staggering step back. His breath came sharp and uneven, his hands clenched into fists at his sides.

Then, without another word, he turned on his heel and walked away.

Phainon didn’t stop him this time. But Mydei could hear his quiet footsteps trailing behind.

The walk back was silent. Phainon hadn’t said a word since *that*, and Mydei was fine with that. He *needed* the silence, needed to shove what happened deep into the recesses of his mind before it had a chance to sink its claws into him.

But something was *off*.

At first, he thought it was his own unease, but the more he focused, the clearer it became.

Phainon’s stride. It was slightly off-rhythm. A fraction slower. He still carried himself with that same languid ease, but there was a stiffness to his movements, a deliberate effort to conceal something.

He was *hurt.*

Mydei didn’t acknowledge it. He didn’t so much as look at Phainon. But he noted it, filed it away, and adjusted his pace accordingly.

And then—

A flicker of movement.

Subtle. Just beyond the broken remains of a nearby pillar.

He didn’t react. Didn’t let on that he’d noticed.

He only waited.

Phainon took another step, and the instant his foot hit the ground—

A figure lunged from the shadows.

A man. Human. A Follower of Strife.

It was rare to see *humans* among the god-tainted zealots, but Mydei didn't waste time wondering why he was here. It didn't matter.

What *mattered* was the blade in the man's hand, the way it arced through the air, aimed straight for Phainon's exposed side.

Phainon was fast. But Mydei was faster.

He moved in a blur, barely registering the snarl on the man's face before he *slammed* into him, driving him back before the knife could connect. They hit the ground hard, dust and dirt scattering as Mydei straddled him, pinning him beneath his weight.

The man choked, but he wasn't given time to struggle.

Mydei's gauntleted hand came down swift and merciless, plunging *straight* into his chest.

Bone cracked. Flesh tore.

The man gasped, eyes going wide in disbelief as Mydei *twisted* the gauntlet deeper, making sure the damage was irreversible.

A human. He could feel the fragility of it—the way the body beneath him trembled, so easily breakable, so unlike the divine beings they usually fought.

He leaned in, voice quiet, emotionless.

"You should've run."

The man shuddered. Then he stilled.

When Mydei pulled his hand free, the body slumped lifelessly beneath him.

He exhaled through his nose, rising fluidly to his feet. Blood dripped from his gauntlet, staining the ground as he turned—

Phainon was watching.

He hadn’t moved. Hadn’t said a word.

He only stood there, one hand pressed loosely to his side, fingers curling and uncurling as if weighing whether or not to acknowledge his own injury. His eyes flickered from the corpse at Mydei’s feet to the crimson staining his gauntlets, then to Mydei himself.

Something unreadable passed across his face.

Mydei scowled. “You’re lagging behind.”

Phainon blinked. Then—slowly, *deliberately*—he smiled.

“I see that,” he murmured.

A muscle in Mydei’s jaw tightened. “Then keep up.”

And yet, as they walked, it was Mydei who stayed a step behind, his eyes locked onto Phainon’s every movement.

Watching.

Guarding.

Ensuring no one *dared* try again.

Even if Phainon never said a word about it, even if he pretended he didn’t notice—

Mydei knew.

And he would make damn sure no one laid a hand on Phainon while he was still breathing.

-

He had expected something.

Anger. Rage. A curse spat through gritted teeth, a threat sharp enough to cut.

But not this.

Phainon lifted a hand to his cheek, fingers ghosting over the spot where Mydei's hand had been just moments before. Not in violence. Not in fury. But in something hesitant, something trembling and fleeting before Mydei had *ripped* himself away, as if the moment itself had burned him.

And then he had *fled*.

Not out of hatred. Not out of disgust.

But because for the first time, Mydei had been confronted with something he *couldn't* fight.

Phainon exhaled, slow and measured, though his pulse betrayed him.

Gods.

Gods.

He hadn't been prepared for this. Hadn't expected the heat curling in his gut, the sharp coil of want twisting tight, pulling, *dragging* him deeper into something he couldn't name.

Not just desire. Not just amusement.

Something more. Something *much* more.

His lips parted, his breath uneven as he let the realization settle, let it take.

He wanted him.

Not just the Mydei who tore through enemies without hesitation, who painted the world in blood and ruin without blinking.

No—he wanted *this* Mydei. The one who *flinched* at kindness. The one who had *no* idea what to do when faced with something he couldn't cut down.

The one who had unknowingly let Phainon in, just for a moment, before retreating in a way that had left Phainon *aching* for more.

His fingers curled, nails biting into his palm.

He would have him.

One way or another.

-

The walk back to Okhema felt longer than it should have.

Mydei kept his pace quick, his feet moving in almost mechanical precision, his thoughts scattered. The streets felt different now, colder, like the city itself had become more fragile. But that was something he couldn't think about—not when his mind kept drifting back to that moment. The kiss.

The heat of it still lingered on his cheek, even though he'd tried to shake it off. The way Phainon's lips had barely grazed his skin, like it was the most tender thing he'd ever done.

Why did it make his heart skip?

He didn't want to care. Didn't want to feel anything for Phainon—certainly not this. He was already too damaged, too broken. He couldn't afford to let someone else in.

And yet…

When he glanced over his shoulder, Phainon was walking a few steps behind him, his posture stiff. His eyes weren't on the ground, but not quite

meeting Mydei’s either. It was a strange kind of silence between them now —uncomfortable, but gentle.

Was this what regret looked like?

But Phainon never seemed bothered by it. Not really. He didn’t push, didn’t force any words, and somehow that made it worse. His mere presence was enough to disrupt everything in Mydei’s mind.

“I’m sorry,” Phainon said quietly, just loud enough for Mydei to hear, his voice an almost unrecognizable softness.

Mydei’s jaw tightened. He didn’t look back as Phainon spoke again, voice hesitant. “I… should’ve—shouldn’t have done that.”

Mydei stopped dead in his tracks, exhaling sharply as the words hit him. The kiss. The touch. Was he apologizing for that?

Phainon’s footsteps faltered behind him, the sudden quiet stretching out like a rope between them.

But Mydei didn’t turn around. He didn’t know what he would say, what he could say. Something inside of him wanted to scream at him to stop, to get away, but the silence in Phainon’s apology held him still.

It didn’t feel like an apology, not the way it should have. It wasn’t heavy with guilt or regret. No, it felt more like… longing.

Like Phainon wanted to reach him but didn’t know how.

Mydei was getting used to keeping everything buried. To keeping his distance, hiding what he felt. And yet, with Phainon?

He felt exposed.

“You don’t have to apologize,” Mydei finally muttered, his voice low and unsure. He hated that it sounded weak, that it came out like he wasn’t really sure what he meant.

He didn’t turn, didn’t dare face him, as he pushed open the gates of Okhema. “I don’t need that from you.”

There was a brief silence before Phainon spoke again, quieter this time. “I’ll give you space.”

Mydei wanted to snap something back. He wanted to say that wasn’t necessary—that he didn’t need anyone’s space, that he didn’t need anyone. But he didn’t. Because the truth was, he *did* need something. And every time he tried to convince himself otherwise, it was Phainon who kept reminding him that he *could* let himself need someone.

The city loomed around them, quiet and unnervingly still, as if it was holding its breath. The distant hum of the Elders’ work was a constant undercurrent, but it felt muted, far away.

Mydei couldn’t stop himself from glancing back one last time. Phainon was still there, walking slowly, his hands hanging loosely at his sides. The man had a way of looking at him—not with expectation or impatience, but with patience. Like he was waiting for something.

It was more unsettling than anything Mydei had felt in a long time.

“I didn’t want to hurt you,” Phainon said softly, just as Mydei reached the door to his chambers. His words were a tentative bridge, though Mydei wasn’t sure if they were meant to be heard or not. “I just… wanted to be close to you.”

The words hung in the air like a confession. Mydei didn’t know how to respond to that. He didn’t want to admit how much it stirred something in him—something he hadn’t let himself feel in years. Something warm, something he couldn’t fight.

He didn’t speak for a long moment, the tension strong between them despite how quietly Phainon had spoken. Finally, he broke the silence with a short nod.

“I know,” he said, his voice almost lost beneath the weight of the moment. “Just… don’t do it again.”

Phainon didn’t respond, but Mydei heard the slight rasp of his breath before he turned and disappeared into the darkness of the hall.

Alone again, Mydei allowed himself a breath, but it was shaky. The words felt like a lie on his tongue. He didn’t want to tell Phainon to stay away. Didn’t want to push him further into the distance, especially when something deep inside him longed to pull him closer.

And it terrified him.

The door closed behind him, and he finally let out the breath he had been holding, the silence wrapping around him like a shroud.

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It was hard to pinpoint exactly when it started, but slowly, Mydei found himself noticing Phainon more—*really* noticing him.

Not just in the way the man stood there, quietly observing, or how he had a knack for saying just the right thing when Mydei’s thoughts began to feel too heavy. But in the little things: the way Phainon’s movements were always careful around him, like he was waiting for a signal—anything—that might allow him to bridge the gap. It made Mydei uneasy, and yet there was something oddly soothing about it.

One evening, after another grueling mission, they returned to Okhema’s inner halls. Mydei’s body ached, but it wasn’t the exhaustion that pulled his attention. It was Phainon’s quiet presence, standing at the threshold of the chambers. He didn’t say anything right away, just watched him with those sharp, calculating eyes, but there was something else beneath it—a softness, almost tentative.

“You should get some rest,” Phainon said, his voice low.

Mydei glanced at him, then quickly turned away. “I’m fine.” His tone wasn’t harsh, just firm. He couldn’t admit how drained he really felt, physically and mentally.

Phainon didn’t press him, just nodded and stepped back to give him space, but not without a brief look of concern. It was strange—how that concern wasn’t suffocating, like it might have been from someone else. It was like Phainon simply cared, without expectation.

Mydei had never been good with that. He had never been good at receiving anything, least of all something that felt so… genuine. But there it was, hovering in the air between them.

A few days later, they found themselves on the balcony of the palace, watching the city below. The view was always stunning—Okhema’s grandeur never failed to take Mydei’s breath away, even now when everything felt like it might crumble beneath the pressure.

Phainon stood beside him, leaning casually against the stone railing, his posture relaxed, though there was a hint of something restrained in the way his gaze never quite met Mydei’s.

“How are you holding up?” Phainon asked after a long pause, his voice soft but steady. It wasn’t an invasive question—he wasn’t pushing for answers. Just a simple inquiry.

Mydei grunted, his arms crossed tightly. He wasn’t sure if he could put his feelings into words anymore. “I’m fine.”

Phainon didn’t say anything in response, but Mydei caught the subtle shift in his expression—like he was trying to decide whether or not to press the issue. For once, Mydei didn’t pull away. He just… waited.

Phainon eventually broke the silence with a small, almost imperceptible smile. “You don’t have to keep pretending with me, Mydei.”

It stung more than it should have. But somehow, it didn’t feel like an accusation. It felt like a reminder—a reminder that maybe, just maybe, he

didn’t always have to shoulder everything alone.

Mydei shifted uncomfortably, his gaze fixed on the horizon. “I don’t know how to be anything else.”

There was a beat of quiet before Phainon stepped closer, closing the distance between them. For once, Mydei didn’t retreat.

“You don’t have to be anything, Mydei.” Phainon’s words were quiet, but they held weight—gentle, but insistent. “Just… be yourself. Whatever that is.”

Mydei tensed, and for a moment, he thought he might snap at Phainon for speaking in riddles, but then something strange happened.

For the first time in *years*, something in him *shifted*.

The walls he had spent so long building around himself—walls of rage, of cold detachment—seemed to weaken, just for a second. He didn’t know if he could trust what was happening, but it felt right, in a way he couldn’t explain.

“I’m not good at this,” he muttered, his voice barely above a whisper, his eyes flicking back to Phainon.

Phainon gave him a small, understanding smile. “You don’t have to be. You just have to let someone in.”

It shouldn’t have felt as *comforting* as it did. It shouldn’t have. But the warmth in Phainon’s voice—the sincerity—made Mydei’s heart clench. He didn’t want to feel anything, but it was getting harder to ignore.

-

The night was still, the kind of stillness that made the air seem almost thick, as though everything was holding its breath. The stars above, far away yet so close, painted the sky in scattered constellations that Mydei knew by heart. They were the only things he could rely on to stay constant, but tonight, something felt different. He wasn’t sure what, but as he wandered

through the quiet paths of Okhema, his feet almost moving without thought, it became clear.

Phainon wasn't in the usual places—his chambers, the training yards, or the hallways. No, tonight, he was out there, beneath the sky, just as Mydei had been so many times before.

It wasn't hard to find him.

Phainon was sitting atop the city's highest wall, his legs dangling over the edge, the same way he always sat. The moonlight reflected off his hair, giving him an almost ethereal quality. He didn't look like someone who had been through the same destruction Mydei had. In fact, for all of his unruly tendencies, Phainon looked at peace.

It caught Mydei off guard. The sight of him, so calm.

He almost walked away, but something about the stillness, the way Phainon's silhouette softened in the moonlight, kept him rooted to the ground.

Without really thinking about it, Mydei climbed up beside him. He moved slowly, quietly, as if not to disturb the serenity of the moment, and as he sat next to Phainon, he saw the brief flicker of surprise in his eyes. It was gone in an instant, but Mydei still noticed.

"You're up late," Phainon said softly, his voice a little hoarse, as if he hadn't expected company.

Mydei shrugged, staring out at the city below. "Couldn't sleep."

There was a pause before Phainon let out a light laugh, a sound that was soft and almost… relaxed. "Neither could I."

It was strange, being there beside him, so close but still so distant. Mydei shifted slightly, then surprised himself when his hand brushed against Phainon's, almost like he didn't realize he was reaching for it.

Phainon didn’t pull away. Instead, he let his fingers settle against Mydei’s, warmth spreading between them like something natural.

Mydei swallowed the instinct to pull back. He just… didn’t want to.

The two of them sat there for a while, side by side, neither of them speaking. It was easy, like it had always been, and yet tonight it felt different. Mydei wasn’t sure if it was the soft glow of the stars above or the quiet steadiness of Phainon beside him, but it didn’t matter. He wasn’t thinking about the city’s crumbling walls or his own internal chaos. For the first time in a long while, he felt calm.

The sky stretched on, endless and filled with stars. Mydei glanced over at Phainon, who was staring up too, his face illuminated in soft light, not hiding anything, not forcing anything. Just… there.

“Did you ever think we’d be here?” Mydei asked, his voice barely louder than the wind.

Phainon turned his head slightly, their eyes meeting for the first time that night. His smile was small, but it was there. “No. But I don’t mind it.”

Mydei didn’t know how to respond. Instead, he leaned back slightly, pulling Phainon’s hand with him until their fingers laced together, quietly, almost naturally. It wasn’t a grand gesture—just the simple act of letting someone in.

Phainon let him.

They didn’t talk for a while after that, and neither of them seemed to need to. Mydei’s grip tightened just a little, not out of need, but because it felt right. When he closed his eyes, he could hear the soft rhythm of Phainon’s breath beside him, steady and real. It wasn’t a fleeting moment, like everything else in his life had been. It was… something he could hold onto.

In the distance, Okhema stretched out, still standing strong for the time being. Mydei allowed himself to believe it might not fall. Not tonight, at least.

And for a little while longer, he let himself simply be.

-

It happened unexpectedly, like most things did.

Phainon sat next to him, eyes focused on the horizon, but Mydei's thoughts were elsewhere. The quiet moments had become increasingly rare, and for some reason, that made them feel even more significant. It was strange—there was something about the way Phainon's presence filled the space, subtle yet undeniably strong. Mydei couldn't deny it anymore; he found comfort in it, even though it unnerved him.

When Phainon reached out, his fingers grazing Mydei's cheek as he brushed a stray lock of hair from his face, Mydei froze. The gentleness in the gesture was almost too much to process, like an invitation to something he wasn't sure he could handle. Phainon's eyes softened, a quiet, fond expression overtaking his features.

"You…" Phainon paused, as if contemplating his words, "I cherish you," he decided on that, his voice quiet but clear. "Please, don't forget that, Mydei. Truly, I care for you, and I'll always be here if you need me."

Something inside Mydei snapped. He couldn't take the tenderness, the warmth that Phainon always managed to pour into every word, every touch. It made his chest feel hollow and full at the same time, and he didn't know how to handle it.

Without thinking, Mydei grabbed Phainon's face, pulling him in roughly. Their lips collided in a fierce kiss, hard and unrelenting. Phainon didn't resist; instead, he met the kiss with equal force, his hands finding Mydei's waist as if grounding them both in the chaos of the moment. Mydei's grip tightened, his breath coming out in ragged bursts as he kissed Phainon over and over, almost desperate.

Time blurred as the kiss deepened, a constant rhythm between them that neither wanted to break. They pulled apart only when the air ran out, both gasping for breath, but it wasn't enough. Without a second thought, Mydei

closed the gap again, his lips claiming Phainon’s once more, this time more insistent, as if trying to drown out the things he couldn’t say.

Phainon, despite the heat, didn’t shy away. He let Mydei take the lead, his hands roaming to Mydei’s back, pulling him closer, if that was even possible. The kiss was no longer about force—it was a raw, unfiltered exchange, a silent reckoning with everything neither of them could express with words.

When they finally pulled back, both of them breathing heavily, Mydei’s forehead rested against Phainon’s, his eyes closing as he tried to steady himself. The world felt quieter, even though his heart was still racing, but somehow, everything felt more clear now.

Phainon smiled softly, a glint of satisfaction in his eyes. “You’re more than I ever thought you’d be,” he said, voice low, affectionate.

Mydei stayed silent, unsure of how to respond. But for the first time in what felt like forever, he didn’t feel like he had to fight it.

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The sun was beginning to set, casting a warm orange glow over Okhema’s skyline. Mydei had been walking through the market square, trying to lose himself in the usual bustle of activity. He hadn’t realized how long he’d been walking until he spotted Phainon, standing by a stall, his posture stiff and his arms awkwardly outstretched.

At first, Mydei didn’t think much of it. He was used to seeing Phainon here, pristine as always. But then he noticed it—the way Phainon was trying to pick up a basket of fruit, his fingers fumbling around the handles like they were foreign objects.

Mydei stopped in his tracks, his brow furrowing slightly. Was Phainon struggling with a basket?

His eyes narrowed, watching as Phainon finally managed to grab the basket, but in doing so, he knocked over an entire stack of apples that tumbled

across the ground. Phainon's face flushed a bright red as he hastily tried to gather them, looking around to make sure no one was paying attention.

Mydei's lips twitched, the strange sight of the usually poised Phainon scrambling like this—completely out of his element—was unexpectedly hilarious. For a brief, heart-stopping moment, he forgot the suffocating weight of his own mind. He forgot about the dark places his thoughts had been retreating to.

A laugh, unexpected and foreign, bubbled up in his chest.

He clamped his hand over his mouth, but it was too late. The laugh escaped him, a light, unintentional sound. It was soft at first, but as he watched Phainon struggle to recover his dignity, it grew, slipping from his lips before he could even stop it.

Phainon turned to him with wide, surprised eyes, clearly caught off guard. There was a beat of silence. Mydei's gaze flickered to the ground, biting the inside of his cheek, trying desperately to suppress the laughter that threatened to overtake him. He was laughing. *Laughing*.

The sound was so foreign that it almost felt like a betrayal to his own sorrow, but for some reason, seeing Phainon mess up in such a ridiculous, human way grounded him—made everything feel a little less suffocating. It was something normal in the midst of the chaos that had been his life for so long.

"Are you laughing at me?" Phainon asked, his voice tinged with mock offense as he knelt down to grab the last apple, his usual smooth confidence replaced by mild embarrassment.

"I—" Mydei began, but he couldn't finish the sentence. His chest tightened as he tried to hold back the overwhelming feeling that was building, the strange mix of laughter and something far softer—something more vulnerable. *Normalcy*.

Instead, Mydei quickly turned away, his back to Phainon, and bit his lip harder, trying to stop the warmth that had crept up in his eyes.

“Yeah, I guess I am,” Mydei said, his voice a little too tight. When he turned back around, there was a faint smile tugging at his lips, and though he tried to hide it, he couldn’t help the genuine glimmer of something like joy—or maybe relief—that had taken root in his chest.

Phainon gave him a knowing look, his lips curling into a smile that mirrored Mydei’s. “You know, you’re cruel for laughing at me like that,” he teased, but there was a softness behind it. “After all, I’m trying to be nice by gathering apples.”

Mydei blinked. He swallowed hard, taking in a shaky breath, but this time, it wasn’t from the weight of sadness or guilt. It was something else. Something lighter.

He gave Phainon a half smile. “Well, maybe you should practice picking up fruit first before doing any grand gestures.”

“Grand gestures?” Phainon raised an eyebrow in mock confusion, but his smile softened, a hint of amusement lighting up his eyes. “What do you mean by that?”

Mydei felt his cheeks flush, realizing what he’d said, and he quickly looked away, though the smile on his face didn’t vanish. “Forget it,” he muttered, wiping at his eyes, pretending it was nothing more than a stray piece of dust.

Phainon stood up and, with a dramatic flair, offered Mydei the basket of fruit as if he were presenting a treasure. “Then I’ll just leave the grand gestures to you, Mydei.”

And just like that, the moment passed. But for a brief, fleeting second, it was as if the world had stopped turning. The gravity of everything had lessened, just enough for Mydei to feel like he could breathe again.

He wasn’t alone.

And for the first time in a long while, he wasn’t drowning either.

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The air was crisp, the evening cool enough to make the warmth of the lantern-lit street feel almost comforting. Mydei didn't know why he let Phainon drag him out here, but he also didn't have the energy to argue. The day had been long, another mission completed, another mess cleaned up. The weight of it all—no, not weight, he reminded himself—just the strain of it settled in his muscles.

And then Phainon did something unexpected. He handed Mydei a small paper bag, warm to the touch.

"What is this?" Mydei asked, though he already knew. The scent of cinnamon and sugar gave it away.

"Pastries," Phainon said simply, as if this were a normal thing to do. As if they were just two people enjoying a quiet night instead of two warriors barely holding Okhema together. "Figured you might want something sweet."

Mydei frowned but didn't refuse. The bag crinkled as he reached in, fingers brushing against something soft and still warm. He pulled out one of the pastries—golden, flaky, filled with something dark at the center.

He took a bite. The filling was rich, some kind of fruit, and it melted on his tongue in a way that was almost unfamiliar. When was the last time he had something like this? He couldn't remember.

Across from him, Phainon had already taken a bite of his own, humming in satisfaction. The sound was easy, natural.

Mydei found himself watching, gaze drawn to the way Phainon enjoyed something so simple. The way his shoulders were relaxed for once, his expression unguarded.

And then he saw it.

A smudge of whipped cream, right at the corner of Phainon's lips.

He shouldn’t have been staring. He definitely shouldn’t have felt something unfamiliar coil in his stomach at the sight.

Phainon caught him looking, raising an eyebrow. “What?”

Mydei could have said nothing. He could have ignored it, let Phainon figure it out on his own.

Instead, he leaned forward, reaching out before he could stop himself. His thumb brushed against the corner of Phainon’s mouth, wiping away the cream. The touch was brief, but enough to make Phainon still beneath his fingers.

Mydei didn’t pull away immediately. His thumb lingered, just for a moment.

Phainon’s lips parted slightly, his breath warm against Mydei’s skin.

There was something about the way he looked then—caught off guard, unreadable yet oddly expectant.

And Mydei, despite himself, didn’t look away.

Phainon’s gaze flickered with something amused, something knowing. He didn’t move, didn’t speak, just watched Mydei, waiting.

A challenge.

Mydei could see it in the slight upward curve of his lips, in the way his eyes held steady, daring him to act.

So he did.

Instead of pulling away, Mydei lifted his thumb to his own lips, brushing it against his tongue as if considering the taste. He wasn’t sure why he did it—maybe to wipe away the lingering cream, maybe to test something. Maybe, deep down, he just wanted to see how Phainon would react.

And react he did.

Phainon’s smirk faltered, only slightly, but enough. A sharp exhale, barely noticeable unless one was paying attention. A flicker of something in his eyes—surprise? Interest? Anticipation?

Mydei didn’t know, but he didn’t regret it.

Phainon tilted his head slightly, leaning in, like he was going to say something. But he didn’t. Instead, his gaze dipped lower, tracing over Mydei’s lips, and then—just as quickly—he leaned back, smirking.

“You play dirty,” he mused, voice just a little rougher than before.

Mydei scoffed. “You started it.”

Phainon hummed, amused, but didn’t deny it. Instead, he shifted, glancing at their surroundings. The marketplace was still bustling, people moving past them without sparing them a second glance. Whatever moment had just passed between them, it was still hanging there, unspoken.

And Mydei, impulsively, grabbed Phainon’s wrist.

“Come with me.”

Phainon raised a brow but didn’t protest as Mydei pulled him through the streets, moving away from the crowd, away from the noise. The further they walked, the quieter it became, until they found themselves in an empty side alley, tucked between the stone walls of the old city.

Finally alone.

Phainon leaned against the wall, arms crossed, watching Mydei with that same insufferable amusement.

“Mydei,” he murmured, voice low. “If you wanted to be alone with me, you could’ve just asked.”

Mydei didn’t answer. He just took a step forward, closing the distance between them.

Phainon didn’t move away. Didn’t taunt him further. Just watched him, gaze half-lidded, lips still faintly curled.

It was infuriating.

And it was intoxicating.

Mydei exhaled sharply, then—before he could think, before he could hesitate—he grabbed Phainon by the collar once again and kissed him.

The kiss deepened, rough and possessive, as Mydei pulled Phainon closer. His hands were everywhere—on Phainon’s back, his neck, gripping him with a hunger that was hard to suppress. He felt his heartbeat pounding in his ears as he pushed Phainon into the wall with more force, the sound of their bodies meeting sharp and breathless.

Phainon’s hands slid up Mydei’s arms, his touch almost teasing as he traced the lines of muscle beneath Mydei’s skin. But Mydei wasn’t interested in teasing. Not now. He pulled back just enough to look Phainon in the eyes, then lowered his mouth to the side of his neck, lips grazing over soft skin. The warmth there made his blood boil, the need to mark him building in his chest.

Without hesitation, Mydei pressed his teeth into the skin of Phainon’s neck, hard enough to draw a soft gasp. He felt Phainon stiffen, but there was no resistance. Phainon wanted this. The moan that escaped his lips confirmed it. Mydei’s grip on Phainon tightened as he sucked, marking him, claiming him in the only way he knew how in that moment. The sting of his teeth was followed by the warmth of his mouth, the sharp contrast heightening the rush of desire.

Phainon’s fingers tightened in Mydei’s hair, urging him on. “Mydei,” he whispered, voice breathless and low.

Mydei didn’t answer. He only bit down harder, the feeling of Phainon’s pulse under his teeth pushing him further into the moment, the intensity of it overwhelming. He marked him again, moving to the other side of his neck, licking at the spot where his teeth had just been.

Phainon's hands slipped down to Mydei's back, fingertips pressing into his skin, urging him closer. He moaned softly, the sound making Mydei's pulse race. Phainon was losing himself too, caught in the storm of sensation and need.

Phainon's voice trembled as he spoke again, his words barely above a whisper. "Don't stop."

Mydei's only response was to move again, teeth sinking into Phainon's shoulder now, claiming him further, the taste of skin and the fact it was *Phainon* filled him with something primal. Each mark, each bite, made him feel more grounded, more in control—yet also utterly lost in the rush of it all.

Phainon gasped, his body pressing into Mydei's more urgently. His lips found Mydei's neck, kissing and nipping as Mydei worked his way down, his hands trailing over Phainon's body, mapping the terrain of him like he couldn't get enough.

The air between them thickened, charged with the heat of their bodies and the tension that built with every touch, every press of skin against skin. But it wasn't enough. Not yet. Mydei wanted more. Needed more.

The bite on Phainon's neck was a mark, but it was also a promise. Mydei wasn't going to stop until Phainon knew exactly what he meant to him, until Phainon could feel him and only him. He pulled away just enough to lock eyes with him, his breathing coming heavy.

Phainon's lips were swollen, his chest rising and falling quickly. "You're certainly persistent." he said softly, his voice almost a laugh.

Mydei's lips curled into a half-smile, but his expression was hard, determined. "Good, that's the point." he whispered, and then he kissed Phainon again, the marks on his neck still fresh, still burning.

Phainon pressed into Mydei, grinding slowly against him. The sensation of his body moving against Mydei's made him shudder, the heat between them

unmistakable. Phainon's hands slid lower, gripping Mydei's hips and pulling him closer, matching the rhythm of their bodies.

Mydei, still caught in the rush of everything, reacted without thinking. He rolled his hips, meeting Phainon's with a low groan, their bodies moving in sync as the pressure built between them. Phainon's lips traced a path along Mydei's jaw, barely brushing against his skin as he continued to grind against him, his own breath growing heavier.

Without missing a beat, Phainon's hand slid between them, his thumb brushed against the skin of his stomach. The pressure of their bodies, the friction, it was all too much, and Mydei found himself bucking forward, desperate for more.

Phainon's chuckle vibrated through the air, a low sound filled with satisfaction as he pressed even harder against Mydei, coaxing out another groan from his throat. "Is this what you wanted, Mydei?"

The words barely registered before Mydei's hands were on him again, pulling at Phainon's clothes, desperate for skin, for contact. His heart raced, pulse thrumming in his ears as his body burned for release.

The moment stretched and snapped. The slow drag of their bodies together, the heat, the urgency. Mydei barely heard anything, lost in the rhythm of it all, his mind going blank. He needed Phainon, needed this, and everything else disappeared. The world around them faded, leaving nothing but the sounds of their breathing, the harshness of their movements.

Mydei's lips were on Phainon's chest before he even realized it, the taste of his skin addicting as he licked along the curve of his collarbone. He paused there for a moment, tongue flicking against the tender flesh, before moving lower, teeth sinking into Phainon's nipple with a sharpness that made Phainon gasp. He barely gave Phainon a moment to react before his mouth was working on the other, rougher this time—marking him with bites that left the skin reddened and sensitive.

Phainon's hands were in his hair, guiding him, encouraging him with the pressure of his grip, but Mydei wasn't looking for guidance anymore. He

was past that. His mouth moved down Phainon's chest, barely pausing before coming back up, teeth scraping, skin warming beneath him. His actions were far more aggressive now, harder bites, but it was calculated—he wanted Phainon to feel every bit of it.

While his mouth was busy, Mydei shoved a finger into Phainon's mouth, forcing him to open wide. The surprised look in Phainon's eyes almost made Mydei smirk, but he didn't give him time to process it. "Suck," he said flatly, voice rougher than before. Phainon hesitated for a moment, a brief flash of confusion crossing his face, but then, almost instinctively, he complied. His mouth wrapped around Mydei's finger, and the sound of his sucking filled the space between them.

Mydei's eyes locked onto Phainon's as he pulled his finger away, his teeth coming down harder on Phainon's chest—this time with purpose, leaving a mark that would take days to fade. Phainon gasped, and Mydei leaned back, his gaze intense. "If you prefer I eat you out in an alleyway, I could make that happen," he said, voice low and blunt, cutting through the tension between them.

For a moment, Phainon looked like he was seriously considering it, his eyes flickering with a thought that Mydei couldn't quite place. But that brief hesitation passed quickly, and Phainon leaned into him, his lips curling up in a slow, hungry smile.

"Not here," Phainon said, voice thick with desire. "But I'm not complaining." His hands slid down, pulling Mydei closer, urging him to keep going.

Mydei didn't wait. His hands were at Phainon's pants now, pulling them off without care, his focus zeroing in on Phainon's reaction. There was no more hesitation, no more uncertainty—just the two of them, tangled with each other.

"Fuck," Phainon muttered under his breath as Mydei's hands moved over him, the heat in his voice making Mydei's pulse race. The moment was everything—just them, no filters, no pretenses. Mydei didn't need anything more than this. And Phainon? He wasn't going anywhere.

Mydei pulled back, hands still hovering near Phainon's pants, his breath coming in short bursts. His chest rose and fell, the intensity of the moment almost too much to handle. But then something in him stopped. He froze.

He couldn't do this here. Not like this. They hadn't even really talked about it, and now… an alleyway?

He gritted his teeth, trying to push back the heat rising within him. "No," he muttered, shaking his head. "Not in an alleyway."

But Phainon wasn't having it. In a flash, he grabbed Mydei's wrist, yanking him closer. His mouth was hot against Mydei's ear, voice low but laced with undeniable need.

"You don't get to decide that," Phainon murmured, his words sharp, almost daring. "You either fuck me here, or I'll make you use your fingers."

Mydei's pulse surged at the command in Phainon's tone, the need behind it. For a brief moment, he wanted to pull away, to stop, to say this wasn't right. But the pressure of Phainon's body against his, the undeniable heat, made it impossible to ignore the aching need burning between them.

Phainon's lips curled up, eyes gleaming with amusement but also dead seriousness. "You think I'm kidding? You're not the only one who can't wait anymore." His grip tightened on Mydei's wrist. "So what's it gonna be? Your fingers or my way?"

Before Mydei could stop himself, his hand was already moving. Phainon's words, the confidence in his voice, had triggered something deep in him. He slipped his fingers between Phainon's legs, pressing him against the wall. Phainon's breath caught, and Mydei could feel the heat of his body shudder beneath his touch.

"Fuck, Mydei," Phainon gasped, his voice thick with need. He leaned into the pressure, biting his lip to hold back the sounds that wanted to escape.

Mydei's grip on his wrist tightened. "Stop being so damn stubborn," he muttered, his fingers slipping in deeper. First it was one, then two, then

more. Phainon's hips bucked upward, seeking more, the sounds of his desperate breath feeding Mydei's desire. The way Phainon's body responded, the way his skin flushed, it was all too much.

Phainon's hand shot to the back of Mydei's neck, pulling him into a kiss that was frantic, hungry. When they pulled away, Phainon's lips were swollen, his breath ragged, eyes dark with desire.

"I'm not waiting anymore," he rasped. "Do it now."

And with that, Mydei's restraint broke, his need taking over as he pulled Phainon even closer, no more words needed between them.

Phainon's shift was instant, the playful teasing dropping into something much darker, much more urgent. His breath quickened, shallow gasps as he gripped Mydei harder, pulling him in closer, his lips crashing into Mydei's again. There was no lightness now, just a raw, desperate need.

"Mydei," Phainon rasped, voice hoarse with impatience. "Please."

The urgency in Phainon's voice made Mydei's pulse quicken. He could feel the tension in his own body breaking. Without hesitation, he pushed forward, slipping easily into Phainon's waiting body. Phainon was still tight, impossibly so, but there was no going back now.

Phainon's breath caught as Mydei filled him, his body instinctively pressing back against him. Mydei's hand found Phainon's jaw, fingers curling into his skin, tilting his head back as their lips met in a bruising kiss. He didn't waste time, his movements rough, pushing into Phainon with every ounce of the hunger he felt.

"Mydei," Phainon groaned, his voice low, needy, fingers digging into Mydei's shoulders. "Harder.."

That plea, the rawness of it, snapped something in Mydei. He tore his mouth from Phainon's and dragged it down his neck, biting hard at the skin, hearing Phainon's breath hitch with each sharp nip. His hands were all over him now, gripping Phainon's chest, tracing over the hard planes of his body

before moving down to his sensitive nipples. He pinched them, tugging, making Phainon gasp.

Phainon's body arched, his chest rising as he pushed into Mydei's touch. His nails raked down Mydei's back, pulling him closer. Phainon's body trembled beneath him, the sounds coming from him thick with desperation.

"Do it, Mydei," Phainon demanded, his voice shaking with need. "All the way. Don't make me wait."

The command made Mydei's head spin, his body moving almost involuntarily. He shifted Phainon's legs further apart, positioning himself just right before thrusting deep, forcing the air from both of their lungs. Mydei's hips moved fast, slamming into Phainon as the rhythm built, quick and unrelenting. Phainon's hands were on Mydei's neck, pulling him in for another desperate kiss. Teeth clashed, their tongues battling as their bodies moved together in frantic need.

"Mydei…" Phainon gasped, pulling him tighter. "So good—"

Every thrust was an explosion of sensation, the sound of their skin meeting filling the space around them. Mydei's cock slid in and out of Phainon's tight body, the friction driving them both closer to the edge. Phainon's hands dug into Mydei's skin, nails scraping as he urged Mydei to move faster, harder.

"*Mydei*…" Phainon moaned his name, his voice cracked with need. "Don't stop. I need more."

Mydei's hips bucked harder, more frantic now. The pressure was building, and Phainon's body was shaking under him, his moans getting louder as he clung to Mydei's body. Phainon's legs wrapped around Mydei's waist, pulling him deeper, wanting more.

Without warning, Phainon's back arched, his body going stiff as he came, releasing with a strangled cry, his cock pulsing between them. The sight of Phainon coming undone pushed Mydei over the edge, but he wasn't done

yet. He kept thrusting, his pace relentless, chasing his own release as Phainon's grip tightened on him.

Phainon's body trembled beneath him, his breath ragged, his hands moving to Mydei's shoulders, pulling him in for a kiss that was messy, hungry. Mydei's hips bucked again, hard, forcing every last bit of air from Phainon's lungs. And just before he lost control, Phainon's shaky voice broke through the fog.

"Inside," he breathed, his voice so raw, so desperate that it shattered Mydei's restraint.

With one last hard thrust, Mydei came, burying himself deep in Phainon's body. He stilled for a moment, his whole body shuddering as he spilled inside him. The heat between them was unbearable, but neither of them moved for a long while, their bodies still pressed together, trying to catch their breath.

Phainon's hand rested on Mydei's chest, his breath still uneven, a lazy smile tugging at his lips. "That was… great," he muttered, his voice low, almost a whisper.

Mydei pulled back slowly, his eyes flicking over Phainon's flushed face, feeling the satisfaction lingering in the air. He didn't know what to say, so he simply leaned in and kissed him again, this time slower, softer, as if savoring the moment before the reality of what just happened set in.

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The water was warm, steam curling around them, softening the harsh lines of the room. Mydei sat on the edge of the bath, his legs submerged, his back leaning against the cool marble. Phainon was beside him, his chest against Mydei's side as he leaned into him, the pressure subtle but comforting.

Phainon didn't speak at first, simply settling into the space between them. He reached out, running a finger down Mydei's arm, the touch light but grounding. The sound of the water, the quiet between them, felt like an anchor in the chaos of everything that had come before.

Mydei’s eyes stayed on the ripples in the water, the steam rising in lazy tendrils. For a long moment, there was only the sound of their breathing, synchronized now, as if they were both settling into something deeper, something unspoken.

It was a slow unraveling. Phainon’s fingers traced along Mydei’s arm, then down to his wrist, where they lingered for a moment, as if giving him space to breathe, to settle. Mydei’s hand moved slightly, just enough to brush against Phainon’s, and Phainon responded immediately, his fingers curling around Mydei’s in an unspoken promise.

The heat from the water seeped into Mydei’s bones, but it was the warmth of Phainon’s body against his that made him feel more alive, more real than he’d felt in a long time. He wasn’t sure what had changed or why it felt different this time, but something in him shifted.

His voice, when it came, was low, as though he were speaking to himself more than to Phainon. “I never thought I’d have something… like this.”

Phainon didn’t say anything at first, just squeezed his hand. Mydei felt the weight of it, but it wasn’t a burden. It was steady, certain, and for once, it felt like there was someone who wasn’t going to let go.

Mydei’s gaze lifted, meeting Phainon’s eyes for the first time in what felt like forever. There was something in those eyes, something open, and for a moment, the world beyond them didn’t exist.

He could feel his heart beat a little faster, a little more uneven. For the first time in ages, it wasn’t because of fear, but because of something else. Something he can now name as affection.

Phainon leaned in, his lips brushing against Mydei’s temple, and Mydei didn’t pull away. He stayed there, the quiet of the room pressing in around them as if this moment were a breath, something to hold onto. Phainon’s hand shifted, trailing down to Mydei’s side, fingertips skimming over his skin in a way that made Mydei’s breath catch.

Phainon’s voice was soft but firm, his lips brushing Mydei’s ear. “I’ll stay with you.”

The words weren’t anything new, but they were different when Phainon said them. There was no promise of forever, no heavy meaning behind them. Just the truth, plain and simple.

Mydei closed his eyes, feeling the tension in his chest loosen, even if only for a moment. He leaned back slightly, resting his head on Phainon’s shoulder, his eyes still closed as the heat of the water and Phainon’s touch grounded him.

Phainon kissed the top of his head, his hand settling against Mydei’s back, pulling him in closer. It was familiar now, the way they fit together. There were no words, no grand declarations. Just the space they shared, the quiet understanding between them.

For once, Mydei felt like he didn’t have to fight. There was someone here who wasn’t going to leave him, even if everything else fell apart. And that was all it took.

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Phainon watched Mydei, his body leaning slightly against him in the warm water, eyes half-closed in contentment. The quiet rhythm of his breathing filled the space between them, steady, predictable.

His fingers lightly traced the line of Mydei’s arm, then down to the curve of his ribs, still lingering where the steady pulse of his heart beat beneath the skin. The intimacy of the moment wasn’t lost on Phainon, but there was something else, something that tugged at the edges of his thoughts.

This… was almost too easy.

He could feel the way Mydei trusted him, the way his body relaxed under his touch, all the pieces falling into place without much effort on his part. There was no struggle, no hesitation. Just Mydei, so willing to give it all. The truth of it settled in his chest like a familiar, comfortable thing.

It wasn’t that he minded. No, far from it. But it was so simple, so easily achieved, that for a fleeting moment, Phainon wondered how much more he could pull from this.

But not now. Not yet.

He leaned back, letting the heat of the bath and the closeness of Mydei settle over him. A slight smile tugged at his lips, but it wasn’t for Mydei’s eyes. This was his to have for now and for as long as he wanted.

And Phainon wasn’t in a rush to make it anything else.

Chapter End Notes

Kudos to anyone who guesses what’s gonna happen in the next chapter. Anyway I PROMISE Phaidei will come soon guys, just not now.

As I can see at the end though I kind of slacked off (Cue repetition of kisses for some reason) so uh…Plz excuse that, but still hoped yall enjoyed it, ty for reading😭

(Before yall say anything yes I know I need to polish my smut writing skills, IM WORKING ON ITTTTT)

Edge of Light

Chapter Notes

> I am finishing this motherfucker before 3.1 whether anyone likes it or not, I have cried blood, sweat and tears while writing this trying to meet my quota of words but fuck if I don't finish this by morning….

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei floated in a tranquil expanse, a dream state that felt light, almost ethereal. There was no pressure, no expectations—just the gentle sensation of being untethered. The world around him was a soft blend of colors, muted and warm, like a fading sunset. He felt at peace, embraced by the silence that enveloped him.

But as time drifted, that serenity began to warp. Shapes flickered at the edges of his vision, shadows twisting in the periphery. The warmth faded, replaced by a creeping chill that gnawed at his skin. The soft hues morphed into stark greys, an oppressive weight pressing down on his senses.

Suddenly, he stood in a graveyard, the air thick with an unshakable sense of foreboding. Tombstones jutted from the earth like jagged teeth, their inscriptions fading into obscurity. Mydei's heart raced, not from fear but from an inexplicable understanding that something was very wrong. The stillness morphed into something uncanny, as if the world held its breath.

Then, faces emerged from the shadows, their expressions frozen in anguish, a collective sorrow that filled the air like a dense fog. Mydei stumbled back, confusion twisting in his gut. He turned, searching for escape, only to find that he was not alone. The graveyard pulsed with an unearthly energy, a sense of anticipation that made his skin crawl. And then, something eldritch, grotesque, began to materialize in the distance—a silhouette shifting against the backdrop of a waning moon.

His heart dropped as the figure loomed closer, its presence suffocating, an ancient hunger emanating from its very being. Just as abruptly, he was

thrust back into a different dream.

Now, he wandered the familiar streets of Okhema. Yet something was off—an unnatural silence gripped the city, and vibrant colors faded to muted tones, as if life itself had been drained. The buildings loomed overhead, their shadows elongated, but no one looked at him. Heads were bowed, bodies moving like puppets on strings, each step a mechanical dance devoid of emotion.

An unsettling chill wrapped around him as he walked. The streets, once bustling with life, now felt hollow. A growing sense of dread seeped into his bones, a realization that this dream was a reflection of something deeper, a cycle he couldn’t escape.

He approached an unmarked grave, its surface unremarkable against the backdrop of despair. But as he leaned closer, recognition struck him like a bolt of lightning. It was Aglaea’s grave, a cruel mockery of their fleeting connection.

Without warning, the faceless figures around him turned, their necks snapping in a synchronized motion, a grotesque display that sent ice through his veins. They bore no features, only an emptiness that echoed the hollow ache in his chest.

Mydei staggered back, fear rooting him in place as the reality of his situation washed over him. This was more than a dream; it was a haunting, a reminder of everything he had lost and everything that was yet to come. He could feel their vacant gazes piercing into him, a judgment as cold as the grave.

As he stood there, the air thickening with palpable dread, the world began to dissolve around him. The faces faded into darkness, and he felt his heart drop, as if severed from him completely. Everything vanished into nothingness, leaving him stranded in an unsettling void.

Mydei jolted awake, the remnants of the dream lingering like shadows at the edge of his consciousness. The familiar surroundings of his room came into focus, but they felt eerily distant, as if he were viewing them through a

glass pane. He lay still for a moment, holding his breath, the quiet pressing down around him like a heavy shroud.

Nothing surprised him anymore—no more shock at the surreal visions that haunted his nights. But today felt different. The air charged with a sense of foreboding, as if the very fabric of reality trembled in anticipation. Shifting slightly, he felt an unsettling twist in his chest, as if the dream had carved something new within him.

Sitting up, he raked a hand through his hair, a deep breath escaping him as he dissected the dream with a detached calm. The graveyard, the faceless figures, the eldritch presence—each element had its place in the mosaic of his mind, each a piece of a puzzle that hinted at something darker lurking beneath the surface of his reality.

The echoes of despair resonated within him. The dream had bared its teeth, and he couldn't shake the sensation that it meant something profound—a warning wrapped in metaphor. Aglaea's grave—why her? Did it signify a loss he hadn't fully processed? Or was it a reminder of the life he once clung to, now slipping through his fingers?

Mydei stood, movements deliberate and almost methodical, as he paced the room. The walls felt as if they were closing in, the memories of those faceless figures pressing against his mind like a haunting melody. What did it mean to dream of an empty city, devoid of life? The absence of color mirrored his own fading hopes, a reflection of a world drained of vibrancy.

An itch of dread crawled up his spine as he recalled the eldritch figure that loomed at the edge of the graveyard. Its presence had been suffocating, an entity thriving in shadows, whispering of untold horrors. Was it a manifestation of his own fears? Or something more, a specter of fate that threatened to engulf him?

Every dream had come with a lesson, and he couldn't ignore the chill gripping his heart. This was a warning, a sign that the fabric of his reality was fraying, that he was teetering on the edge of something monstrous.

He glanced out the window, early morning light filtering through the grime, illuminating the world outside. The streets of Okhema seemed deceptively calm, yet he felt an underlying tension, as if the city itself held its breath, waiting for something to unfold.

Mydei stepped back, leaning against the wall, his heart racing in sync with the pounding of dread in his chest. Something was coming—he could feel it in the marrow of his bones. The dream had stripped him bare, exposing his vulnerabilities, and he was left grappling with a chilling realization: the boundaries between his dreams and reality were blurring, and whatever had emerged from the depths of his mind would not be easily contained.

The weight of the dream lingered, but Mydei refused to let it unnerve him. Instead, he took a slow breath, grounding himself in the present. The edges of fear sharpened into something else—clarity.

These dreams weren't just dreams. He had long since stopped doubting that. They meant something, left breadcrumbs, clues buried beneath layers of cryptic imagery. And this one… this one had been louder than the rest.

His fingers twitched at his side. The city drained of color. The faceless figures. The grave. And that thing that had watched him, that had felt real. It wasn't just another nightmare. It was a message.

And messages could be deciphered.

He moved without hesitation now, dressing quickly, strapping on his shoes. The usual morning haze, the slow lull between sleep and waking, didn't touch him today. There was no time for it. His mind was already working through the pieces.

Aglaea. Why had it been her grave? Was it a metaphor? A warning? He hadn't thought about her in a long time—had forced himself not to. What was his mind trying to tell him now?

He left his room, steps steady, gaze sharp. The city outside stretched before him, bathed in early morning light, but something about it felt different today. He had seen it empty in his dream, its people silent, avoiding him.

Now, as he walked, he studied every passerby with scrutiny. Did they look at him differently? Did they know something he didn't?

No, that was paranoia. He exhaled, pushing it down.

First, he needed information. He couldn't afford to chase vague impressions. There were people who kept records—of deaths, of burials, of disappearances. Aglaea's grave existed, marked somewhere.

And if it wasn't?

Then that meant something too.

Either way, he was going to find out.

-

Mydei stepped into the cool morning air, the remnants of his dream clinging to him like a heavy fog. Today felt different—a restless compulsion pulled him toward Aglaea's grave, a place where memories mingled with shadows of regret. He navigated the familiar streets of Okhema, each step a deliberate act to push past the echoes of his night terrors.

As he rounded a corner, he collided with a force that felt like sunlight cutting through the gloom. Phainon stood before him, effortlessly charming, an easy smile dancing on his lips. It had been two weeks since they had crossed that unspoken threshold, and Mydei's heart twisted at the sight of him—comforting yet laced with an undercurrent of danger.

"Going somewhere?" Phainon asked, his voice teasing, a glint of mischief in his eyes.

Mydei raised an eyebrow, irritation flaring at the interruption. "Yeah, actually. I have things to do." The words came out sharper than intended, but he couldn't shake the feeling that the graveyard loomed in his mind. Confessing that felt like a betrayal.

"Things can wait." Phainon stepped closer, his presence a tantalizing distraction. "You should take a break from all that brooding. The sun is

shining, and the city is alive. Why not enjoy it?”

“I said I have things to do.” Mydei’s voice was firmer, though he felt the warmth of Phainon’s presence tug at him. “This isn’t some idle stroll.”

Phainon brushed his fingers along Mydei’s forearm, a gesture that sent a jolt of awareness coursing through him. “What’s more important than sharing a moment with me?”

Mydei fought against the instinct to lean into the touch, aware of the precarious line he was treading. “I need to find something out,” he finally admitted, the words slipping out as if confessing a secret.

“Something?” Phainon feigned confusion, his eyes sparkling with playfulness. “What’s so pressing that it can’t wait for a stroll? The city isn’t going anywhere.” He gestured toward the vibrant life around them. “Come on, let’s walk. Just for a little while.”

Mydei felt his heart race, the tug of Phainon’s charm hard to resist. “Fine,” he relented, though he held onto his irritation like a shield. “Just for a moment.”

They walked side by side, the city buzzing with life, but Mydei’s thoughts remained anchored in the shadow of Aglaea’s grave. The ache in his chest tightened, memories tugging at him like persistent ghosts.

“You seem distant,” Phainon remarked, glancing sideways with a mix of curiosity and concern. “What’s on your mind?”

“Nothing.” Mydei’s tone was clipped, the warmth of Phainon’s attention feeling both invasive and comforting. “I’m just…thinking.”

“Thinking can be dangerous,” Phainon replied, teasing yet tinged with something deeper. “It’s far more enjoyable to simply be.” He leaned in closer, brushing against Mydei, their shoulders almost touching, igniting a tension he couldn’t ignore.

Mydei fought against the urge to pull away, the gentle pressure of Phainon's body language urging him to stay. "Look, I'm not in the mood for distractions," he said, trying to keep his tone steady, though he could feel the walls around his heart crack slightly.

"Come on, Mydei," Phainon said softly, his voice a low invitation. "Let me show you something. Let's forget about all the heavy thoughts for a moment."

Mydei swallowed hard, the temptation clashing with the remnants of his irritation. "I don't know…" he started, his resolve weakening.

"Trust me." Phainon's eyes locked onto his, earnest and captivating. "Just breathe. I promise I won't let you fall."

In that moment, Mydei felt ensnared, the tension in his chest unwinding slightly. He took a deep breath, surrendering to the moment, letting the warmth of Phainon's presence envelop him. The journey to Aglaea's grave faded into the background, obscured by the intimacy of their connection. The shadow loomed still, but it felt distant now, almost bearable.

For now, in this stolen moment, he chose to indulge in distraction, letting the weight of his worries slip away, if only for a while.

Phainon led him through the winding streets of Okhema with a casual ease, his hands tucked loosely behind his back, as if he had all the time in the world. Mydei followed, tense despite himself, scanning the city as they moved. The dream still clung to him like a damp fog, its weight pressing against his ribs. The faceless figures, the empty streets, Aglaea's grave—all of it lingered in his mind, making every shadow feel sharper, every quiet moment too loud.

They passed through a market street, the air thick with the scent of spiced meats and the bite of citrus. The city was alive, buzzing with movement, vendors shouting their wares, coins clinking in fast exchanges. It was the kind of scene Mydei had walked through countless times, but today it felt… off. He couldn't put his finger on it—just a feeling, an itch beneath his skin, as if the world around him wasn't sitting quite right.

Phainon, however, seemed unbothered. If anything, he was reveling in the moment, smiling at passing merchants, plucking a dried fig from a vendor's stall without hesitation. He tossed it to Mydei, who caught it on reflex, staring at the wrinkled fruit in his palm as if it might dissolve into ash.

"You're brooding again," Phainon remarked, biting into his own piece, voice laced with amusement. "I can practically see the storm cloud hanging over your head."

"I'm thinking," Mydei corrected, his tone clipped.

Phainon exhaled an exaggerated sigh. "Yes, and as I've said before, thinking too much is bad for your health." He nudged Mydei's shoulder, his touch brief, barely there, but enough to send a jolt through him. "Come on. I'm taking you somewhere."

"I don't need—"

"I wasn't asking," Phainon interrupted, his grin widening as he grabbed Mydei's wrist and tugged him forward.

Mydei let out a quiet growl of irritation but didn't pull away. He could have, easily. Phainon's grip was firm but not unbreakable. Yet Mydei let himself be led, if only because arguing further felt like more effort than it was worth.

They weaved through the market and slipped into a quieter part of the city, where the stone streets grew narrower and the sounds of trade faded into the distance. Mydei's shoulders remained stiff, his unease deepening with every step. The city wasn't supposed to feel like this. He'd walked these streets before, and yet today, they felt unfamiliar in a way he couldn't articulate.

Phainon finally stopped in front of a small terrace overlooking the city. A stone ledge framed the view, and beyond it, the rooftops of Okhema stretched into the horizon, bathed in warm, golden light. The sky above was a soft gradient of deepening blue, the first hints of evening creeping in.

Phainon leaned against the ledge, stretching his arms out as if embracing the air itself. “See? Peace. No nightmares here, just a city that’s too busy to care about whatever storm is brewing in your head.”

Mydei hovered near the edge, arms crossed tightly over his chest. He hated how easily Phainon peeled away his defenses, how effortlessly he pulled him into his rhythm. He shouldn’t be here, indulging in distractions when his dream still gnawed at him. And yet, as he took in the view, something inside him loosened, just a fraction.

But the itch beneath his skin remained.

The city below was alive, vibrant, and yet—wrong. His eyes flicked across the streets, searching, scanning. The way the people moved, the rhythm of it—it wasn’t… natural. It was too orderly. Too precise. As if they were all following some unseen pattern.

Phainon tilted his head, watching him with a knowing look. “You’re still doing it.”

“There’s something off,” Mydei muttered. “Can’t you feel it?”

Phainon hummed as if considering. “Or maybe you’re just looking for something to be wrong.”

Mydei’s jaw tightened. “That dream wasn’t just a dream.”

Phainon sighed, his teasing edge softening—just a little. “Maybe not. But you’re here, now.” He reached out, fingers grazing Mydei’s wrist again, grounding him. “Can’t you be here, just for a moment?”

Mydei exhaled sharply, looking away, unwilling to meet the warmth in Phainon’s gaze. The city stretched before him, pulsing with life, but that nagging sense of unease wouldn’t let him go.

Still, he didn’t move.

Phainon was patient. He always was, in his own way.

And Mydei, despite everything, despite the wrongness pressing at the edges of his senses—

He stayed.

Mydei leaned against the railing, his posture languid, arms crossed as he gazed down at the city. The tension in his shoulders had loosened, just slightly, though he wouldn't admit it out loud. Beside him, Phainon shifted closer, not enough to touch but enough to be felt—a steady, warm presence.

"You're quiet," Phainon mused, his voice soft, lacking its usual teasing lilt. "That's rare."

Mydei scoffed but didn't look at him. "You say that like I'm always running my mouth."

Phainon hummed, tilting his head. "Not always. Just when you're irritated." He nudged him lightly with his shoulder. "And when you're trying not to care about something."

Mydei didn't flinch away this time. He stayed still, watching as the wind carried the faint sounds of the city up to them. "And you're always this insistent?"

"Only when it's important." Phainon's voice was quieter now, sincere, slipping beneath Mydei's skin. "I can tell something's weighing on you."

Mydei pressed his lips into a thin line. He could feel Phainon's eyes on him, searching, waiting. It made something in his chest twist—something unfamiliar, like a thread being tugged loose. He wasn't used to this, to someone seeing through him so easily.

"I had a dream," he admitted, the words escaping before he could stop them. He sighed, rubbing a hand over his face. "It doesn't matter."

Phainon didn't push. He didn't demand details or tease him for it. Instead, he leaned forward against the railing, mirroring Mydei's posture, his voice light but careful. "Sometimes dreams tell us things we don't want to hear."

Mydei turned his head slightly, just enough to catch the soft expression on Phainon's face. It wasn't pity—he wouldn't have tolerated that. It was understanding. A quiet patience.

"Yeah," Mydei murmured, looking away again. "I know."

They stood there for a long moment, the silence between them comfortable, stretching out like something fragile but steady. Mydei didn't realize how close they'd become until the warmth of Phainon's arm brushed against his own.

He could have moved. Should have, maybe. But he didn't.

Instead, he let himself stay there, eyes tracing the city below, his heart beating a little too loud in his ears.

Mydei lingered where Phainon had led him, resting an arm against the railing as he gazed out over the city. His posture was deceptively relaxed, his expression unreadable, but the weight of the morning—of the dream—still pressed against his thoughts. He didn't want to talk about it. Especially not with Phainon, whose presence always made him feel too exposed, too seen.

Phainon, of course, wasn't one to let things be. "You're still so quiet, Mydei," he mused, watching him. "That's not like you."

"I don't feel like talking," Mydei said flatly, they'd already gone through this, why's he repeating his words?

Phainon hummed in amusement, undeterred. "Since when?"

Mydei shot him a sharp glance. "Since now."

But Phainon didn't step away. If anything, he drifted closer, his movements unhurried, deliberate. "You were heading somewhere before I stopped you," he noted. "Something important?"

"Not particularly." Mydei's reply was smooth, but Phainon caught the slight tension in his jaw, the way his fingers curled subtly against the railing.

“Liar.”

Mydei exhaled through his nose, irritated but not surprised. He turned his gaze back to the horizon, willing the conversation to end there.

It didn’t.

Phainon took another step, closing the space between them, and Mydei—without thinking—edged back slightly. A mistake. The cool metal of the railing pressed against his lower back, and before he could adjust, Phainon braced his arms on either side of him, palms resting lightly against the railings. Not pinning him, not quite. But close. Close enough that Mydei became acutely aware of how little distance remained between them.

Phainon smiled, slow and knowing. “You’re acting like you have something to hide.”

“Or maybe I just don’t like being cornered.” Mydei’s voice was sharp, but there was a slight hitch in it, betraying his composure.

Phainon tilted his head, his breath warm against the space between them.

“Cornered?” he echoed, amusement threading through his tone. “You could push past me if you really wanted to.”

Mydei hated that he had a point. He could move—should move—but his body betrayed him, heat creeping up his neck, irritation mixing with something he refused to name. Phainon was too close. His eyes, gold in the morning light, held him in place, as if waiting for something.

Then—

“Mydei!”

The voice shattered the moment like glass. Mydei jerked his head toward the source, heart still hammering in his chest.

Phainon, to his credit, didn’t seem the least bit bothered. He sighed, stepping back as though nothing had happened, leaving Mydei with too

much space and not enough air.

“Well,” Phainon mused, glancing toward the interruption. “Saved just in time, I suppose.”

Mydei scowled, willing the heat in his face to subside. He was going to kill whoever had interrupted—right after he got a grip on himself.

As Mydei turned, he found himself face-to-face with a young Kremnos refugee—one of many who had fled with him after the fall of their homeland. The child’s cheeks were smudged with dust, but their eyes gleamed with unshaken excitement. Clutched tightly in their small hand was a frayed toy, a relic of the life they had left behind.

“Mydei! Mydei!” The child bounced on their heels, breathless. “Come see! I found something!”

He exhaled, irritation flickering at the edges of his composure. Not now. Not when Phainon was standing so close, not when the moment between them had been so precariously balanced. But the child was looking up at him, expectant, too bright-eyed to turn away.

“What is it?” Mydei asked, his voice steady, though the tension had yet to fully leave his body.

“A secret place! You’ll love it!”

Their excitement was infectious, their enthusiasm unwavering. Mydei hesitated, glancing over his shoulder. Phainon still leaned lazily against the railing, arms draped in a way that felt almost deliberately careless. That familiar smirk tugged at his lips—bemused, knowing. Mydei clenched his jaw at the sight of it. Always so damn sure of himself.

A small hand tugged at his sleeve. “Come on!”

He sighed. “Alright, alright,” he relented, straightening. A part of him felt like he was retreating—stepping away from something unspoken. He

wouldn’t acknowledge that. Instead, he focused on the child’s eager steps as they led him away, leaving behind the phantom heat of Phainon’s proximity.

Even as the city’s noise swallowed them, Mydei could still feel him watching.

The child wove through the streets, talking the entire way, their small voice filling the silence Mydei didn’t realize he’d been carrying. Eventually, they ducked into a narrow alley where the walls were worn with age, the murals upon them faded but still bursting with color. Sunlight pooled through the cracks in the stone, illuminating a small patch of wildflowers that had taken root despite everything.

“See?” The child turned to him, beaming. “They’re still growing!”

For a moment, Mydei simply stared. The flowers—delicate yet stubborn—stood defiantly in the light, their colors stark against the worn stone. Something in his chest tightened, not in pain but in something quieter, something he wasn’t sure he knew how to name.

“They’re beautiful,” he murmured, crouching to touch one of the petals.

“Just like you!” the child chirped.

He scoffed, shaking his head as he ruffled their hair. “You’ve got bad eyesight.”

The child laughed, utterly unconcerned, and Mydei let himself be drawn into it. For just a moment, the world felt smaller, simpler. He could almost forget the conversation left unfinished—the proximity of Phainon’s face, the way his arms had boxed him in against the railing. Almost.

But not quite.

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Phainon remained where Mydei had left him, the last echoes of his presence still lingering in the space between breaths. The air was thinner without him, the city’s hum suddenly distant, as if dulled at the edges.

He tilted his head, exhaling slowly. So close. Mydei had been cornered, pressed back against the railing with nowhere left to go, his sharp tongue faltering for once. Phainon had seen the way his breath hitched, how his resolve wavered beneath the teasing. A single push, and perhaps he would've—

But then the child had called out. The moment shattered, slipping through his fingers like sand.

Phainon tapped his fingers against the railing, the motion unhurried, but something darker coiled beneath his skin. It wasn't jealousy. No, that would be petty. It was something else entirely. Mydei had turned away too easily, his focus shifting like Phainon hadn't just unraveled a thread of his defenses.

A low chuckle escaped him.

Mydei was still holding onto the illusion of choice. Of distance. But the truth was already settling in around them, slow and inevitable.

Phainon let his gaze drift toward the city, where somewhere beyond the winding streets, Mydei was caught in a fleeting moment of peace. Let him have it. Let him think he had pulled away.

Because in the end, Mydei always found his way back to him.

And soon, he wouldn't be able to walk away at all.

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Mydei returned to find Phainon where he'd left him, leaning against the railing with an air of idle amusement, as if he had never once doubted that Mydei would come back.

The sunset had deepened, staining the sky in hues of violet and crimson, casting long, flickering shadows across the city below. Phainon turned his head slightly at Mydei's approach, his blue eyes gleaming in the fading light.

“You’re good with children,” Phainon mused, his voice light, conversational. But there was something beneath it, something illegible. “It suits you.”

Mydei tensed at the remark, a flicker of irritation rising in his chest. “It’s nothing,” he muttered, brushing past him. “They needed something to hold on to. That’s all.”

Phainon hummed in acknowledgment, pushing off the railing with easy grace. He fell into step beside Mydei as if it were the most natural thing in the world. “That’s what you do, isn’t it?” he said, casting Mydei a sidelong glance. “Give people something to hold on to. Even when you have nothing left for yourself.”

Mydei exhaled sharply, shaking his head. “Spare me the analysis,” he said, but the words lacked their usual bite. The moment with the child had softened something in him, made it harder to summon the same sharp-edged resistance.

Phainon didn’t press, only chuckled, the sound rich and knowing. “Come on. You look like you could use a distraction.”

“I’m fine.”

“Are you?” Phainon tilted his head, considering. Then, without waiting for an answer, he gestured toward the street ahead. “There’s a place not far from here. Good food, quiet atmosphere. Humor me.”

Mydei hesitated. He should say no. He should put distance between them, shake off whatever strange pull Phainon had over him. But he didn’t.

“Fine,” he relented. “Just for a little while.”

Phainon smiled, the kind of smile that felt like a victory, though Mydei couldn’t tell whose.

They walked side by side through the winding streets, the city settling into the lull between dusk and nightfall. Lamps flickered to life, casting warm

glows over the cobbled paths. The tension from before faded, replaced by something easier, something that almost felt normal.

Phainon let the silence linger for a time before speaking again. “You know, you don’t always have to carry everything alone.” His tone was softer now, almost gentle, like he was offering something real.

Mydei scoffed, but it wasn’t harsh. “And what, you’ll carry it for me?”

Phainon’s eyes flickered with something unreadable. “If you let me.”

Mydei looked away, pretending to be more interested in the dimly lit street than the weight of Phainon’s words. He didn’t have a response for that, not one that wouldn’t give too much away.

And Phainon, ever patient, didn’t push. He only smiled to himself as they continued walking, their steps falling in sync, the distance between them growing smaller with every moment.

They reached the quiet eatery Phainon had mentioned, a tucked-away place with lanterns casting soft, flickering light over polished wooden tables. It was quiet, just as promised, the hum of the city muffled by thick walls and heavy curtains. Mydei slid into his seat with the ease of someone who didn’t care for the pretense of decorum, stretching out his legs beneath the table.

Phainon sat across from him, watching with that same unreadable look from before, but something shifted in his posture when Mydei leaned back, settling in like he belonged there. Mydei tilted his head, eyeing Phainon as he picked up a glass of wine from the table between them. The way the dim light glowed against his skin made something stir in Mydei’s chest, but he ignored it in favor of something far more entertaining—the way Phainon’s fingers tightened ever so slightly around the stem of his own glass, his carefully maintained composure beginning to fray.

“Oh?” Mydei murmured, letting the sound roll off his tongue in lazy amusement. He turned the glass in his hand, taking a slow sip before meeting Phainon’s gaze. “Something on your mind?”

Phainon’s blue eyes narrowed slightly, his lips pressing together for a fraction of a second before curving into a smirk. “You tell me,” he countered smoothly, but there was something else now—a slight stiffness in his movements, a tell.

Mydei almost laughed.

Instead, he leaned forward, resting his chin in his palm, watching Phainon with the kind of look that could be mistaken for idle interest, but wasn’t. “You keep staring at me like that,” Mydei said, voice deceptively casual, “and I’ll start thinking you actually like me.” It was an obvious provocation, of course Phainon did, and likewise so did he.

But Phainon still went unnaturally still for half a heartbeat.

Then, he chuckled, shaking his head as he took a sip of his wine, but it wasn’t enough to mask the way his fingers flexed slightly around the glass. “And what if I do?”

“*Oh*?” Mydei said again, slower this time, watching as Phainon’s breath hitched, so subtle that anyone else wouldn’t have noticed.

It was a fascinating thing, seeing Phainon react to him like this.

So, Mydei pressed.

He leaned in further, resting his forearm on the table, bringing himself just close enough that Phainon had nowhere to look but at him. “Then I suppose I’d have to do something about it.” His voice dropped lower, softer, a brush of velvet over steel. “Wouldn’t I?”

Phainon had always been a master of self-restraint, but Mydei saw the slight parting of his lips, the way his throat moved when he swallowed, the flicker of something almost vulnerable before it was quickly masked.

It was intoxicating.

And Mydei, for once, was the one pushing Phainon’s buttons.

He let the silence stretch just long enough before he sat back again, exhaling as if he'd lost interest—though they both knew better. He picked up his glass, swirling the juice in it idly before taking another slow sip. "You're quiet all of a sudden," he mused. "Did I say something to fluster you?"

Phainon recovered fast, but not fast enough. His smirk returned, but the corner of his mouth twitched like he was holding back something more genuine. "Not at all," he lied.

"Hmm." Mydei pretended to believe him.

And then, just as he was about to lean in again, to push just a little more, the door to the restaurant creaked open. A waiter was asking for their order, breaking whatever had been thrumming between them.

Phainon exhaled through his nose, quiet, controlled, but Mydei didn't miss the way his shoulders relaxed ever so slightly.

Well, Mydei thought, amused. This was going to be *fun*.

The waiter's departure left a quiet stillness between them, the space charged yet unspoken. Mydei watched as Phainon lifted his glass again, his movements smooth, practiced—but there was a shift, barely perceptible. A touch more controlled, as if steadying himself.

Mydei let the silence breathe, idly turning his own glass between his fingers, watching how the candlelight caught in the wine, deep and rich, much like the way the lamplight flickered in Phainon's eyes.

"You looked relieved just now," he remarked, tilting his head slightly.

Phainon glanced up, looking at Mydei faintly. "Did I?"

Mydei hummed, neither confirming nor denying, only watching the way Phainon held himself a fraction too still. "Did I make you nervous?"

A pause. Just long enough to be telling.

Then Phainon exhaled softly through his nose, setting his glass down with careful precision. “You think quite highly of yourself.”

“You’re avoiding the question.” Mydei rested his chin against his knuckles, gaze unshaken. “Which is interesting.”

Phainon’s lips curved—not quite a smirk, but close. “And if I said no?”

“I might believe you.” Mydei took a slow sip, letting the words settle. “Or I might not.”

Phainon traced the rim of his glass, the motion absent, but Mydei caught the subtle tension in his wrist, the quiet restraint.

“You have a habit,” Phainon mused after a moment.

“Oh?”

“You prod,” he said, as if considering aloud. “Like you’re looking for something. A weak spot, maybe.” He lifted his gaze, meeting Mydei’s over the rim of his glass, blue eyes half-lidded, guarded. “Have you found one?”

Mydei smiled, just faintly. “Would it bother you if I had?”

Phainon’s smirk was measured, deliberate. “Not at all.”

Liar.

But Mydei let it pass, leaning back as the waiter returned with their meals. The interruption was brief, polite, yet by the time they were alone again, something between them had shifted. The conversation carried on, light and unhurried, but beneath it lingered the trace of something unresolved.

Mydei had no intention of settling it. Not yet.

As the evening stretched on, their conversation drifted between idle musings and sharp-edged remarks, circling the unspoken. Mydei played the part well—relaxed, engaged, entirely at ease. He let his amusement flicker

through, a half-smile here, a slow tilt of his head there, watching Phainon with a gaze just a little too steady. Just enough to make him wonder.

Phainon held himself well, as he always did, but Mydei noticed the way he reached for his glass more often, the measured pause before certain responses. How his fingers lingered at the stem just a fraction longer than necessary.

Leaning forward slightly, Mydei let his voice drop, just enough to shift the air between them. “You’ve been watching me all night.”

Phainon didn’t flinch, but his grip on the glass tightened—briefly, barely. “Observing,” he corrected, smoothly.

“Mm.” Mydei tilted his head, as if considering. “And what have you observed?”

Phainon met his gaze, composed, yet something about it felt more carefully placed than before. “That you enjoy pressing my limits.”

Mydei smiled, slow and knowing. “I like seeing what people do when pushed.” He tapped a finger against the rim of his glass, the sound light, almost absent. “You’re interesting.”

Phainon chuckled, low and indulgent. “Flattering.”

“I wasn’t trying to be.” Mydei’s voice remained even, but his gaze flickered lower, just once, just enough. When he looked back up, Phainon was already watching him, blue eyes sharpened, as if weighing something.

Mydei let the silence stretch before leaning back, an easy, effortless shift. “I think I like you like this,” he murmured, almost to himself.

Phainon raised a brow. “Like what?”

Mydei only smiled, finishing his drink with slow deliberation. Then he set his glass down and stood, the movement fluid, unrushed.

“I’ll let you wonder,” he said, voice light, but edged with something that stayed behind.

Then he turned, stepping past Phainon with the faintest brush of movement—just enough to be noticed. He could feel Phainon’s gaze on his back as he walked away, and he didn’t need to look to know he had left him thinking.

As they continued their silent walk together, Phainon moved to stand, adjusting his sleeve, but before he could step away, Mydei followed suit, cutting off his path with an almost absent motion. Close, but not imposing. Just there.

Phainon glanced at him questioningly. “Something else on your mind?”

Mydei hummed, as if considering, before reaching out—not with force, not with the urgency Phainon might have expected. No, this was different. His fingers barely brushed Phainon’s sleeve, and then—

A kiss.

Not on the lips. Not demanding, not searing, not the kind of thing that burned with all-consuming heat.

Just a press of warmth against his cheek, light, fleeting. A whisper of contact rather than a declaration.

And Phainon—froze.

Every small movement, every unconscious shift of breath, simply stilled. His entire body locked in place as if something in his mind had abruptly short-circuited, leaving him staring straight ahead as Mydei pulled back, stepping away without fanfare, without even looking to see the full aftermath of what he had just done.

“You really are easy to fluster,” Mydei mused, voice light with amusement as he turned on his heel, leaving Phainon standing there, utterly motionless.

And then he was gone.

-

Phainon stood there for longer than he would ever admit.

It wasn’t until the ambient sounds of the street shifted, people moving around him, that he forced himself to start walking, steps measured and even.

But the scene kept replaying.

Again.

And again.

The warmth lingering against his skin, phantom-like. The casual, almost careless ease of it. The words Mydei had left him with, slipping into his mind like a perfectly aimed dagger.

You really are easy to fluster.

His pace quickened.

It wasn’t often that Phainon found himself off balance. Even less often that he was caught so thoroughly off guard.

And yet.

By the time he turned a corner into a quieter street, his steps had grown sharper, more hurried, something rattling in his chest that he couldn’t quite place. Then, with a sharp inhale, he stopped.

A hand came to rest against the nearest wall, steadying himself, his head tipping forward slightly. His other hand, against his own will, rose to his face, covering his cheek as if that would somehow erase the sensation.

The heat had not faded.

He exhaled sharply, his body slouching just slightly against the wall. The kind of posture he never allowed himself.

…Damn

-

The warmth lingered longer than he expected.

Even as Mydei walked away, leaving Phainon behind, he could still feel the faint press of his lips against his cheek—the heat of it, the stunned silence that had followed. It was almost funny how easily he had turned the tables. Almost.

Yet, just as the satisfaction settled in, something else surfaced. A pause, a pull.

His steps slowed.

He had forgotten something.

The thought came unbidden, striking like a thread snapping loose from a tapestry—just subtle enough to be ignored, but persistent enough to gnaw at him. Something important.

Mydei frowned, rubbing his temple as if that might bring clarity. His mind offered nothing. Just an empty space where certainty should have been.

…Had he really been so tired?

A scoff left him as he straightened, shaking the thought away. It was probably nothing. He hadn't slept well, had barely rested at all. If anything, he was overdue for a real night's sleep.

Whatever it was—whatever he thought he was forgetting—it couldn't have mattered that much.

With that, he exhaled and kept walking, letting the warmth return.

-

Weeks passed, and with each mission, Mydei felt a shift within himself. The streets of Okhema thrummed with renewed energy, the once-dim hope flickering to life as they saved more people from the chaos beyond their borders. He found himself venturing out more frequently, every outing a chance to make a difference, to carve through the darkness with a blade of light.

The elders, too, seemed galvanized. Their focus sharpened as they worked tirelessly to ensure Okhema remained a sanctuary. Mydei observed their efforts—the new protections being enacted, the city's defenses reinforced, and the intricate network built to aid those in need. It was a tangible shift, one that made the air feel lighter, the city alive with possibility.

There was a sense of camaraderie that grew with each successful rescue. Mydei felt the warmth of gratitude in the eyes of those they brought to safety, and it ignited something within him. The fear that had once anchored him began to dissolve, replaced by a burgeoning hope that maybe, just maybe, they could rebuild what had been lost.

As he strolled through the bustling market square one afternoon, the laughter and chatter of the people filled the air, mingling with the aroma of freshly baked bread. Mydei stopped for a moment, taking in the vibrant scene. Children played in the streets, their joy infectious, while vendors called out, peddling their wares with enthusiasm. He couldn't help but smile.

This was what they were fighting for—a future worth believing in.

And for the first time in a long while, Mydei felt the weight of his past lift, replaced by a glimmering sense of hope for the city and its people.

-

The sun hung high in the sky, casting sharp shadows over the training ground. The scent of sun-warmed earth filled the air, mingling with the distant clamor of the city beyond. Mydei stood opposite Phainon, wooden practice sword in hand, adrenaline humming through his veins. The tension between them crackled like the charged air before a storm.

“Ready to lose again?” Mydei challenged, his voice low, laced with bravado. Usually he’d use his gauntlets, but he decided he’d make an exception this time.

Phainon’s expression was bright, the hint of a smile tugging at his lips. “You’d best focus, Mydei. One victory doesn’t make you unbeatable.”

Before Mydei could fire back, Phainon lunged. Their swords clashed, the impact reverberating up Mydei’s arms. Phainon moved with the fluid grace of a predator, each strike precise, controlled. Mydei parried each blow, the thrill of the challenge surging through him. He met Phainon’s intensity with his own, dodging and weaving, matching the older warrior’s movements with an agile finesse honed through countless hours of training.

“Is that all you’ve got?” Mydei taunted, darting in closer, his breath mingling with Phainon’s for the briefest second as he feinted left and struck right.

Phainon deflected the attack, but Mydei didn’t retreat. He pressed forward, his body brushing against Phainon’s for a fleeting moment before he pivoted and landed a firm hit to his opponent’s shoulder.

Phainon stumbled back, surprise flickering in his piercing blue eyes. “Impressive,” he admitted, rolling his shoulder, but his stance remained confident, unwavering. “Let’s see if you can keep that up.”

Mydei grinned, exhilaration thrumming through him. “You’re getting slower, Phainon.” He shifted his weight, stepping in to deliver a swift kick that sent Phainon off balance. “Or maybe I’m just getting better.”

Phainon recovered swiftly, but the corner of his mouth twitched in reluctant admiration. “Just a lucky shot.”

“Lucky? Please.” Mydei spun, bringing his sword down in a decisive arc. At the last moment, Phainon twisted to block, but Mydei’s footwork was too quick. In a final calculated maneuver, he knocked Phainon’s weapon from his grip.

Silence stretched between them, broken only by the sound of their heavy breathing. Mydei stood over Phainon, victorious, his smirk triumphant.

Phainon exhaled a laugh, warm despite his defeat. “You’ve improved.” He wiped a hand over his face, shaking his head. “I’ll give you that.”

Mydei extended a hand, his fingers brushing against Phainon’s as he helped him to his feet. Their eyes met, and for a moment, the world around them faded.

The bond forged through competition and camaraderie thrummed between them, thick as the summer heat.

“Next time,” Phainon murmured, voice low, steady. “I won’t go easy on you.”

Mydei’s grin widened. “Wouldn’t have it any other way.”

-

The night sky stretched infinitely above them, a vast expanse of darkness punctuated by constellations that shimmered like scattered embers. A gentle breeze whispered through the tall grass, carrying the crisp scent of earth and the lingering traces of rain from earlier that evening. Mydei and Phainon sat on a quiet hillside, far from the remnants of the city, where ruin and memory tangled into one indistinguishable blur. Here, in the hush of the night, there were no echoes of the past, no burdens pressing upon their shoulders—only the steady rhythm of the wind and the weight of unspoken thoughts hanging in the air between them.

Mydei lay back, propped on his elbows, his gaze fixed on the endless stretch of stars. He had always looked up at the sky and wondered what it would feel like to drift among them, weightless, untethered, free. The cool breeze tousled his hair, and for a fleeting moment, he felt lighter, as if the heaviness in his chest had momentarily lifted.

Beside him, Phainon sat cross-legged, his presence a quiet contradiction—both a comfort and a reminder of all the things Mydei could not quite put

into words. The faint silver glow of the moon illuminated his face, casting sharp lines over soft expressions, highlighting the intensity in his gaze even as he looked up at the same stars.

“Do you ever wonder what’s out there?” Phainon mused, his voice breaking the stillness, low and contemplative, as if the question had been resting on his tongue for some time.

Mydei’s tone remained dry. “Only when I’m bored.”

Phainon turned to him then, his expression thoughtful. “Boredom is a luxury,” he murmured, the corners of his mouth twitching slightly, almost amused, but not quite.

Mydei chuckled, the sound rougher than he expected, as though laughter had become something foreign to him. “Is that so?” he asked, shifting his weight onto one elbow as he glanced at Phainon. “I’d say boredom is a necessity when you have nothing else to occupy your mind.”

Phainon tilted his head slightly, considering. Then, with quiet certainty, he replied, “You’re starting to sounding like you have everything figured out.”

“Hardly.” Mydei exhaled, shaking his head as he turned back to the sky. The stars seemed distant, but constant—unchanging in a world where nothing else ever stayed the same. “I’m just trying to find some peace, that’s all.”

For a moment, neither of them spoke. The weight of their past—of choices made and fates entwined—hung thick in the air, unspoken yet ever-present. And yet, despite it all, Mydei allowed himself to shift just slightly, just enough that his shoulder brushed against Phainon’s. A small gesture, a quiet concession.

“Peace isn’t something you find,” Phainon said at last, his voice softer now, reflective. “It’s something you create.”

Mydei scoffed, though there was no real bite to it. “Then I suppose I’m not very good at creating things.”

Phainon’s gaze remained steady, unwavering. “Seems to me you’re doing all right.”

The words unsettled something in Mydei, stirred something long buried beneath layers of cynicism and guarded silence. He wasn’t sure what to do with them, wasn’t sure how to accept them without picking them apart. Instead, he let the silence stretch, let himself sink into the quiet between them, let himself remember what it felt like—this closeness, this warmth, this lingering tether between two people who had fought both against and for each other.

“Do you think things will get better?” The question escaped before Mydei could second-guess himself, slipping into the space between them like a whispered uncertainty.

Phainon’s answer came without hesitation. “Better? Or just different?” He glanced at Mydei, his voice steady. “The world will always change. It’s what you choose to do with that change that matters.”

Mydei let out a short, humorless laugh. “Easy for you to say. You thrive on change. You revel in it.”

“And you survive in its wake,” Phainon countered, eyes glinting with something almost like admiration. “You’ve always had that strength.”

Strength. The word felt heavy, felt like something Mydei wasn’t sure he deserved. The world had taken so much from him, carved him into something unrecognizable, and yet, here he was, beneath the stars, leaning into something he didn’t quite understand but couldn’t bring himself to pull away from.

“You know,” he said at last, his voice effortlessly cool despite the steady beat of his pulse, “I’ve never been one for sharing. The spotlight was never mine to begin with—I never wanted it. The shadows have always been more accommodating.”

Phainon smiled, a slow, knowing thing. “Then maybe it’s time you stepped into the light.”

Mydei arched a brow. “I doubt it would suit me.”

“Funny. I don’t recall you ever lingering on the sidelines.” There was a challenge in Phainon’s gaze now, a flicker of something dangerous and familiar and far too tempting.

And just like that, something in Mydei shifted. The way Phainon looked at him, the way he always looked at him—steady, unyielding, seeing past every wall Mydei had carefully constructed—made something inside him stir.

“Maybe I just need a little push,” Mydei murmured.

Phainon leaned in slightly, their shoulders pressing closer. “What kind of push?”

Mydei turned his head, and suddenly, they were close—so close that he could see the flicker of moonlight in Phainon’s eyes, could feel the warmth of his breath against his skin. The air between them crackled, electric, charged with something neither of them had ever dared to name.

And then Mydei moved, just slightly, just enough.

The kiss was hesitant at first, a tentative press of lips that tasted of uncertainty and quiet longing. But then Phainon responded, deepening it, threading his fingers into Mydei’s hair and pulling him in as if anchoring him there, as if grounding them both in this moment, beneath this sky.

When they finally broke apart, foreheads resting together, breath mingling in the cool night air, Phainon smirked. “Better?”

Mydei exhaled a small, breathy laugh, something real, something new. “Maybe,” he admitted, his voice softer than he meant it to be. “I suppose I’ll have to see.”

And above them, the stars shone on—silent witnesses to a moment neither of them would ever forget.

-

The garden was a sanctuary, a quiet refuge from the chaos that so often shadowed their lives. Mydei and Phainon strolled along the winding paths, surrounded by a lush tapestry of colors and scents, each bloom breathing life into the air. A gentle breeze wove through the leaves, carrying the perfume of roses, lavender, and jasmine, blending into something intoxicatingly serene. The world outside the garden walls felt distant, inconsequential. Here, there was only the soft rustle of petals, the whisper of wind, and the measured rhythm of their steps against the stone path.

Mydei's gaze drifted over the myriad of blossoms, lingering on a patch of roses in full bloom. Their deep crimson petals gleamed under the waning sunlight, rich and velvety. He plucked one, its stem still adorned with a few sharp thorns, and turned to Phainon with an unreadable expression. With a casual flick of his wrist, he held it out. "Here, take this."

Phainon arched a brow, his gaze flickering between Mydei and the flower. "You're not serious, are you?"

"Why wouldn't I be?" Mydei asked, his tone laced with indifference. "It's just a rose."

Phainon hesitated, his fingers twitching slightly. "Right. And you're not making fun of me?"

Mydei remained deadpan, though a glimmer of amusement lurked in his eyes. "Not at all."

For a moment, Phainon simply looked at him, as if trying to decipher the deeper meaning beneath Mydei's words. Then, with an exaggerated sigh, Mydei stepped past him, feigning impatience. "Are you going to stand there all day, or are you going to keep up?"

Phainon exhaled, shaking his head, but before he followed, he reached out and plucked the rose from Mydei's grasp. Its weight was unexpected, heavier than he anticipated, as if it carried something unspoken. "You're impossible," he muttered, watching as Mydei merely shrugged and kept walking.

They wandered deeper into the garden, past beds of violets and lilies, trailing fingers over the cool stone of a low wall. The atmosphere was thick with something unspoken, a tension neither of them dared to name. Phainon examined the rose in his hand, twirling it thoughtfully between his fingers. “Do you think flowers actually mean anything?” he mused after a while. “Like the way people say they do?”

Mydei hummed, considering. “Maybe. But meanings change, depending on the person.” He gestured vaguely to the garden around them. “A rose could mean love or it could mean loss. A daisy could mean innocence or it could mean naivety.” He paused, then shot Phainon a sidelong glance. “Depends on how you take it.”

Phainon felt something twist in his chest at the words. He covered it with a question. “And what am I supposed to take from you handing me a rose, then?”

Mydei’s lips curved into an enigmatic smile. “That’s up to you.”

Phainon huffed a quiet laugh, shaking his head before abruptly kneeling to pluck a small flower with deep purple petals. Without hesitation, he held it out to Mydei. “Then here. Take this.”

Mydei arched a brow as he studied the offering. “What is it?”

“Just a flower,” Phainon said, mirroring Mydei’s earlier words. “What does it matter?”

Mydei took the flower, turning it between his fingers with mild curiosity. Then his expression shifted into something amused. “Ah. This one symbolizes deception.” He lifted his gaze to Phainon, voice lilting with teasing delight. “Interesting choice.”

Phainon faltered. “Deception?”

“Mm.” Mydei twirled the flower lazily. “Didn’t take you for the type to hand me something so dubious.”

Phainon ran a hand through his hair, suddenly regretting his choice. “I… I didn’t know that’s what it meant.”

Mydei let out a short chuckle, the sound light but filled with something unreadable. “It’s fine. I’ll keep it.” With a quiet smirk, he tucked the small flower behind his ear. The deep purple petals stood out starkly against his blonde hair, an ironic crown of falsehoods. “After all, it’s just a flower.”

Phainon let out a slow breath, watching him carefully. Mydei had a way of making everything feel like it carried more weight than it should—every word, every glance, every careless gift. He wasn’t sure what to do with that thought.

They reached a stone fountain, the soft trickle of water filling the space between them. Mydei rested a hand against the cool surface, his fingers tracing patterns on the weathered stone. His expression had turned contemplative, a rare softness etching into his features. Phainon studied him for a long moment before finally breaking the silence. “What’s on your mind?”

Mydei’s response was slow, deliberate. “Nothing. Just… enjoying the moment.”

Phainon nodded, sensing the lie but not calling him on it. Instead, he leaned against the fountain beside him, letting the warm breeze ruffle his hair. The silence stretched, neither awkward nor uncomfortable, just a space in which both could exist without pretense.

After a while, Mydei turned to Phainon, his eyes glinting with something unspoken. “Thanks for the flower, even if it’s a deceptive one.”

Phainon met his gaze, and for a fleeting second, something heavy hung between them, unacknowledged but undeniably present. “You’re welcome,” he replied, voice steady. “Just don’t let it go to your head.”

Mydei chuckled, a low, warm sound that made something in Phainon’s chest tighten. “You should be more worried about yourself, Phainon.”

The laughter that followed was rare and unguarded, mingling with the rustling leaves and the distant chirping of crickets. As the sun dipped below the horizon, casting the garden in hues of gold and violet, Mydei absentmindedly touched the flower still resting behind his ear.

A silent reminder. A lingering question.

In the midst of the blooms, they stood side by side, each lost in thought yet bound together by something unspoken, something neither of them was quite ready to name.

Chapter End Notes

> Next chapter is being posted either in a few hours if I pull an all nighter or by morning if I spend the whole time just writing, THIS FUCKER WILL BE DONE 😭😭😭
>
> Omg this is definitely my least favorite chapter because of how I literally went through the five stages of grief writing this only for it to be the most tamest and fluffies/casual-ist thing it can be, and the fact I DEFINITELY repeated some words cause I was rushing. tweaking out

Fading Reverence

Chapter Notes

Pretend I posted this before 3.1 uhhhhh

PS: Warning for dub/non-con (I don’t get the difference sorry, so u decide which it is😭)

Quick question though, would you prefer more angsty works or comedy/fluff like I’ve been doing recently?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The night stretched quiet around them, the air tinged with the scent of damp earth and the distant promise of rain. The path they followed was uneven, broken in places by the stubborn roots of old trees, but neither of them seemed to mind. The mission had gone well—better than most. No missteps. No unexpected losses. No bitter weight pressing against their ribs, reminding them of what they could have done differently.

For once, Mydei felt something close to lightness. Not quite peace, not entirely at ease, but as if the weight he carried had lessened, even if only for a moment. His breath came easier. The tension in his shoulders, so familiar it often felt like a part of him, had loosened just enough to be noticeable. He wasn’t sure how long it would last, but he didn’t question it. He simply let himself exist in the moment.

Ahead of him, Phainon walked with an easy, unhurried stride, hands tucked behind his head. His posture was loose, the kind of relaxed that suggested he was either deep in thought or thinking about nothing at all. Eventually, he glanced back.

“You’re quiet,” he noted.

“You say that as if it’s unusual.”

Phainon huffed a soft laugh. “Not unusual. Just different.”

Mydei didn’t answer, but he also didn’t refute the statement. Maybe it was different. Maybe, just for tonight, he didn’t feel the need to fill the silence with sharp edges and distance.

They continued on, the sound of their footsteps blending with the rustling of leaves in the breeze. The city loomed in the distance, its glow muted but constant, a reminder of where they had come from and where they would return.

The path dipped slightly, rough with cracks and hidden hazards. Phainon, ever careless, caught his foot on an exposed root. There was a startled curse, a sharp lurch forward—

Mydei moved before thinking. His hand shot out, gripping Phainon’s wrist in a firm, instinctive hold. He pulled him back upright with practiced ease, steady as ever.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

Phainon blinked, looking down at Mydei’s hand still wrapped around his wrist. Then up at him, eyes glinting with something unreadable. “Oh? Didn’t take you for the chivalrous type.”

Mydei released him immediately, expression impassive. “I’d rather not have to explain why you cracked your skull open on a walk.”

Phainon grinned, rubbing the back of his head. “Admit it. You’d miss me.”

Mydei was already walking again. “I’d miss the quiet more.”

Phainon let out a low, exaggerated sigh, falling into step beside him once more. “Truly, your heart knows no bounds.”

The banter came easy. Familiar. It was strange, in its own way—how much they had endured together, how often they had fought both side by side and against each other, yet somehow, they had settled into something steady. Not unbreakable, but resilient.

They talked about small things after that. The mission. The city. A few dry remarks from Mydei about Phainon's questionable self-preservation instincts. It felt… normal, almost. The kind of normal that didn't need to be picked apart.

Then Phainon, careless as ever, said something he didn't think twice about.

"Besides, you're always dreaming about it anyway."

Mydei stopped walking.

The shift was immediate. Subtle, but absolute.

The lightness he had felt only moments ago vanished, replaced by something sharp, unyielding. The air turned cold, or maybe it was just the way silence suddenly stretched between them, no longer easy or comfortable but heavy, weighted with unspoken things.

Phainon, who had already taken another step forward, noticed too late. He turned back, confusion flickering across his face—then realization.

Mydei's expression hadn't changed much. No visible anger. No immediate outburst. But there was a stillness to him now, deliberate and unmoving. The kind of stillness that came before something dangerous.

His voice, when it came, was quiet. Unshaken.

"How do you know that?"

Phainon stilled.

The space between them, once filled with conversation and warmth, stretched wide and unfamiliar.

He didn't answer right away.

Didn't joke. Didn't brush it off with a grin or some deflective remark.

And that, more than anything, set Mydei further on edge.

His gaze was steady, unreadable, but there was something underneath it now. Something simmering.

Phainon exhaled, slow.

He could lie.

Or he could tell the truth.

Either way, the night was no longer quiet.

Phainon didn’t move. Didn’t shift his weight, didn’t look away, didn’t even fidget the way he usually did when faced with something uncomfortable. He simply stood there, watching Mydei with an unreadable expression.

Then, slow as anything, he tilted his head. “What are you talking about?”

The words were easy. Too easy.

Mydei’s fingers curled into a loose fist at his side. “You know exactly what I’m talking about.”

Phainon blinked, brows furrowing just slightly, like someone trying to make sense of a misplaced accusation. “You lost me.”

Something cold settled in Mydei’s chest.

It wasn’t the first time he had seen Phainon lie. It wasn’t even the best lie Phainon had ever told. But it was the way he said it—the way he delivered the words with such casual certainty, as if the problem wasn’t what he had let slip, but rather that Mydei had misunderstood him.

“You mentioned my dream,” Mydei said, voice measured. “How do you know about it?”

Phainon huffed, shaking his head with a bemused smile. “A dream? Mydei, I don’t know what you—”

“Don’t.”

The amusement vanished.

It wasn’t often that Mydei’s tone hardened like that, not with him. Phainon might have laughed if it were anyone else. Might have called him dramatic, teased him for taking things so seriously. But Mydei wasn’t just serious. He was looking at him like he was waiting for something—for a misstep, an admission, an opening.

Phainon let out a soft breath, hands slipping into his pockets. “Alright,” he said. “Say I did mention a dream. What’s the big deal?”

Mydei didn’t answer.

“People talk in their sleep all the time,” Phainon continued. “Maybe I heard something. Maybe you said something and forgot.”

It was a trap of a statement—carefully constructed, delicately placed. A path for Mydei to follow, a way to explain it to himself without forcing Phainon to admit anything. If he latched onto it, if he let himself believe it, then the weight of suspicion would lessen. The uncertainty would linger, sure, but uncertainty was manageable.

But Mydei didn’t take the bait.

“That’s not how I dream.”

Phainon made a thoughtful noise. “You sure?”

Mydei’s jaw tightened. “Yes.”

Phainon held his gaze for a long moment, then sighed, shaking his head like this was some kind of mild inconvenience. “Gods, Mydei, you’re acting like I’ve committed some kind of crime.”

“You’re avoiding the question.”

Phainon’s lips twitched. “Maybe I just don’t like being interrogated over something that doesn’t matter.”

“It matters.”

A pause. A shift.

For the first time since this conversation began, something flickered across Phainon’s face. Something fleeting but sharp, like the glint of a blade catching the light before vanishing back into shadow.

Then it was gone, replaced with that same easy carelessness. “Fine. You’re convinced I know something? Then tell me—what exactly do you think I know?”

And there it was. The final push.

Because if Mydei answered, if he gave Phainon even the smallest thread of speculation, then Phainon could untangle it. Could twist it just enough to make Mydei question himself.

Because doubt, after all, was easier to live with than certainty.

And Phainon was very, very good at making people doubt.

The silence between them thickened, heavy and charged, stretching like an unseen tether Mydei refused to sever. He felt the weight of Phainon’s gaze—steady, unwavering, patient in a way that made his skin prickle. It was the same look Phainon always wore when he was shifting the ground beneath Mydei’s feet, making him question whether he had been standing on solid earth to begin with.

Phainon exhaled softly, a sound almost too light for the tension between them. His expression softened, that usual glimmer in his eyes flickering like a candle in a draft. “You really think I’d just dig around in your mind like that?” he asked, voice warm, almost wounded. “Come on, Mydei. You know me better than that.”

Mydei clenched his jaw. “Then why did you bring it up?” His voice was steadier than he felt. “What do you know about my dreams?”

Phainon tilted his head slightly, as if considering the question with some great care, and then—just like that—he stepped closer. Not enough to be aggressive, not enough to be obvious, but enough that Mydei could feel the faint heat radiating from him, the scent of smoke and something unplaceable curling in the crisp night air.

“You,” Phainon spoke resolutely, like the answer should have been obvious. “You’re the one with the vivid imagination, Mydei. You always have been.” His voice turned almost fond, a note of indulgence threading through it. “I thought you’d appreciate a little mysticism, that’s all. We all have dreams. We all talk about them sometimes.” He gave a half-shrug. “It’s not a big deal.”

A slow, creeping pressure settled over Mydei’s chest.

Not a big deal.

The words pressed against the inside of his skull, chafing, irritating. That was exactly the trick, wasn’t it? Make him feel like the problem. Make him question why he was even pushing this.

“I don’t talk about them,” Mydei said, voice edged.

Phainon sighed, shaking his head like Mydei was being difficult. “Not out loud, maybe. But I know you, Mydei.” His voice softened further, becoming something dangerously gentle, something that could slip into the cracks of Mydei’s resolve if he let it. “And if something’s bothering you that much, I want to help.”

Mydei’s fists curled at his sides. “I never asked you to help.”

“You never have to.”

The words were so effortlessly smooth, so laced with quiet sincerity, that for half a second, Mydei almost believed them.

But the doubt was still there, gnawing at the edges of his mind.

Phainon must have sensed it, because he suddenly leaned in—close enough that Mydei felt the whisper of his breath against his skin, close enough that it would have looked, to any outsider, like something intimate instead of a battlefield of words.

“If I knew something, I’d tell you,” Phainon said, so quiet it barely carried between them. “I would never hide anything from you.”

Mydei’s breath caught.

“We’re in this together, right?” Phainon continued, voice like velvet, warm and steady. “You’re safe with me.” He reached out, brushing his fingers over the edge of Mydei’s sleeve—not quite touching him fully, but enough for Mydei to feel the weight of the gesture. “So why do you still seem so anxious?”

Mydei forced himself to breathe. He tried to keep the logic in his head, tried to cling to it like an anchor, but Phainon’s words wrapped around him like a net, made to comfort, made to bind.

“I just…” He exhaled, trying to clear the haze in his thoughts. “It’s unsettling. You shouldn’t know about my dreams.”

Phainon hummed, tilting his head as if he were puzzled by the very notion. “Why not?” he asked. “They’re a part of you, aren’t they? And I care about you, Mydei.” His voice dipped lower, nearly a whisper. “Maybe you’re just afraid of what you dream about.”

Mydei stiffened.

Phainon smiled, soft and knowing. “Maybe you’re afraid to share it with me.”

“I’m not—”

“And that’s okay,” Phainon interrupted smoothly. “We can explore it together.” His fingers ghosted against Mydei’s wrist, the touch light enough to make Mydei’s pulse jump. “You don’t have to shut me out.”

Mydei swallowed, his throat dry. “You’re making this sound like I’m the one at fault here.”

“Not at fault,” Phainon corrected, shaking his head. “Just… guarded. You always have been.” His thumb brushed lightly over Mydei’s knuckles, his voice lowering to something almost reverent. “But I can’t help you if you don’t let me. Let me in, Mydei.” His gaze softened, full of something that almost looked like devotion. “You’re not alone.”

Mydei’s mind swayed, uncertainty lacing through him like poison in the bloodstream.

Trust isn’t a light switch, Phainon had said once. *It’s a dance.*

Mydei’s heart was still hammering against his ribs, but there was something almost lulling about Phainon’s voice, about the warmth that pressed against the cold places inside him. It felt… safe.

And yet, wasn’t that the most dangerous part?

His breath hitched. He took a step back, forcing space between them. “No,” he said, shaking his head as he tried to clear his thoughts. “You’re not getting away with this.” He forced himself to meet Phainon’s gaze, steady despite the storm inside him. “How do you know about my dreams?”

Phainon’s expression faltered, just for a fraction of a second.

And in that heartbeat of silence, the warmth between them cooled.

Then, just as quickly, the smile returned—softer this time, almost regretful. “You’re still so fixated on this,” he stated. “What do you think I’m hiding?”

Mydei exhaled sharply. “I don’t know,” he admitted. “But you’re not telling me the truth.”

Phainon studied him, searching his face, and for a moment, something unreadable flickered in his expression. Then he sighed, running a hand through his hair. “I just—” He hesitated, shaking his head. “I don’t want you to think I’d ever hurt you.”

“You’re dodging the question.”

“No, I’m trying to make you see reason.” Phainon’s voice was softer now, gentler. “I don’t want to fight with you, Mydei.” He took a step forward again, his presence pressing into Mydei’s space like a tide returning to shore. “I want to give you something.”

Mydei blinked, thrown by the shift. “What?”

Phainon smiled, slipping a hand into his coat. “A gift.” His eyes met Mydei’s, dark and steady. “Something to remind you that I’m always looking out for you.”

The words settled deep in Mydei’s chest, like a stone thrown into still water.

Phainon held out his hand.

“Here,” he reached out. “Take it.”

And despite everything, despite the doubt clawing at his thoughts, Mydei found himself hesitating.

Because even now, after all of this—part of him still wanted to believe.

Mydei hesitated, his eyes flickering between Phainon’s outstretched hand and the unreadable expression on his face.

“A gift,” Mydei repeated slowly.

Phainon only nodded, gaze patient, unwavering.

There was nothing in his hand. No trinket, no charm, no object that could explain the weight of his words. Just the steady, open invitation of his palm—waiting.

Mydei exhaled sharply. “You can’t be serious.”

Phainon’s lips curved into a knowing smile. “Oh, but I am.”

And somehow, that was worse.

Mydei's fingers twitched at his side. This was stupid. This was a trick. This was—

Warmth.

Before he fully realized what he was doing, Mydei reached out and clasped Phainon's hand.

The touch was grounding, solid, and yet it sent an immediate shiver through him. Not from cold, but from something deeper, something that curled around his ribs like unseen vines. Phainon's fingers flexed slightly, a satisfied hum slipping from him as if this—this—was what he had been waiting for all along.

Mydei's throat tightened.

The weight of it, the significance—

A sudden, loud crack split through the air.

Mydei flinched violently, ripping his hand away as his head snapped toward the source of the noise. His heart pounded against his ribs, the rush of instinct overtaking the haze Phainon had been weaving around him.

"What was that?" he demanded, his voice sharp.

Phainon let out a slow, measured sigh, rolling his shoulders like he had just been rudely interrupted from a pleasant conversation. "Tsk." He glanced off to the side, barely concerned. "That was too early."

Mydei's stomach twisted. "Too early for what?"

Phainon turned back to him, his expression unreadable, but there was a flicker of something behind his eyes—something calculating, something knowing.

“Oh, don’t worry about it,” he said lightly, waving a hand. “Just a bit of bad timing, that’s all.”

Mydei’s breath felt too shallow. His pulse still raced from the noise, but now something else coiled beneath his skin—a different kind of tension, a gnawing uncertainty that had Phainon’s name written all over it.

His hands clenched at his sides. “Phainon,” he said carefully, “what was too early?”

Phainon’s smile was slow, almost lazy.

He didn’t answer.

The silence that followed was different this time. Not heavy with tension, not charged with unspoken challenges—just quiet.

Phainon’s usual ease, his ever-present glibness, was absent. He didn’t answer. Didn’t joke. Didn’t deflect.

Mydei narrowed his eyes. “Phainon.”

Still nothing.

Phainon stood there, gaze idly drifting past Mydei, past the trees, past whatever had made the noise. Like he hadn’t heard him. Or maybe like he had and just wasn’t interested in playing along anymore.

That set Mydei’s nerves on edge more than any clever evasion ever could.

He took a step closer, voice lowering. “You said *too early*—too early for *what*?”

Phainon hummed softly. Not in amusement. Not in interest. Just… a sound. Thoughtful.

“You’re doing that thing again,” Mydei pressed, eyes flickering over him, searching for the crack in his mask. “Where you pretend I didn’t say something.”

Phainon finally turned his gaze back to him, unreadable. “Am I?”

Mydei clenched his jaw. “Yes.”

Silence.

For the first time in a long time, it felt like Phainon wasn’t guiding the conversation, wasn’t leading him into some tangled web of half-truths and distractions. No, this time, he was just *waiting*.

For what, Mydei couldn’t tell.

And that? That was somehow worse.

Phainon tilted his head slightly, considering Mydei with a gaze that was neither dismissive nor entirely present.

Then—so casually it almost felt accidental—he spoke.

“You always get like this when Okhema is involved.”

The words landed like a physical blow.

Mydei went still.

Something inside him—something instinctive, something primal—lurched at the statement, like a trap had just been sprung beneath his feet. His breath caught, the rhythm of his heartbeat stuttering violently before slamming into overdrive.

“What did you just say?” His voice barely carried, hoarse with the weight of his own dread.

Phainon’s expression didn’t shift.

For a moment, Mydei wondered if he had imagined it—if the words hadn’t been spoken at all, if he was only hearing the things his fear wanted him to.

But no.

Phainon was watching him.

Watching him too closely.

Mydei felt the pit open beneath him, an abyss of terrible understanding that he refused to acknowledge. He shook his head, trying to steady himself.

“Phainon,” he said, sharper this time. “What the hell does that mean?”

Phainon didn’t answer.

The silence rang louder than any explosion, louder than the noise that had broken through the night, louder than Mydei’s own pulse roaring in his ears.

And then—

A flicker.

Not on Phainon’s face, but in his posture. Something infinitesimal. A shift. A second’s hesitation that Mydei almost missed.

Almost.

Something was wrong.

Something was so wrong.

And Mydei knew—deep in the marrow of his bones, in the instincts that screamed at him to move, to run, to go—that he wasn’t ready for the answer.

But he had to know.

He turned.

And then he was *running*.

The ground blurred beneath him, the wind biting against his skin as his feet pounded forward, carrying him faster than thought, faster than reason. His

body moved on instinct, his mind barely keeping up as the distance between him and the city closed at a terrifying pace.

Please no. Please no. Please no.

The sky over Okhema wasn't right.

Smoke curled like blackened fingers into the night, staining the stars. An eerie glow pulsed beyond the city walls, flickering and violent.

Mydei pushed forward, his breath ragged, his muscles burning.

And then—

He reached the gates.

His steps faltered.

His stomach lurched.

The sacred city—

The holy, untouchable city—

Had been *razed to the ground.*

The streets were awash in blood, slick and dark beneath the dim light. Buildings, once pristine and unmarred, had collapsed into ruin, their skeletal remains jutting against the sky like broken ribs. The scent of burning flesh choked the air, thick and cloying.

Bodies.

So many bodies.

They were scattered haphazardly—some slumped against crumbling walls, some collapsed mid-step, their expressions frozen in terror and agony. The devastation was total.

Something inside Mydei cracked.

His legs buckled, and he barely caught himself before he hit the ground. His lungs seized, his vision tunneling. The weight of the destruction pressed against him, suffocating, consuming.

His hands—he didn't remember lifting them—were shaking. Trembling violently, his fingers curling into claws, trying to grasp something—*anything*—that would make this not real.

A sound.

A strangled, ragged breath.

It took Mydei too long to realize it had come from him.

He was drowning.

His chest seized, his thoughts spiraling, everything folding inward as panic consumed him whole. His vision blurred at the edges, his pulse a deafening roar. His body *would not move.*

And then—

A shadow at the edge of his vision.

A figure.

Standing amidst the wreckage.

Unmoving. Unbothered.

Watching.

Mydei didn't have to turn to know who it was.

He didn't want to.

But he did.

Phainon stood just beyond the carnage, his posture languid, his expression unreadable.

Not alarmed. Not surprised.

Just looking at him.

Like he had been waiting for this.

Like he had known exactly what Mydei would find.

Terror sank its teeth deep into Mydei’s chest.

His breath hitched, sharp and shallow, his vision tilting at the edges. The panic—before, it had been suffocating, unbearable.

But now?

Now it was nothing compared to the weight of understanding.

Phainon knew.

Phainon had always known.

And still—

Still, he smiled.

Soft.

Gentle.

Like he pitied him.

Like this had always been inevitable.

And Mydei *broke*.

The world had shattered for him.

One moment, Mydei had been standing before Phainon, questioning him, pushing at the edges of his silence, and the next—

This.

Okhema was gone.

How did it come to this?

The sacred city had been gutted from the inside out, its once-pristine streets now a grotesque tableau of ruin and death. Mydei barely processed the sequence of his own actions—one second, he had been running, breath tearing through his throat, and now he stood in the middle of something unspeakable.

Blood coated the stones in thick, congealing pools, the scent of iron so strong it clung to the back of his throat. Some bodies were barely recognizable—ripped apart, limbs torn from sockets, flesh twisted into something unholy. Others remained whole but disturbingly still, their eyes fixed open in frozen horror, the last moments of their lives preserved in expressions that would never change.

A child lay just a few feet from him, small hands still clutching the fabric of a tattered doll, its face smeared in red. Mydei couldn't look away from the way her body curled inward, like she had tried to make herself smaller, as if that could have saved her.

His stomach twisted violently. His knees buckled.

How did this happen?

One moment—he had been standing there, arguing. Just talking. And then —

He couldn't breathe. His mind reeled, trying to bridge the impossible gap between then and now. Between the quiet conversation and the smell of burning flesh. Between Phainon’s infuriating half-truths and the pieces of people scattered across the ground.

His breath came in short, sharp bursts. His vision swam. His hands were shaking so violently that he could barely feel them, numb and distant. He knew—he knew—he was losing control, slipping under the weight of it, drowning in it, and yet he couldn't stop.

He barely registered the soft sigh behind him.

“Tsk.”

The sound was mild, almost indulgent, as if this were nothing more than an inconvenience. “Much too early…” he repeated.

Mydei flinched. He turned, his body stiff with unspent terror, and found Phainon standing there—just standing, unbothered, untouched by the horror unfolding before them.

Phainon’s gaze swept over the carnage, unreadable. Then, with the same mild irritation, he muttered, “This is why I didn’t want this to happen so soon.”

The words didn’t make sense. None of this made sense. Mydei wanted to demand answers, wanted to grab him by the collar and *shake* him, *force* him to explain, but he couldn’t make his body move. Could barely make his lungs work.

Phainon exhaled again, more thoughtful this time, then turned his attention back to Mydei.

His lips curled into something resembling a smile. “Do you want to walk somewhere else?” he asked, voice soft, as if suggesting they take a stroll through a garden and not a slaughterhouse.

Something inside Mydei *snapped*.

His stomach twisted again, a violent churn of nausea and disbelief. He could barely see through the static crawling at the edges of his vision. The bodies, the smell, the ruin—his chest hurt, his ribs locking up, trapping the air in his lungs until the edges of his world blurred.

This wasn’t real.

This couldn’t be real.

Phainon stepped closer, his presence unnervingly steady against Mydei’s unraveling world. His eyes—sharp and knowing—softened slightly.

“I have a gift for you,” he spoke, voice dipped in something intimate, something meant to soothe. “Something rare. Something precious.”

Mydei barely processed the words. His ears were ringing.

Phainon tilted his head, patient, undeterred. “I’m offering you the coreflame of Mnestia.” His voice was slow, deliberate, as if he were explaining something sacred. “Algaea’s own power. The essence of romance itself.”

It took Mydei a second to register what he was saying.

Then another to process it.

The coreflame of Mnestia.

His mind latched onto the words, trying to make sense of them, trying to slot them into the same reality where Okhema was in ruins and Phainon was standing before him with a lovesick expression.

Romance.

Here. Now. With blood still soaking his boots.

Mydei’s stomach turned again, and suddenly, violently, he shoved Phainon back.

Phainon barely moved. He didn’t stumble. Didn’t even react beyond the slight shift in weight.

But something in his expression cooled.

Not anger. Not disappointment.

Just a quiet, knowing patience, as if this was always how it was going to go.

As if Mydei was being difficult, but not unpredictably so.

Phainon smiled again—smaller now, less indulgent.

And he waited.

Mydei's breath shuddered as he backed away, his legs weak beneath him. The taste of bile clung to the back of his throat, the sheer, overwhelming wrongness of it all pressing down on his chest like a vice.

The blood, the bodies, the **absolute desecration** of Okhema—it was everywhere. He couldn't escape it, couldn't blink without seeing the grotesque display carved into the ruins of what had once been holy ground.

But Phainon…

Phainon was **untouched**.

He stepped toward him with the same casual ease as if this were nothing more than a stroll through the gardens, his expression still gentle, still unbearably soft, like he wasn't surrounded by the horror he had caused.

"Stop being difficult," Phainon scolded, his voice almost chiding, but still laced with that infuriating, almost affectionate patience. "You're trembling."

Mydei flinched as Phainon reached out, fingertips brushing against his cheek, light as a whisper. His skin crawled at the touch, and he jerked back violently, his heart hammering like a war drum.

Why was he acting like this? Why was he speaking so gently when Mydei could hardly breathe past the grief suffocating him?

His throat clenched. His voice had abandoned him.

But he had to say it. He had to force himself to say it.

Swallowing against the sheer terror constricting his chest, Mydei managed a breathless whisper:

“You did it.”

A statement, not a question. The truth laid bare between them.

Phainon didn’t deny it.

Instead, he exhaled, tilting his head, regarding Mydei with something almost wistful. “I really didn’t want this to happen so soon,” he admitted, sighing as if this was an inconvenience rather than a massacre. “I told you. Too hasty.”

A sick, horrible *crack* nearly split Mydei’s ribs.

His hands clenched into fists, nails digging into his palms. His body screamed at him to run, but the weight of what he was seeing, of what Phainon had done, pinned him in place.

His breath hitched, broken, as his next question rasped from his throat.

“Why?”

His voice wavered, raw with disbelief. His chest ached. “Why didn’t you —” His lips trembled. “Why didn’t you get rid of me too?”

Phainon’s gaze softened, and that was somehow the worst part.

“Oh, Mydei.” He reached for him again, but this time, Mydei *recoiled* so fast he nearly tripped over his own feet.

Phainon let his hand drop, unbothered. Instead, he smiled, slow and knowing.

“I have something else for you,” he said smoothly, shifting the conversation as if Mydei hadn’t just accused him of slaughter.

And then, in his palm—

A circular flame.

Faint, flickering, but undeniably alive.

The sight of it sent a bolt of terror straight down Mydei's spine.

Even before Phainon spoke, he knew what it was.

A Titan's coreflame.

Not just any.

Nikador's.

Titan of Fury and Strife.

A relic of a god Mydei's people had once worshipped before he fell to madness.

Mydei's entire body locked.

The coreflame flickered in Phainon's palm, casting faint, eerie light against the carnage surrounding them. Mydei couldn't take his eyes off it. The heat of it gnawed at the air, ancient and waiting.

Phainon didn't move, didn't speak. He only watched him, patient. Expectant.

Mydei's breath hitched.

"No."

His voice was barely above a whisper, but it was firm. It had to be.

He *would not* take that coreflame.

Phainon's expression didn't change, but something in the air did.

It tightened.

It pressed down on Mydei’s ribs, his lungs, as if the world itself had leaned in closer to listen.

And then—

A sigh.

Long, weary, slow.

Phainon ran a hand through his hair, his fingers dragging slightly. “See, this,” he mumbled to himself, “is exactly why I wanted to do this the easy way.”

Mydei’s stomach twisted.

Before he could move, before he could even breathe—

Phainon stepped forward.

Faster than Mydei could react.

And the moment Phainon reached him, *the world shattered.*

Pain exploded through his body.

A force slammed into his chest, searing and *unrelenting*, sending him crashing into the blood-soaked ground.

His head spun. His vision blurred. His breath caught in his throat, and—oh.

This was bad.

This was—this was worse than anything he’d ever felt.

Phainon knelt beside him, slow and deliberate, like he had all the time in the world. His fingers grazed Mydei’s cheek, tilting his face upward with unbearable gentleness.

“Mydei,” he whispered, voice soft, but dangerously fraying at the edges. “You know I don’t like being cruel.”

A fresh wave of pain lanced through him as Phainon pressed a hand against his ribs. A hum of energy coursed from his fingertips, scalding beneath Mydei’s skin.

“But you,” Phainon continued, his voice still achingly tender, “are making this so very difficult.”

Mydei wheezed, his body screaming as something inside him cracked.

It didn’t matter.

He was immortal.

No matter how much Phainon broke him—he’d come back.

Phainon’s lips curved into something too close to fondness.

“So, then,” he whispered.

His fingers curled—

And Mydei’s world erupted into agony.

Mydei barely registered his own scream. His vision shattered at the edges, black seeping into the corners of his mind like ink, crawling, spreading. His hands clawed against the blood-slicked ground, nails scraping against the jagged stone beneath him, desperate to anchor himself against the sensation ripping him apart.

And still—Phainon’s touch remained light.

A hand at his cheek, fingers pressed just barely against his skin. A tenderness that made the horror worse.

Phainon was watching him.

Not with anger. Not even with amusement.

Just patience.

Like he was waiting for Mydei to realize something.

The pain ebbed—just enough for Mydei to hear again, to think. To feel the ground beneath him, wet with blood, the way his own breath came in ragged, uneven gasps. His body was still wracked with tremors, his limbs barely obeying him as he forced himself to look past Phainon's face—to the ruin around them.

To the bodies.

He had thought the city destroyed before. Had thought he had seen the worst of it.

He had been wrong.

Because now, in this moment, with his mind slowed and his body failing, he could see the things he hadn't processed before. The details his brain had shielded him from.

The corpses weren't just bodies.

They were defiled.

Some had been burned—charred beyond recognition, their flesh peeling away in thick, blackened sheets. Some had been torn apart, limbs scattered like discarded dolls, as if something had ripped through them with monstrous force.

A woman lay to his right, or what remained of her. Her torso was still intact, her ribs jutting through the skin like pale, splintered wood, but her head—

Gods.

Her head was gone. Torn clean from her shoulders, the ragged wound still oozing. Her hands were curled inward, fingers stiff, frozen in the last desperate grasp of someone who had known—had known—that death was coming.

Beyond her, more.

A priest, still in his robes, his staff snapped in two, his body slumped against a collapsed pillar, his eyes wide—too wide. The whites were stark against the gore staining his face, his mouth parted in something soundless, as if the horror of his own death had stolen his last breath.

And then there were the ones who weren't intact at all.

The ones reduced to remnants—shreds of flesh, streaks of viscera smeared across the broken streets, things that had once been people but now were just… pieces.

Something shifted beneath him.

No—someone.

Mydei choked, horror snapping through him as he realized—he wasn't just lying on the blood-soaked ground.

He was lying on bodies.

The realization sent another violent tremor through him. His hands slipped against the gore beneath him, his entire body recoiling, nausea clawing up his throat. He scrambled back, slipping, breath coming too fast, too shallow, his vision narrowing.

This wasn't just a slaughter.

It was a message.

A spectacle. A display.

The devastation wasn't just about killing—it was meant to be seen.

He turned his head back to Phainon, and that was when he saw it.

The thing that made his stomach drop.

The thing that solidified the cold, unspeakable truth already curling in his chest.

Phainon’s footsteps.

Wherever he had stepped—wherever he moved—the ground beneath him was untouched.

No blood stained his boots. No dirt clung to his robes.

He had walked through all of this and remained unscathed.

As if the massacre itself refused to touch him.

Or worse—as if he had orchestrated it, and it knew him as its master.

Phainon watched him piece it together.

And then—he smiled.

Not a grin, not a smirk—a real smile.

Soft. Patient. Loving.

Like Mydei had just done something that pleased him. Like this moment was something cherished, something worth remembering.

“You poor thing,” Phainon had said with a gentle voice. “You still don’t understand, do you?”

Mydei’s breath hitched.

He could still feel the burn in his chest, the lingering echoes of pain where Phainon had touched him. His body was weak, barely holding itself

together, but his mind—his mind was reeling, clawing for anything, any answer that might make sense.

And Phainon was still so calm.

That was what terrified him most.

Not the massacre. Not the ruin. Not even the blood pooling at his feet.

But Phainon, standing there, untouched, smiling as if none of it mattered.

As if Mydei's fear was expected.

As if it was part of the plan.

Phainon sighed then, kneeling beside him again, reaching out once more.

Mydei flinched—hard—but he was too weak to pull away.

Phainon's fingers brushed against his jaw, tilting his face up slightly, and then—his lips ghosted over his forehead.

A kiss.

Light. Unbearably tender.

Mydei's stomach dropped.

He couldn't breathe. He couldn't move.

His entire body locked up, stiff and trembling beneath Phainon's touch, horror flooding every nerve in his body, because—

Because it was real.

Phainon had done this.

And he was treating Mydei like he was precious.

As if Mydei wasn’t a witness to his crimes.

As if he was the only thing in this entire massacre worth keeping.

Phainon leaned back slightly, his gaze unreadable, but there was something there—something satisfied.

“There, that’s better.”

His fingers lingered against Mydei’s skin, his grip featherlight but unshakable.

Then, softer—almost reverent—

“Nothing in this ruined city is as breathtaking as you are right now.”

Mydei’s blood ran cold.

Darkness pressed at the edges of Mydei’s vision, creeping in like ink bleeding through parchment. His body wouldn’t move. His limbs were leaden, his breath shallow and uneven. Every nerve in his body burned, screaming protest, but he could barely muster the strength to flinch.

Phainon’s arms curled around him, cradling him with unnerving tenderness. His warmth was suffocating, too close, too familiar. Mydei wanted to recoil, to shove him away, to tear himself free, but his strength was draining too fast. His fingers barely twitched against Phainon’s chest, a pathetic, useless attempt at resistance.

“Shh,” Phainon whispered, voice almost reverent. His hand smoothed over Mydei’s hair, slow and deliberate, as if soothing a lover rather than holding him captive in his own failing body. “Don’t fight it. You’ll feel better soon.”

A fresh wave of nausea rolled through him. The iron scent of blood clung thick in the air, clogging his lungs, coating his tongue. The world blurred, twisting in ways it shouldn’t. He couldn’t tell if he was falling or if Phainon was pulling him deeper into his embrace.

His heart pounded, frantic, desperate. No, no, no—

“See?” Phainon’s lips brushed against Mydei’s temple in a mockery of comfort. “It’s easier this way.”

Mydei’s breath hitched. His chest constricted. His own body was betraying him, slipping further into the abyss with every sluggish beat of his heart.

A soft hum vibrated against his skin. Phainon was still speaking, but the words stretched and distorted, drowned beneath the rush of his own pulse.

His vision tunneled.

The ruined city, the bodies, the blood—they were fading into shadow, lost to the encroaching dark.

Phainon’s fingers traced along his jaw, tilting his head just enough for their eyes to meet one last time before the void swallowed him whole.

And the last thing Mydei saw—

Was Phainon’s eyes.

-

The first thing he noticed was warmth.

A terrible, all-encompassing warmth, seeping into his skin, his bones, his breath. It curled around him, insidious in its gentleness, too steady, too undisturbed. The scent of linen, faint traces of candle smoke, something almost sweet. It should have been suffocating. It should have burned.

But it didn’t.

His mind waded through sluggish recollections—blood in his throat, the weight of unseen hands, a voice at his ear promising something he could not name. The crash of bodies falling, of a world reshaped in crimson, and then—

Nothing.

His breath shuddered. His fingers twitched, his body slow to respond, as if the violence had been stripped from him along with everything else. No pain, no wounds, no crushing weight of exhaustion where there should have been.

His eyes snapped open.

The room was quiet. Too quiet.

Sunlight spilled through sheer curtains, casting gold along soft sheets, over furniture untouched by ruin. A bed beneath him—too comfortable, too real. He gritted his teeth, shifting against it, half-expecting resistance, the ache of bruises that did not come.

The nausea was immediate.

His breath locked, his limbs stiffening as if they could anchor him in place. He had been dying. He had felt it, the unraveling of himself, the pull toward something he should not have escaped. But this—this was not death. This was—

“You’re awake.”

He did not flinch.

His body had already gone still, rigid beneath an invisible weight. Not one he could see, but one he could *feel*—something lingering at the edges of his nerves, something colder than the warmth pressing against his skin.

Phainon was standing at the far end of the room, watching him.

No blood. No flames. Just *him*, composed as ever, as if the last thing Mydei remembered had never happened at all.

Mydei forced himself upright. The room tipped dangerously, nausea curling at the edges of his ribs, but he ground his teeth, bracing himself. A deep breath, slow, controlled. His pulse was betraying him, but his hands—his hands would not.

He exhaled sharply, his voice coming steady, sharpened like a blade.

“You tell me what the hell that was.”

Phainon’s expression barely flickered.

“You’ll have to be more specific.”

Mydei’s stomach twisted. He did not look away.

“The Coreflame,” he said, carefully, evenly, though his fingers clenched against the sheets. “The slaughter. *Why?”*

For a moment, Phainon simply looked at him.

Then, with an exhale, he stepped forward.

Not slow, not hesitant—just assured, like this conversation was already decided.

“You really don’t understand,” he whispered.

Something cold curled beneath Mydei’s ribs, pressing against something he did not have words for.

Phainon sighed, amused, as if the answer was obvious.

“As expected.”

A tremor clawed up Mydei’s spine, the kind he couldn’t suppress, the kind that festered in his bones and made his breath turn shallow, hollow. He fought to keep his expression blank, to steady the unrelenting storm pounding against the walls of his mind, but it was caving in, suffocating, inevitable.

He needed answers. *Now*.

His voice came sharp. “Then explain.”

Phainon tilted his head, considering. A flicker of amusement passed through his violet eyes, distant, wrong, like this was all some harmless jest. “Where should I start?”

Mydei’s fingers curled into his palms, blunt nails biting into flesh. *Don’t react. Don’t give him anything.*

Phainon exhaled, almost absentmindedly. “Well, the Coreflame—that was something extra. I added that myself.”

The words twisted through Mydei’s skull like a parasite.

They didn’t make sense. They didn’t *fit*. His mind tried to parse them, to *understand*, but all it found was a wall of static, blank and deafening.

Something cold sank into his stomach, sharp as a blade.

He was on his feet before he realized he’d moved. The room swayed, the edges warping, but he didn’t stop. His body still felt like it wasn’t his own, but his grip was *his*, his fingers *his* as they twisted into Phainon’s collar and *slammed* him into the nearest wall.

The impact sent a crack through the air.

Phainon’s head tipped back slightly. That was all. Like he’d barely noticed.

Mydei’s breath came ragged. His pulse pounded against his ribs, a hammering, erratic thing. His arms shook with something he refused to name.

“What the fuck does that mean?” His voice was low, guttural, like something had crawled into his throat and made a home there.

Phainon blinked, as if the question was trivial. “The rest, I made sure to do your way.”

A sick, wrenching sensation curled through Mydei’s stomach.

Phainon's hands lifted, fingers ghosting over Mydei's grip—*not prying, not struggling,* just fixing the fabric, like he was the one who'd been inconvenienced.

"You see," he continued, unshaken, "I know your people used to offer a sacrifice to the gods before marriage."

Mydei couldn't breathe.

The words dug their way beneath his skin, carving themselves into every nerve, until he could see it again—the bodies, the slaughter, the blood that painted the streets in rivers.

Phainon smiled. "Unfortunately, there aren't many gods left." A conversational lilt. A joke. "So I modified that a little."

Something inside Mydei *split.*

His grip loosened. Phainon stepped away, brushing nonexistent dust from his collar.

"And, if I recall correctly," Phainon mused, "they also captured their partner and kept them secluded somewhere, right?"

The world tilted.

Phainon chuckled. "I did that part too. But I changed a few things." He leaned in slightly, his voice dropping to something quieter, something *intimate*. "Leaving after the night is over? I don't like that part."

A black hole yawned open inside Mydei's chest, vast and endless.

The realization hit, not as a thought, but as a physical thing, crawling under his skin, latching onto his spine with hooked, writhing fingers.

His legs folded beneath him. He couldn't stop them.

He didn't even feel himself falling.

But before the floor could meet him, something warm caught his waist, something solid, steady.

Phainon.

His touch was gentle. Careful. Like he was holding something fragile.

His breath ghosted against Mydei's ear, his voice soft, *sincere*.

"So," he murmured, "next is consummation, right?"

Mydei didn't move.

He couldn't.

His mind refused to process it—the words still ringing in his skull, the weight of Phainon's voice pressing down on him like hands around his throat. The air was wrong, thick and suffocating, his own body failing him as his limbs refused to obey.

Phainon was still holding him.

That warm, steady arm around his waist, keeping him upright as if he were something fragile, something to be *cherished*. Phainon leaned in, the tip of his nose brushing against Mydei's temple, inhaling deeply like he was drinking him in.

"So tense," his voice was dripping with something between amusement and indulgence. "Relax, Mydei." A soft sigh, almost as if he were fond. "There's nothing to be afraid of anymore."

That snapped something in him.

A raw, burning surge of instinct clawed its way up from the depths of Mydei's being, overriding the numbness. He *moved*, shoving against Phainon's chest with all the strength he could muster, trying to wrench himself free from that suffocating embrace.

"No." His voice was sharp, ragged. Desperate. "No—get away from me."

Phainon’s hold didn’t loosen.

If anything, it *tightened.*

The pressure around his waist became unrelenting, arms coiling like iron bars, keeping him firmly in place. Mydei barely sucked in a breath before he felt it—the way Phainon’s body tensed, his chest rising slow with a long, measured inhale.

Then, silence.

A few unbearable seconds of nothing.

Then—

“…Damn brat.”

The words were quiet. Too quiet.

Then pain.

A slow, excruciating *crush* as Phainon’s arms around him possessively with a force that sent lightning bolts of agony through his ribs. The breath was forced from his lungs, a sharp gasp torn from his throat as his spine bent under the pressure.

Phainon was still smiling.

But it was different now.

Colder. Calculated.

The warmth was gone, the tenderness vanished like an illusion stripped away, revealing something sharp and pitiless beneath.

“You’re making things so *difficult*.” His voice was still smooth, still carrying that deceptive lilt of patience, but there was something else threaded underneath it now—something dangerous. “Haven’t you *learned* by now?”

His grip tightened.

A small sound broke from Mydei's throat before he could stop it. His fingers clawed weakly at Phainon's arm, body twisting against the crushing hold, but it was useless.

Phainon exhaled through his nose, like a teacher disappointed in an unruly student.

"Struggling isn't going to change anything." He dipped his head, lips barely grazing Mydei's ear as he whispered, "You're *mine*, Mydei." Another pulse of unbearable pressure, making stars explode behind his vision. "And I always take care of what's mine."

His grip didn't loosen.

Not even a little.

Mydei barely registered the way his back hit the bed, the impact stealing what little breath he had left. His arms were wrenched above his head, forced together in a single, crushing grip—Phainon's fingers locking around his wrists like shackles of flesh and bone.

He bucked, twisting, trying to throw his weight to the side, but Phainon didn't budge.

Didn't strain.

Didn't struggle.

It was like wrestling against a mountain, immovable and unyielding, the difference in strength as stark as reality crashing down around him.

A sharp gasp tore from his throat as Phainon moved, shifting his weight, one hand leaving Mydei's wrists only for something far worse—

His leg.

Phainon grabbed his thigh, forcing it up, throwing it over his own shoulder with a grip that *dug* into muscle, keeping it *down*. Mydei's body twisted on instinct, but the pin was perfect—his limbs were trapped, caged, his struggles reduced to useless, writhing motions beneath the weight pressing into him.

His breath came ragged, teeth clenched as he sucked in air, heart pounding against the walls of his ribs.

Phainon's expression was unreadable.

No more warmth. No more pretense.

Just an unwavering, *calm* control—an inevitability made flesh.

One of his thumbs stroked idle circles against Mydei's wrist, mockingly gentle.

"Still fighting?" A soft, almost amused hum. "Even now?"

He tilted his head, watching as Mydei's chest rose and fell with each shallow breath, eyes dark with something like *fascination*.

"You never know when to stop."

Mydei couldn't move. Not even an inch.

His body moved involuntarily, a raw, involuntary reaction to the sheer force holding him down. But Phainon didn't let up, only shifted to press closer, breath warm against Mydei's cheek as he said—

"You're just making this more fun for me."

Phainon doesn't rush. That would ruin it.

Instead, he takes his time—deliberate, methodical—as he peels away Mydei's clothes, layer by layer. Each movement is precise, his fingers skimming too lightly over exposed skin, never lingering long enough to give warmth or comfort.

He knows Mydei hates this. Hates the slowness, the inevitability of it. So, of course, he draws it out.

His fingers trail down Mydei's arms before unfastening the first piece of clothing, nails grazing along bare skin like an afterthought. The fabric slips away, cool air brushing against Mydei's collarbone as Phainon hums, pleased.

"You always liked things done properly, didn't you?" Phainon murmurs, voice warm, almost fond. His hands smooth over Mydei's shoulders, thumbs pressing in just enough to feel the tension coiled beneath. "Then let's not ruin the moment."

The worst part is that Phainon doesn't hold him down anymore. He doesn't need to. Mydei's breathing is controlled, measured, but his body betrays him—a single, fleeting hesitation before he jerks away.

Phainon lets him. For a second.

Then, just as Mydei shifts to rise, Phainon's hand lands lightly on his wrist, fingers curling—not a hard grip, just a reminder.

A test.

A taunt.

Mydei stills.

Phainon smiles, slow and knowing. "There it is."

The next layer comes undone.

Mydei jerks back, sharp and immediate, but Phainon doesn't react—not at first. He lets him move, lets him fight, lets him *think* he still has some control.

Then, just as Mydei shifts to push him away, Phainon intercepts effortlessly, his grip tightening just enough to keep him still. Not painful, not forceful—just certain.

“Go ahead,” Phainon said, amused. “Keep fighting. If that makes you feel better.”

The struggle is useless. They both know it.

Fabric slips away, trailing over Mydei’s skin in a slow, almost mocking caress. He stiffens, jaw clenched, but Phainon drinks in the sight—eyes tracing over every inch of freshly bared skin, savoring the tension rippling beneath.

“Look at you,” Phainon hums, fingers brushing along Mydei’s collarbone, light as a whisper. “You act like this isn’t familiar.”

Phainon moves like this is routine—as if he’s just preparing for bed while he strips himself, unbothered, unaffected. Unlike Mydei.

Mydei sits motionless, gaze fixed to the side, his breathing sharp and uneven.

Phainon doesn’t allow it.

A firm grip tilts Mydei’s chin up, forcing their eyes to meet. The touch isn’t rough—just unyielding. Just enough to remind Mydei who’s in control here.

“Don’t look away,” Phainon says, low and quiet, but there’s something dark underneath. “If you can glare at me like that, you can watch, too.”

His fingers drag over Mydei’s wrists, collecting every twitch, every flinch, before finally forcing them together above his head. A single hand holds them there, the other tracing lower—down Mydei’s arm, along his ribs, following the curve of his hip.

“Stay still,” Phainon mouthed, voice warm, almost fond. “I’d hate to ruin you before we even begin.”

The sharp inhale Mydei takes is not fear.

But Phainon hears it anyway. Savors it.

His fingers move lower. Testing. Feeling. Pressing just enough to make Mydei stiffen.

“Relax,” Phainon coaxes, lips just barely brushing his ear. He presses inside, the first slow intrusion stealing the breath from Mydei’s lungs. “You wouldn’t want this to hurt, would you?”

A cruel mockery of concern.

Mydei clenches his jaw. He refuses to react, refuses to let Phainon have this.

But Phainon is patient. So patient.

He moves slowly, deliberate in every touch, stretching Mydei open with calculated precision. A second finger joins the first, scissoring, coaxing, the slick, obscene sound filling the space between them.

“You take it so well,” Phainon muses, watching every flicker of tension, every minute betrayal of Mydei’s body.

Mydei’s breaths turn shallow. He tries to turn his face away, but Phainon’s hand is already there, catching his chin in a firm, unyielding grip.

“Don’t look away.” Phainon’s voice dips lower, an unspoken order laced in the softness. He strokes deliberately against that spot inside Mydei that makes his body tense against his will. “I want to see everything.”

And Mydei knows—knows he won’t stop. Knows he’ll drag this out until there’s nothing left to fight.

Knows he’s already lost.

Phainon works slowly as he marks Mydei’s neck—not rushed, not mindless, but precise. Each graze of his teeth is deliberate, a lingering press before he bites down, sucking deep bruises into Mydei’s skin.

A reminder. A claim. A punishment.

“You never did thank me,” Phainon murmurs against his throat, voice low, almost thoughtful. His fingers don’t stop moving—pushing deeper, stretching Mydei open with cruel intent. “For what, you ask?”

He laughs softly, pressing his lips to a fresh bruise. “For saving you, of course.”

Mydei tenses immediately—because he already knows this isn’t about him.

“Ifigenia,” Phainon purrs, fingers spreading wider, forcing Mydei to feel every inch of it. “She saved you once, didn’t she? Pulled you from the water. Gave you breath.”

The way he says it—gave you breath—is a cruel imitation of reverence. Mocking. Worshipful. Twisted.

“Do you want to know how it felt, watching the light go out of her eyes?”

Mydei turns his head away.

Phainon’s fingers press deeper, rougher, pushing him open until it burns.

“Ah.” Phainon grins against his throat, tongue flicking over a fresh bruise before he bites down again—harsher, sharper, enough to make Mydei flinch. “Still ignoring me?”

He drags his lips lower, sinking his teeth in just beneath Mydei’s collarbone, sucking deep, possessive marks into his skin. His fingers twist inside him, stretching without care, without patience.

“Every time you refused me, every time you turned away—” His voice drops to a whisper, dark and sweet. “You feel it now, don’t you?”

He doesn’t wait for a response.

“I told Ifigenia about you before she died,” Phainon continues, slowly dragging his tongue over the marks he’s left. “How lucky she was to have touched you first. To have had your lips before I did.”

Mydei’s breath hitches.

Phainon hums, satisfied.

“You should’ve seen her face when she realized what I meant.”

A pause, just long enough for it to sink in.

Then, a sharp, deliberate twist of his fingers, pulling a shudder from Mydei before he can stop it.

“And the refugees?” Phainon’s voice turns thoughtful, almost dreamy. “The way they burned… I wonder, did they scream for you?”

Mydei’s entire body locks up, but Phainon’s grip keeps him right where he wants him.

“You never looked at me when I did all that for you,” Phainon’s breath was warm against Mydei’s bruised skin. His hand moves lower, pressing possessively against his abdomen. “So you’ll look at me now.”

The defiance in Mydei’s eyes doesn’t fade. Even now.

Phainon can feel it in every inch of him—the rigid set of his shoulders, the way he keeps his head turned, refusing to break, refusing to acknowledge him.

It’s infuriating maddening.

Phainon’s fingers dig into bare, flushed skin, pressing deep enough to leave crescent-shaped imprints against Mydei’s waist. He leans in, lips brushing against Mydei’s temple—mocking intimacy, a cruel ghost of something softer.

“Look at me.”

Silence.

Phainon’s hand slides lower, skimming over the bruises he’s already left, fingers ghosting over raw, marked skin. He lets his lips graze Mydei’s jaw, teeth scraping—but not yet biting.

“I said—look at me.”

Nothing.

Mydei keeps his head turned, breath too controlled, too even, like he’s bracing himself. Like he’s still pretending he has a choice.

Phainon snaps.

“Fine.”

A rough jerk—his hands lock around Mydei’s waist, wrenching him forward, forcing him down onto his elbows as he’s flipped onto his stomach.

A sharp exhale—Mydei’s breath punches out from the sudden movement, but Phainon doesn’t give him time to recover.

He forces his knees apart, dragging him into position—face down, hips lifted, fully open to him. Exposed. Vulnerable. Trapped.

A hand presses down between his shoulder blades, pinning him there. His other grips hard at Mydei’s hip—possessive, unrelenting, demanding.

“You don’t want to see me?” Phainon’s voice is low, dangerous. Not a question.

His hips press forward, grinding against him, making sure Mydei feels the inevitable.

“Then I’ll make sure you don’t forget how I feel instead.”

The first push is rough, deliberate— forcing Mydei to take him without space to fight.

His hips snap forward, a brutal pace from the start, dragging Mydei further into the mattress with every thrust.

Mydei claws at the sheets, fingers twisting into the fabric as his body jerks forward, forced to take it, forced to feel every inch of Phainon inside him.

Phainon presses down harder, hand firm between Mydei's shoulder blades, keeping him face-down, ass-up, exactly where he wants him.

His grip is bruising, fingers digging into Mydei's hip as he pulls him back into every thrust, taking what's his.

"You belong to me, Mydei." His voice drops to a whisper, breathless, full of something far too dark to be love.

The sound of skin meeting skin fills the space between them, every movement driving Mydei deeper into the sheets.

"You always had so much to say," Phainon murmurs, fingers sliding up Mydei's throat, pressing just enough to steal the next breath.

"Where is it now?"

The sudden shift drives Mydei forward, his face pressing into the sheets, muffling his breath.

He refuses to make a sound. Refuses to give Phainon the satisfaction.

Phainon can feel the tension, the effort it takes for Mydei to hold it in—the way his body trembles beneath him, muscles locked tight, trying so desperately not to react.

It's entertaining.

"Still pretending, Mydei?" Phainon muses, fingers trailing lazily down the length of his spine, tracing every mark left behind.

No response.

Not until Phainon pulls out almost entirely—only to slam back inside, deep, deliberate, forcing a sharp, ragged breath from Mydei's lips.

A breath that almost turns into a sound.

"Damn you," Mydei grits out, his voice taut, biting, desperate to sound unaffected.

Phainon laughs.

Low, quiet, mocking.

"Oh, Mydei." He presses a hand against the back of Mydei's neck, forcing him deeper into the sheets, his grip loose but firm, fingers playing at the edges of control.

"You're adorable when you think you still have a choice."

His other hand slides forward, between Mydei's thighs, finding him hard, the evidence of his body betraying him.

Phainon hums in satisfaction.

"Look at that," he muses, his fingers stroking too lightly, too teasingly, not giving him enough. "I haven't even started playing with you yet."

A sharp inhale, Mydei's fingers clawing deeper into the fabric beneath him, a helpless reaction he can't stop.

Phainon takes his time.

Slow touches, feather-light strokes meant to frustrate rather than satisfy. Never enough to let Mydei fall over the edge—only enough to keep him on it.

"I could keep you like this for hours." A smirk, his voice soft, mocking amusement as he feels Mydei's body twitch in response.

He presses deeper, thrusts slow and precise now, forcing Mydei to feel every inch of him, dragging out every second of this.

“What’s wrong?” Phainon murmurs, leaning down, his breath hot against Mydei’s ear. “You wanted to be silent, didn’t you?”

He tightens his grip, strokes him just right—just enough to make Mydei’s hips stutter forward before he can stop himself.

Phainon grins.

“Ah. There it is.”

Phainon doesn’t stop.

Even when Mydei shudders beneath him, even when his body tenses, then breaks, his release spilling between them, staining the sheets beneath him—Phainon doesn’t stop.

If anything, he enjoys it more.

“So sensitive already?” His voice is light, almost teasing, but there’s something darker beneath it, something cruel.

He grinds in deeper, relishing the sharp, involuntary twitch of Mydei’s overstimulated body.

A sharp gasp—half a strangled sound, half a curse—before Mydei bites it back, trying to bury his face in the sheets again.

Phainon doesn’t allow it.

He drags Mydei up by the hair, just enough to expose his neck again, his cheek pressing against the mattress instead.

“No use hiding now.” He drives forward again, hard enough to make Mydei’s fingers dig into the sheets, a fresh tremor racking through him.

Too much. Too soon.

And Phainon? He just chuckles.

“Look at you. A mess, just for me.”

He lets his hands roam, one still gripping Mydei’s hip, the other sliding upward, tracing the curve of his spine before dipping lower.

Then, further up.

Mydei stiffens when fingertips ghost over his chest, barely there at first—a featherlight tease that quickly turns into something more when Phainon rolls a nipple between his fingers.

A small, barely audible inhale.

Phainon hums, amused. Catching that reaction like a predator catching scent of blood.

“Sensitive here too, hmm?”

A sharp tweak—not enough to truly hurt, but enough to make Mydei’s hips jolt forward involuntarily, his body betraying him again.

“Fuck you,” Mydei hisses through gritted teeth, his voice frayed, weak but stubborn.

Phainon laughs.

“You already are, sweetheart.”

He tugs again, harder this time, then palms over Mydei’s chest, feeling the way his body shudders beneath the overstimulation, his muscles twitching helplessly.

“So perfect for me.” His voice lowers, a breathy murmur, full of satisfaction. Like Mydei is nothing but a prize, a possession he’s finally taken in full.

And he’s not done.

“You’re mine, Mydei. To use. To ruin. To break apart piece by piece.”

Phainon thrusts in again, harder, deeper—chasing his own pleasure now, using Mydei’s body however he pleases.

And Mydei?

He can only take it.

Phainon notices it before Mydei does.

The subtle shake in his breath. The way his fingers, still curled weakly into the sheets, start to tremble.

Then, a drop.

Warm. Trailing down Mydei’s cheek before falling soundlessly onto the mattress below.

Another follows.

And then another.

Phainon stills.

For the first time, his movements slow, no longer chasing his own pleasure—just watching.

Watching as Mydei shudders beneath him, silent but breaking, as if the weight of everything—the past, the present, the inevitability of what’s to come—has finally crushed him.

Tears.

Phainon hadn’t expected tears.

His grip eases, fingers brushing against Mydei’s flushed, tear-streaked face—not wiping them away, just feeling the wetness against his fingertips, taking in the reality of Mydei’s unraveling.

And then, with a gentleness so at odds with everything before—he takes Mydei's hand.

Presses a kiss to his knuckles.

Soft. Reverent. Like an offering, as if this isn't the same hand that had fought against him, had tried to push him away.

As if Mydei isn't fucking terrified of him.

Phainon doesn't let go. Instead, he guides Mydei's hand to his own cheek, pressing it there, letting Mydei feel the warmth of his skin, the slow, steady breath he takes.

His gaze is too tender, too full of something unspoken, something twisted in its affection.

A moment of quiet.

The sounds of their bodies colliding, of skin against skin, have long faded, replaced by nothing but the sound of their breathing.

Mydei stares at him.

At everything Phainon has done. Everything he's taken. Everything he's reduced him to.

And in the end, resignation sinks in.

He knows Phainon won't stop. He never has.

So why is he still pretending to fight?

His fingers twitch against Phainon's cheek, but he doesn't pull away.

He lets him hold him.

And then, a thought—quiet, damning—slips past his lips.

“Is this so bad?”

It doesn’t even sound like a real question.

Just the last remnants of defiance giving way to something far, far worse.

Phainon’s touch is different now.

Gone is the cruelty, the bruising grip, the sharp edge of punishment. Now, his hands trace Mydei’s skin like something sacred, something he’s been desperate to claim but unwilling to break.

Soft thrusts now, deep but unhurried, each roll of his hips measured, drawn out—as if savoring the moment.

As if this is the true consummation of their marriage.

His lips finally meet Mydei’s.

Not forceful. Not demanding.

Soft.

And that’s the worst part.

Because Mydei feels it now.

Every inch of his body betrays him, arching into Phainon’s touch, shivering at every precise stroke, every lingering kiss.

Phainon’s mouth moves slowly, pulling him under, drowning him in sensation.

His name—Mydei’s name—is whispered between kisses, each syllable laced with reverence, like a prayer.

Phainon had taken everything from him.

And now he’s worshipping him.

Mydei doesn’t know which is worse.

The way Phainon makes him feel good, so unbearably good that resistance becomes impossible—

Or the words he speaks next.

“I didn’t do all of this just for no reason.”

The confession slips out casually, effortlessly, like it’s not the weight of a thousand sins spilling from his lips.

Phainon doesn’t stop moving. Doesn’t stop fucking him.

“At first, it was noble.” He drags his hands over Mydei’s chest, thumb grazing a hardened nipple, delighting in the shudder it pulls from him.

“I wanted to save Okhema. Restore everything we lost.”

Mydei stiffens. The coreflames. The ritual.

Phainon hums, kissing his jaw, his neck, the bruises he’d left behind.

“If one coreflame makes you a demi-god,” he murmurs, hips pressing deeper, rolling in a way that leaves Mydei gasping, clutching at Phainon’s shoulders without thinking.

“Wouldn’t twelve make you a god?”

It sounds insane.

But Mydei knows he’s not lying.

Phainon had believed it. Had sought it. Had torn the world apart for it.

“I was going to become a god and fix everything.” Phainon’s fingers lace through Mydei’s, pressing their hands together above his head.

“But then…”

His breath brushes against Mydei’s lips, his voice turning softer, darker.

“I realized something.”

He thrusts deeper, slow but devastating, dragging Mydei through unbearable pleasure as his voice drops to a whisper.

“I didn’t want to save Okhema anymore.”

Mydei’s breath hitches.

Phainon smiles against his skin. Presses another soft, lingering kiss to his parted lips.

“I wanted you.”

The words shatter him.

Because Phainon isn’t done.

“And I wanted to see the world burn.”

Mydei barely has the strength to speak.

His body aches with overstimulation, with exhaustion, but his mind is heavier.

“You…” His voice is hoarse, worn down by everything Phainon has put him through. “You were going to become a god… and you—” A sharp inhale, his body jolting as Phainon rolls his hips deeper, perfectly measured.

”—you gave that up… for me?”

Phainon laughs. A pleased, quiet chuckle that rumbles through his chest, through Mydei, sinking under his skin.

“Does that surprise you?”

Mydei wants to fight back.

Wants to call him insane, to spit something cruel.

But all that leaves him is a tired breath. His fingers twitch against Phainon's hand, still pinned above his head.

He feels Phainon looking at him.

A hum, thoughtful, almost doting. Then, gentle fingers brush Mydei's sweat-damp hair from his face.

"You know," Phainon muses, voice warm with amusement, with something dangerously close to affection. "So far, you've only questioned and cursed at me."

His thumb trails over Mydei's cheek, slow, unhurried.

"Shouldn't you be making some other noises by now?"

The next thrust is deliberate—

And Mydei can't stop the sound that finally escapes his throat.

Phainon continues his pace, specifically designed to pull another sound from Mydei's lips—one that Phainon is determined to hear.

Phainon leans down, lips grazing Mydei's ear, his voice low, seductive. "Come on, Mydei… don't hold back." His fingers tug lightly at Mydei's chin, ensuring that his face is always exposed, making sure the other man doesn't have the option to hide or look away.

Mydei's breath catches.

His hips jerk back into Phainon, unwillingly, but that soft gasp, that whimper, breaks free and Phainon immediately rewards it.

"There you go," Phainon said, voice filled with approval, the warmth of his breath heavy against Mydei's skin. "You make such beautiful noises. Why hide them?"

Mydei tries to bite down on his lip, but Phainon's fingers brush his hand away, catching his jaw instead.

"No, Mydei," he admonishes, tone playful but harsh. "No covering up. I want to hear every bit of you."

Mydei's eyes are wide, empty, staring straight ahead, but inside, a flicker of something is breaking. Something tender, fragile, just waiting to shatter under the weight of what Phainon is doing to him.

Phainon's pace picks up, each movement firm and relentless, coaxing out noise after noise from Mydei as he loses all control.

Mydei's hand grips the sheets, knuckles pale, but he doesn't fight anymore. There's no fight left in him. His body is betraying him, and his mind is numb, overwhelmed by the feeling of Phainon inside him, by the constant motion, the constant pressure.

The last shred of resistance snaps.

There's no escape.

Mydei has already given everything—his body, his trust, his heart. Phainon owns it all. Every breath, every whimper, every silent plea that had stayed buried is now out in the open, vulnerable, raw.

He understands now—there is nowhere left to run.

And Phainon, with a satisfied smile, knows it too.

Chapter End Notes

> And finally done with this series! This by far has been my longest, and most inconsistent to update but I'm grateful to anyone who stuck around <333

Sorry abt the pacing that was also a bit funky since this chapter was meant to go with chapter 6 originally, and I honestly forgot how I wanted it to end😭 ♀

At some point I’m definitely gonna redo obsessive Phainon though because I feel I dragged this on and made it too wordy, so if I do would you guys prefer sm like this fic’s plot but reworked to have shorter more detailed sentences, or somethig entirely different?

But anyway, to anyone who got this far and has the patience to read all of this, thanks again and have a wonderful rest of your day

End Notes

Finally done! Originally I wanted to write like 30k for this but after some consultations I decided not to and that I'll split it into 2-3 chapters or more.

Please, PLEASE tell me how you guys think of this so far, and what parts I can improve or add onto.

I'm really proud of this, genuinely because I don't usually write this much, but it is a bit saddening I don't have anyone to tell me what I'm doing wrong as I'm treading into new territory😭

Anyway, thank you for reading and please stick around for more <3

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!